

The Architecture of *Grace*

Book 3 · The Interior

*A Complete Year-Long SEL Curriculum in Forgiveness, Grace, and
Self-Compassion*

GRADES 6 · 7 · 8 · TEACHER MASTER EDITION

SECULAR · RESEARCH-GROUNDED · TRAUMA-INFORMED · CASEL-ALIGNED

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BOOK THREE

Architecture of Grace

The Interior

Teacher Master Edition

Secular · Research-Grounded · Trauma-Informed · CASEL-Aligned
Tier 1 Universal SEL · 28 Lessons across 4 Units

CONFIDENTIAL · FOR DISTRICT REVIEW AND EDUCATOR USE ONLY

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SECTION ONE

Teacher Launch Pack

Daily-Use Materials · Read Before Lesson 1

1.1 How to Use This Master Document

This document is your single source of truth for delivering Architecture of Grace, Book 3: The Interior to Grades 6–8. Everything you need — lesson scripts, worksheets, safety protocols, assessment tools, reference materials, and printable visual anchor charts — is in one place, organized so that the materials you use daily are at the front, and the materials you reference occasionally are at the back.

WHAT IS IN EVERY LESSON

Opening Review — a 2-minute structured bridge from the previous lesson activating prior knowledge.

Direct Instruction — scripted instructional sequence with timed steps. Embedded after the Opening Review.

Anchor Charts — described at each lesson. Draw on chart paper before class. Post on the day indicated. Keep posted all year.

Scenario Cards — one or two per lesson, embedded directly where they are used.

Worksheets — embedded at the end of the lesson where distributed. Reproducible for students. Never collected unless student chooses.

Exit Ticket & Teacher Reflection — closing formative check and private teacher prompt at every lesson.

In-Lesson Scan — embedded inline at the precise activity where observation matters. Watch for specific student behaviors. Note privately.

Safety Check — appears before every elevated and highest-risk lesson. Complete before delivering the lesson.

GRADE-BAND NOTE · GRADES 6–8

The Interior does not use physical props. The 3–5 Heavy Backpack has no equivalent here — this is a deliberate design decision. Adolescents engage with abstract concepts directly. The 6–8 curriculum operates through a layered metaphor system: The Mask vs. the Mirror (Unit 1), The Internal Critic / Compassionate Witness (Unit 2), The Digital Backpack (U1 L3), The Letter of Release (U3 L6), and The Grace Gap (Unit 4). These metaphors live on anchor charts and in student journals. Every lesson begins with a predictable opening ritual — 2–4 minutes of grounding before any instruction. **This ritual is not optional.** It is the threshold between the social world of school and the interior work of this class.

1.2 Color & Icon Key

Each visual cue in this curriculum has a consistent meaning. Read this key once and return to it as needed.

Opening Review	TEAL	2-minute structured bridge activating prior knowledge from the last lesson.
Direct Instruction	TEAL	Scripted step-by-step instructional sequence with timed steps. Placed after Opening Review.
Anchor Chart	TEAL	Described at each lesson. Draw on chart paper or display before class. Keep posted all year.
Scenario Cards	PURPLE	Embedded at point of use. One or two per lesson. Print and laminate before Unit 1.
Worksheet	GOLD	Reproducible student worksheet, embedded at end of distributing lesson. Never collected unless student chooses.
Exit Ticket & Teacher Reflection	GREEN	Closing formative check and private teacher prompt. Every lesson.
In-Lesson Scan	AMBER	Placed inline at the specific activity it monitors. Watch for named behaviors. Note privately. Do not intervene publicly.
Safety Check	RED	Pre-lesson checklist. Complete before delivering any risk-flagged lesson. Non-negotiable.
★★ HIGHEST RISK	RED BANNER	Counselor must be physically on-site the full lesson. No exceptions. No substitutes.
★ HIGH / ELEVATED RISK	AMBER BANNER	Counselor on-site or co-facilitating. Minimum one week advance notice. No pre-break scheduling.
PPRA-Designated	PURPLE NOTE	Parental notification required. All standard opt-out protocols apply. See Section 4, Legal & Clinical Compliance.
Equity Alert	GREEN ALERT	Explicit equity content required. Deliver the flagged script directly and specifically — not as a footnote. Not optional.

1.3 Safety Protocols — Quick Reference

Read before Lesson 1. Return before every risk-flagged lesson.

★★ HIGHEST RISK · COUNSELOR PHYSICALLY ON-SITE, FULL LESSON · NO EXCEPTIONS

U2 L6 · Rewriting the Script U3 L6 · The Agency of Release — Letter of Release

★ HIGH / ELEVATED RISK · COUNSELOR ON-SITE OR CO-FACILITATING

U3 L3 · Forgiveness vs. Reconciliation — Counselor on-site **U4 L6** · Grace Audit — Final Project — Counselor on standby **U4 L7** · Community Charter & Year-End Celebration — Counselor on standby

DISCLOSURE PROTOCOL · APPLIES TO ALL LESSONS

1. Stop the lesson immediately. 2. Activate your school's mandatory disclosure protocol. 3. Contact the counselor now — not after class. Not after the lesson. Now. **4. Do not leave the student alone.** 5. Do not attempt to assess risk yourself. 6. Document in writing the same day. See **Section 4** — Legal & Clinical Compliance · Student Disclosure Protocol (Types 1–4) for the complete protocol.

CRISIS RESOURCES · POST BEFORE U2 L6 · KEEP POSTED THROUGH YEAR-END

988 Suicide & Crisis Lifeline · Call or text **988 Crisis Text Line** · Text **HOME** to **741741**

1.4 Year-at-a-Glance Pacing Calendar

IDENTITY WEIGHT OF PERCEPTION SEPTEMBER — OCTOBER	THE SELF- COMPASSION THE INTERNAL CRITIC NOVEMBER — DECEMBER	EMPATHY FORGIVING OTHERS JANUARY — MARCH	GRACE GENEROSITY APRIL — JUNE
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ASSESSMENT TIMING

Pre-Assessment: Administer Instrument C in the first week of the year — before Unit 1 Lesson 1. **Post-Assessment:** Administer after Unit 4 Lesson 7. **Family Surveys:** Distribute Instrument G at the end of Unit 2 (mid-year) and end of Unit 4 (year-end).

1.5 Counselor Coordination — Scheduling Summary

BLOCK THESE DATES ON THE COUNSELOR'S CALENDAR BEFORE UNIT 1 LESSON 1 IS DELIVERED. NO EXCEPTIONS.

U1 L2 — The Anatomy of a Mistake	PPRA	Counselor briefed. Awareness only — no co-facilitation required.	Brief before delivery
U2 L1 — The Internal Critic	PPRA	Counselor briefed. Awareness only — no co-facilitation required.	Brief before delivery
U2 L6 — Rewriting the Script	★★ HIGHEST	ON-SITE · Co-facilitates full lesson · No exceptions	No pre-break · No sub · Crisis resources posted
U3 L3 — Forgiveness vs. Reconciliation	★ HIGH	ON-SITE or immediately available, full lesson	No pre-break · No sub
U3 L6 — The Agency of Release	★★ HIGHEST	ON-SITE · Full lesson · Same-day debrief required	No pre-break · No sub · Counselor in room entire time
U4 L6 — Grace Audit Final Project	★ ELEVATED	On standby — reachable and available same day	Mon–Wed preferred
U4 L7 — Community Charter & Year-End	★ ELEVATED	On standby — reachable and available same day	Not last day of year

STANDING COORDINATION REQUIREMENTS

Before Unit 1 Lesson 1: Counselor attends PD day. Disclosure protocol reviewed. Communication channel established. Calendar blocked. **Before Unit 3 Lesson 1:** Counselor and teacher review Unit 2 bridge exit tickets. Identify students entering Unit 3 with highest emotional load. **January mid-year:** Virtual coaching session — counselor attends. Delivers debrief on student wellbeing patterns across Semester 1. **After Unit 4 Lesson 7:** Counselor and teacher year-end debrief. Review post-assessment data. Identify students who may benefit from continued counselor contact.

1.6 Year-Start Student Introduction Script

Use on the first day of **Unit 1 Lesson 1** — before distributing any materials. Read it aloud or say it in your own voice. Do not skip it.

"Think about the last time you walked into a social situation and consciously thought about how you were coming across. What were you managing? What were you hiding?" "Once a week, for about 40 minutes, we are going to work on the inside of your life — not your grades, but the part of you that decides how you treat yourself when things go wrong, and how you treat other people when they hurt you." "This is not a class where you will be graded on your feelings. Your journal is private — I will never read it without your permission. You will never be forced to share more than you choose. And nothing you say in this room gets repeated outside of it." "There are three things I want you to know before we begin: You are more than your worst moment. Every feeling in this room is information — not a weakness. And what you do with the inside of your life is one of the most important things you will ever work on."

After this opening — proceed directly into **Unit 1 Lesson 1**. The opening ritual follows immediately. Students will understand what this class is by experiencing it — not by being told about it.

1.7 Classroom Compact Guide

Co-create with students at the end of **Unit 1 Lesson 1**. Post permanently — this is the relational contract for the full year.

WHY CO-CREATION MATTERS AT MIDDLE SCHOOL

Adolescents are exquisitely sensitive to authenticity. A list of norms the teacher has already written communicates that this is something done to them, not with them. Students who feel the compact was imposed are less likely to hold each other to it and less likely to take emotional risks inside it. When students write it themselves — they own it. When they sign it, they have made a public commitment in front of their peers. That is a fundamentally different kind of accountability.

PROTOCOL • FOUR STEPS

Step 1 • Frame it before you start (2–3 min): Say: "Before we do any of the work in this curriculum, we need to build the room it happens in — the social room. The kind of space where you can say something real without it being used against you. That doesn't happen automatically. It happens because we build it together."

Step 2 • Generate (5–7 min): Students call out what they need. Write it on the board exactly as they say it — not edited, not paraphrased. Take everything.

Step 3 • Refine (3–5 min): Read the full list back. Ask: "Is anything missing? Is anything on here that shouldn't be?" Aim for 5–8 clear norms.

Step 4 • The Signing Ritual (3–4 min): Write or print the final compact cleanly. Every student signs it. You sign it last.

FOUR AGREEMENTS THAT MUST ALWAYS BE INCLUDED

1. WHAT IS SHARED HERE STAYS HERE.
2. YOU NEVER HAVE TO SHARE MORE THAN YOU CHOOSE.
3. EVERY FEELING IN THIS ROOM IS INFORMATION — NOT A WEAKNESS.
4. THE COMPASSIONATE WITNESS STANDARD APPLIES TO HOW WE SPEAK TO EACH OTHER.

Ask students: “What else do you need this space to feel like to be honest here?” Write responses on chart paper. Add any student-generated agreements to the four above. Post the final compact permanently where every student can see it — and where every student can see their own signature.

AFTER DAY 1 · USING THE COMPACT ALL YEAR

At the start of high-risk lessons: “Before we begin today — take a look at the compact. Your signature is still there. So is mine.” **After a lesson where something real was shared:** “What this room just held is exactly what the compact is for. Thank you for keeping it.” **When a norm is broken:** Move quietly to the student involved. Do not make it a public event. “Let’s talk after class.”

SECTION TWO

The Lessons

28 Lessons · 4 Units · 35–50 minutes each

UNIT 1 · IDENTITY & THE WEIGHT OF PERCEPTION

UNIT 2 · SELF-COMPASSION & THE INTERNAL CRITIC

UNIT 3 · EMPATHY & FORGIVING OTHERS

UNIT 4 · GRACE & GENEROSITY

UNIT 1

Identity & The Weight of Perception

“Who defines me — my mistakes, my social circle, or my character?”

SEPTEMBER – OCTOBER · 7 LESSONS · 35-40 MIN EACH

The Mask vs. The Mirror

35–40 min · September Week 1

OBJECTIVE	Students distinguish between the persona they project socially (Mask) and their authentic self (Mirror), and identify at least two gaps using the Identity Audit.
CASEL FOCUS	Self-Awareness · accurate self-perception and identity formation
SCENARIO CARDS	Card 1-A (Amara — New School, New Mask) · Card 1-B (Jordan — The Class Clown)
QUICK REVIEW	None — this is Lesson 1. Begin with the opening ritual.

SAFETY CHECK

Before class: Confirm crisis resource numbers (988 Lifeline · Crisis Text Line: HOME to 741741) are posted visibly. Know your school counselor's name and same-day contact method. You will use these throughout the year. This lesson is not high-disclosure-risk — but the Identity Audit occasionally surfaces something significant for students carrying heavy self-perception burdens.

ANCHOR CHART · MASK VS. MIRROR — TWO-COLUMN DISPLAY

Post this **before class**. Keep visible **all year**. **LEFT COLUMN — THE MASK:** What I show others. What I perform. What I hide. What I emphasise. **RIGHT COLUMN — THE MIRROR:** What is actually there when the performance stops. My real opinions. My actual struggles. What I value. Grade 6: Label each column with a simple icon — a theatrical mask and a reflective surface. Grades 7–8: Add below the columns: "The gap between these two is where the cost lives."

OPENING · 3–4 MINUTES

"Think about the last time you walked into a social situation and consciously thought about how you were coming across. What were you managing? What were you hiding? That process of management is what we are going to examine today."

Pause 10 seconds. Let the question land. Students write in journals for 60 seconds before any class discussion.

DIRECT INSTRUCTION · STEPS 1 — 4

I

Introduce the Mask

5 MIN

"Everyone wears a Mask — a social performance. The Mask is not always dishonest. Often it is sensible. The problem is not the Mask. The problem is when the Mask becomes so habitual that we lose contact with what is underneath."

Point to the Mask column. Ask: **"What kinds of things go in this column?"** Take 2–3 answers.

2

Introduce the Mirror

5 MIN

"The Mirror is what is actually there when the performance stops — your real opinions, your actual struggles, the things you find funny when you are not worried about whether it is the right thing to find funny. The Mirror is not more virtuous than the Mask. It is just more real."

Point to the Mirror column. Ask: **"What kinds of things live in the Mirror column?"** Take 2–3 answers.

IN-LESSON SCAN

OBSERVE Students who go very still during the Mirror introduction, or who look away from the anchor chart. **MAY SIGNAL** A student who cannot tolerate even hearing the Mirror column described may have very high identity fusion with a curated self — or significant fear of what they would find underneath.

ACTION Note privately. Do not address publicly. Monitor through Unit 2.

WORKSHEET

Identity Audit WS1 · U1-L1 · Primary Activity — Private Two-column private reflection. Left: Who I am when performing. Right: Who I am when not performing. Students work independently and silently. **Never collected. Never shared** unless student chooses.

3

Identity Audit · Private

10 MIN

"Left column: who I am when I am performing — what I show, what I hide, what I emphasise. Right column: who I am when I am not performing — what I actually think, feel, value, and struggle with. Work in complete silence. This is private."

Set a visible 10-minute timer. Circulate — do not read over shoulders.

IN-LESSON SCAN

OBSERVE A student who stares at the blank worksheet for more than 2 minutes, or who writes a single word and stops. **MAY SIGNAL** May indicate significant difficulty accessing the Mirror column — either because it feels unsafe or because the gap has been suppressed for a long time. **ACTION** Move quietly toward them after 2–3 minutes. Say low: "You can label the columns with one word each if that helps." Do not linger. Note for Unit 2 watch list.

4

Discussion — The Gap

8 MIN

"Without revealing the contents of your columns — where is the gap between your two sides biggest?" Take 3–4 responses. Redirect to the anchor chart as each lands.

"What does maintaining that gap cost you — in energy, in authenticity, in connection?" Take 2–3 responses.

"What would it take to reduce the gap by even 10%? Not radical transparency — just one small step toward being slightly more real in a safe context." Let this sit without requiring answers aloud.

UNIT 1 · LESSON 1 · THE INTERIOR (6–8)

SCENARIO CARDS

CARD 1-A Amara — New School, New Mask Transfers schools, constructs a careful Mask. "I don't know which one is me anymore." Use if time allows — pairs only. Four discussion questions. **CARD 1-B Jordan — The Class Clown** Funniest person in every room, reads philosophy books in private. For Grades 7–8 or faster classes. Introduces identity-foreclosure concept. Use optional — do not cut Step 3 or Step 4 to accommodate.

TEACHING TIP

Grade 6: Scaffold the Identity Audit with concrete examples before students begin — sports tryouts, lunch table choices, what you post vs. what you feel. Grades 7–8: Introduce "**identity foreclosure**" — committing to a persona so early that you stop questioning it. Ask: "When did you decide who you were going to be, and was that decision really yours?"

EXIT TICKET

"**The version of me that almost no one sees is ____.** Why does that version stay hidden?" Journal entry — student writes privately. Never collected. Never graded.

TEACHER REFLECTION

Which students seemed most activated — with relief (as if they have been waiting for permission to name the gap) or with resistance (dismissing the concept)? Students who heavily resist may have very high identity fusion with their curated self. Note for Unit 2. Which students completed both columns quickly and easily? Those students may have unusually high self-awareness — or may have been performing the reflection rather than doing it.

FAMILY CONNECTION

Today we began our identity unit by examining the gap between the persona students perform socially and who they actually are. You can open this at home by modelling vulnerability — share a moment when you felt like you were "performing" rather than being real.

ANCHOR CHART · MASK VS. MIRROR — TWO-COLUMN DISPLAY

BUILD SPECIFICATION

THE MASK	THE MIRROR
What I show others What I perform What I hide What I emphasise	What is actually there My real opinions My actual struggles What I value

Draw two columns separated by a bold vertical line. Title across the top in large text.

Grades 7–8 add-on: "The gap between these two is where the cost lives."

POST: Before class. Day 1 of the year. · **KEEP:** All year.

REGULATION & REPAIR STRAND

Calming · Physiological Awareness + 3-Breath Reset



The Anatomy of a Mistake

35–40 min · September Week 2

OBJECTIVE	Students distinguish shame ("I am a bad person") from guilt ("I made a choice that did not fit my integrity"), and explain why guilt is more useful than shame for growth.
CASEL FOCUS	Self-Awareness: shame vs. guilt distinction · Self-Management: reframing self-critical thoughts
SCENARIO CARDS	Card 1-C (Maya — "I am stupid") · Card 1-D (Darius — Keeps Paying for It)
QUICK REVIEW	1–2 min: "Last lesson we talked about the Mask and the Mirror. Give me one word for the Mask column and one for the Mirror column." Call on 2–3 students. "Today we look at what happens when the person under the Mask makes a mistake."

LEGAL · PPRA NOTE

PPRA Designation — All standard opt-out protocols apply. This lesson is PPRA-designated. All standard opt-out protocols apply. Brief your school counselor before delivery — awareness only, no co-facilitation required. Students who show visceral recognition of chronic shame should be noted for counselor follow-up.

ANCHOR CHART · SHAME VS. GUILT — T-CHART

Draw this T-chart on the board **before class**. Keep visible throughout this lesson and revisit in Unit 2. **SHAME COLUMN:** "I AM bad." → Produces hiding, withdrawal, defensiveness, aggression. Focuses on self. Almost never produces growth or repair. **GUILT COLUMN:** "I DID something that did not fit who I want to be." → Produces discomfort directed toward repair. Functional and forward-moving. Add student descriptors to each column as the lesson progresses.

OPENING · 2–3 MINUTES

"Has anyone ever done something they regret — and then spent more time feeling terrible about themselves than actually fixing the problem? That experience — where the feeling of badness becomes bigger than the behaviour itself — is what we examine today."

Pause. Let students recognise the experience without sharing yet.

1

Define Shame

6 MIN

"Shame is a global, identity-level response — I AM bad." Write "I AM bad" on the Shame side. "It produces hiding, withdrawal, defensiveness, or aggression. It focuses on the self, not the situation. Shame almost never produces growth or repair."

Ask: **"What does shame feel like in your body?"** Take 2–3 responses. Add to the T-chart.

2

Define Guilt

5 MIN

"Guilt is a specific, behaviour-level response — I DID something that did not fit who I want to be." Write "I DID something bad" on the Guilt side. "It produces discomfort directed outward toward the repair. Guilt is functional; shame is not."

Ask: **"What is different about how guilt feels compared to shame?"** Take 2–3 responses. Add to chart.

IN-LESSON SCAN

OBSERVE During the shame definition, a student who nods emphatically, exhales, or immediately names very specific shame phrases without hesitation. **MAY SIGNAL** This student likely lives with chronic shame as a central feature of their inner life — not a passing experience. They are at elevated risk for Unit 2 L6 material. **ACTION** Note name privately. Brief counselor before Unit 2 L1. Do not address in the moment.

3

T-Chart Scenario Analysis

12 MIN

Work through Cards 1-C and 1-D. For each: **"What is the emotional response? Is that shame or guilt — how do you know? What would the alternative response look like? What does each lead to?"**

Model Card 1-C as a whole class. Pairs for Card 1-D. Prioritise 1-C (Maya: "I am stupid") — it illustrates the core distinction cleanly.

4

The Digital Dimension

5 MIN

"In middle school, mistakes often have a digital component — screenshots, group chats, posts that spread. The digital permanence of mistakes can intensify shame dramatically."

Ask: **"How does the public nature of a mistake change how it feels?"** Take 2–3 responses. Note on chart: "Digital permanence → shame amplifier."

5

The Integrity Framework

5 MIN

"Guilt tells us a choice did not fit our integrity." Students write privately: "A choice that would NOT fit my integrity is ____."

Do not share. Keep private. This plants the seed for Lesson 4 (Peer Pressure).

UNIT 1 · LESSON 2 · THE INTERIOR (6–8)

IN-LESSON SCAN

OBSERVE During partner discussion of Card 1-C, a student who deflects or jokes every time the conversation lands near a personal connection. **MAY SIGNAL** Humour is a developmentally normal defence, but consistent deflection during shame content may indicate this topic is hitting very close to home. **ACTION** Do not name or interrupt the behaviour. After class, note the pattern privately. Monitor in Unit 2.

SCENARIO CARDS

CARD 1-C Maya — "I am stupid" Failed maths test → avoidance → "I am just stupid." Whole-class first. Prioritise. **CARD 1-D Darius — Keeps Paying for It** Apologised, was forgiven — still self-punishing 6 months later. For Grades 7–8 after 1-C debrief.

TEACHING TIP

Grades 7–8 Extension: Explore the neuroscience — shame activates the same threat response as physical danger (fight/flight/freeze). Guilt activates a social bonding and repair circuit. "That is why shame makes you want to hide, and guilt makes you want to fix things." Grade 6: Keep concrete. The T-chart is the anchor. Avoid going into shame neuroscience at Grade 6 — the distinction itself is the learning.

EXIT TICKET

"The difference between shame and guilt, in my own words, is ____." Journal entry — student writes privately. Never collected. Never graded.

TEACHER REFLECTION

Students who show the most visceral recognition of shame — as if it is a central feature of their daily inner life — are at elevated risk. Note names privately for counselor awareness. Chronic shame is a significant risk factor for the disclosure material in Unit 2 and 3. Brief your counselor before Unit 2 Lesson 1 on any students this lesson brought to your attention.

FAMILY CONNECTION

Today we studied the difference between shame (I am bad) and guilt (I made a bad choice). This distinction matters enormously at home: when your child makes a mistake, focus on the behaviour, not the person. "That was a dishonest choice" stays in guilt. "You are a liar" pushes into shame.

LEGAL · PPRA NOTE

PPRA-designated activity. All standard opt-out protocols apply. Parental notification letter must be distributed minimum 10 calendar days before Unit 1 Lesson 1. Brief your school counselor before delivery.

UNIT 1 · LESSON 2 · THE INTERIOR (6-8)
ANCHOR CHART · SHAME VS. GUILT — T-CHART

BUILD SPECIFICATION

SHAME	GUILT
"I AM bad." Produces hiding, withdrawal, defensiveness Focuses on self Almost never produces growth	"I DID something bad." Produces discomfort directed toward repair Focuses on the choice Functional and forward-moving

Draw a T-chart, color-code columns, add student descriptors during lesson.

Post **before** the sorting activity. When a student uses shame language, point to the chart: "Which column is that in?"

POST: Before class. Color-code the two columns. · **KEEP:** All unit. Revisit in Unit 2.

The Digital Backpack

40 min · September Week 3

OBJECTIVE	Students examine their digital footprint as an extension of identity and identify one way their digital self diverges from their authentic self.
CASEL FOCUS	Self-Awareness: digital identity · Social Awareness: permanence and impact of digital choices
SCENARIO CARDS	Card 1-E (Kezia — Perfect Digital Life) · Card 1-F (Marcus — Deleted Post)
QUICK REVIEW	1-2 min: "Last lesson: shame vs. guilt. Quick check — finish this sentence: Shame says 'I AM ___'; guilt says 'I DID ___'. Today we look at a new layer of identity: the digital version of yourself."

EQUITY ALERT — DELIVER EXPLICITLY. NOT OPTIONAL.

Deliver this before Step 1 — not at the end, not as a footnote: "Some people and families have very good reasons to be careful online. Limited digital presence is often wisdom — not absence. That is also worth naming. We are looking at patterns today, not judging the size of your digital footprint." Students from families navigating immigration, safety concerns, or privacy needs may have deliberately minimal digital presence and real anxiety around digital permanence. For students without significant digital access: "Apply the same questions to your in-person social presence — how you present at lunch, in class, in the hallways."

ANCHOR CHART · THE DIGITAL BACKPACK

Draw this image on the board **before class** — a backpack filling up. Label what goes in: posts, comments, likes, shares, screenshots, reactions, messages. Key message: "Unlike a physical backpack, this one is mostly permanent, potentially public, and carries things longer than you intended." Add as the lesson progresses: "→ Once it's in, it stays."

OPENING · 3 MINUTES

"If someone who had never met you could only learn about you through your digital presence — your posts, your comments, your likes, your shares — what would they know about you? Would that picture be accurate? Would you want it to be?"

Students write 60 seconds in journals before any sharing.

1 The Digital Backpack Metaphor

7 MIN

"Everything you post, share, react to, and comment on is added to your Digital Backpack." Point to the visual. "Unlike a physical backpack, this one is mostly permanent, potentially public, and often carries things longer than you intended."

Ask: **"What kinds of things go into a digital backpack without you realising?"** Take 3–4 responses. Add to the anchor chart visual.

WORKSHEET

Digital Backpack Audit U1-L3 · Private Activity **Patterns** audit — NOT specific posts. What do you typically post about? What tone do you use? What do you react to? Does the digital picture match your Mirror column from Lesson 1? Never collected.

2 Digital Backpack Audit · Private

10 MIN

"Work privately. This is about patterns — not specific posts. What does your digital presence tend to emphasise? What does it hide? Does your digital self match the Mirror column from Lesson 1?"

Set a 10-minute timer. For students without digital access: **"Apply the same questions to your in-person social presence."**

IN-LESSON SCAN

OBSERVE During the audit, a student who writes very quickly and then turns the paper over or closes their journal hard. **MAY SIGNAL** May indicate the audit has landed on something specific and uncomfortable — possibly a post or pattern they have been carrying with shame. **ACTION** Do not retrieve or probe. Note privately. If the student approaches you voluntarily after class, follow your disclosure protocol.

3 The Permanence Reality

7 MIN

"Even deleted content can be screenshot, cached, or remembered." Use Card 1-F (Marcus deleted his comment — still showing up 14 months later). "The digital environment operates on different rules than in-person interaction."

Ask: **"Marcus deleted his comment — why is it still appearing a year later?"** Take answers. Confirm: screenshots, shares, memory. Add to the backpack visual: "→ Once it's in, it stays."

4 One Thing to Change

6 MIN

"Identify one specific aspect of your digital behaviour you want to be more intentional about — not necessarily remove, but do with more awareness."

Students write in journals: **"One way my digital self diverges from my authentic self is _____. One thing I want to be more intentional about is _____."** No sharing required.

UNIT 1 · LESSON 3 · THE INTERIOR (6–8)

SCENARIO CARDS

CARD 1-E Kezia — Perfect Digital Life, Hidden Pain "If I posted what I actually feel, I'd lose everything."

Illustrates gap between curated digital self and authentic self. **CARD 1-F Marcus — Deleted Post, Still Circulating** Screenshot appeared 14 months later. Anchors the permanence reality discussion. Use 1-E for the gap discussion, 1-F for the permanence step. Do NOT ask students to share real examples of posts they regret.

TEACHING TIP

Grade 6: Focus on the gap concept and permanence. Keep the audit very broad — general patterns only. Do not probe specific posts. Grades 7–8: Introduce **"audience collapse"** — posting for one audience when many others may be watching. "How does knowing multiple audiences might see your content change what you feel comfortable expressing?"

EXIT TICKET

"One way my digital self diverges from my authentic self is _____. One thing I want to be more intentional about is _____." Journal entry — student writes privately. Never collected. Never graded.

TEACHER REFLECTION

Equity follow-up: Did the equity alert land meaningfully — did students with limited digital access seem included rather than othered? Pacing note: The permanence reality discussion often runs long at Grades 7–8. Monitor time at the 20-minute mark.

FAMILY CONNECTION

Today students examined their digital identity — what their online presence says about who they are. At home, this is worth an honest family conversation: what are our expectations about digital permanence and public vs. private?

ANCHOR CHART · THE DIGITAL BACKPACK — FILLING-UP METAPHOR

BUILD SPECIFICATION

Draw: a large backpack outline. Label items entering it: Posts · Comments · Likes · Shares · Screenshots · Messages

Add as lesson progresses: "Mostly permanent" · "Potentially public" · "Carries longer than you intended"

Arrow into the backpack: "→ Once it's in, it stays."

For students without digital access: also applies to in-person social presence (lunch, class, hallways).

POST: Before class. · **KEEP:** Unit 1.

Peer Pressure & The Volume of Integrity

40 min · September Week 4

OBJECTIVE	Students identify at least two mechanisms by which peer pressure operates and articulate one strategy for maintaining integrity when social pressure is high.
CASEL FOCUS	Self-Management: maintaining values under social pressure · Social Awareness: understanding group dynamics
SCENARIO CARDS	Card 1-G (Sofia — Didn't Stop the Mockery) · Card 1-H (The Lunch Table Vote)
QUICK REVIEW	1–2 min: "Three lessons in. Quick check: what is the Mask? What is the Mirror? What is the difference between shame and guilt?" Take 3 quick answers (one per question). "Today we look at the biggest external force that pushes you toward the Mask: peer pressure."

ANCHOR CHART · SIGNAL VS. NOISE — THE VOLUME OF INTEGRITY

Draw this on the board **before class**. Keep posted through the end of Unit 1. **SIGNAL:** Integrity — the consistent, quiet voice of your values. **NOISE:** Peer pressure — loud, surrounding, hard to hear past. Add the three mechanisms as you teach them: SOCIAL PROOF · FEAR OF EXCLUSION · IDENTITY MERGER. Central question: "What makes the noise louder?" Students contribute.

OPENING · 2–3 MINUTES

"Have you ever been in a situation where you knew what the right thing to do was — and then the pressure of the people around you made it feel impossible to do it? What happened?"

Students write 60 seconds in journals. No sharing yet.

DIRECT INSTRUCTION · STEPS 1 — 4

I The Volume Metaphor 7 MIN

"Integrity is a signal — the consistent, quiet voice of your values. Peer pressure is noise — loud, surrounding, and hard to hear past." Point to the anchor chart. "The challenge of adolescence is not that the signal goes away. It is that the volume of the noise makes the signal almost impossible to hear."

Ask: **"What makes the noise louder?"** Take 3–4 answers. Add to chart.

2

Three Mechanisms of Peer Pressure

8 MIN

Write each on the board as you explain: **(1) SOCIAL PROOF** — "Everyone is doing it, so it must be right." **(2) FEAR OF EXCLUSION** — "If I don't go along, I lose my seat at the table." **(3) IDENTITY MERGER** — "My group's opinion is my opinion."

Then: **"These are not moral failures. They are features of human social cognition. Your brain is wired for these responses. Knowing that doesn't make them go away — but it gives you a fighting chance against them."**

IN-LESSON SCAN

OBSERVE During the Fear of Exclusion mechanism, a student who goes very still, breaks eye contact, or looks down in a sustained way. **MAY SIGNAL** This student may currently be experiencing active social exclusion — not theoretical. The mechanism may not be abstract for them. **ACTION** Do not single out or address publicly. Approach quietly after class: "I noticed today landed for you. I'm available to talk." Note for counselor.

3

Scenario Card Analysis

10 MIN

"Small groups. For each scenario: What is the peer pressure mechanism? What is the integrity response? What would it cost? What would it give?"

Run Card 1-G as a whole class first — walk through all four questions together. Then groups on Card 1-H.

4

The One-Ally Strategy

5 MIN

"Research shows that having ONE person who shares your position dramatically reduces conformity. Before a social pressure moment — find one person who might agree with you. You don't have to announce it. Just know they're there."

Students write a name or descriptor privately — not to share. Also distribute and introduce the Values Under Pressure worksheet as a private journal entry.

SCENARIO CARDS

CARD 1-G Sofia — Didn't Stop the Mockery Didn't join in, laughed once, felt sick. Targets bystander behaviour. Work through all four questions as a whole class first. **CARD 1-H The Lunch Table Vote** "Vote" to exclude someone. Introduces vote as social coercion mechanism. Use for faster classes after 1-G debrief.

WORKSHEET

Values Under Pressure U1-L4 · Private Journal One value that has come under peer pressure. What was the pressure? What did they do? What do they wish they had done? What would they do differently next time? Never collected.

UNIT 1 · LESSON 4 · THE INTERIOR (6–8)

IN-LESSON SCAN

OBSERVE During the one-ally strategy discussion, a student who cannot name a single potential ally — who looks around the room with apparent desperation or resignation. **MAY SIGNAL** May indicate significant social isolation or a perception of complete peer non-support. This is important relational data. **ACTION** Note privately. Do not press during class. Raise with counselor as context for Unit 3 (forgiving others) work.

TEACHING TIP

Grade 6: Focus on concrete, immediate peer scenarios — school social hierarchy, friend group dynamics. Emphasise: noticing the pressure is the first skill. Grades 7–8: Introduce "**preference falsification**" — saying one thing publicly while believing something privately. "How does this accumulate over time into a loss of authentic voice?"

EXIT TICKET

"One situation where I maintained my integrity under pressure — and what it cost and gave me." Journal entry — student writes privately. Never collected. Never graded.

TEACHER REFLECTION

Common error: framing peer pressure as a moral failure. This lesson explicitly teaches that conformity is a feature of human social cognition, not a character flaw. Normalise the mechanism before addressing the response. The scenario cards are the primary load-bearing activity. Do not abbreviate. The one-ally strategy must be explicitly taught, not just mentioned.

FAMILY CONNECTION

Today students studied how peer pressure works — and what to do about it. At home, you can open this conversation by sharing a time you faced peer pressure as an adult or young person. What did you do? What do you wish you had done?

ANCHOR CHART · SIGNAL VS. NOISE — THE VOLUME OF INTEGRITY

BUILD SPECIFICATION

SIGNAL = Integrity — the consistent, quiet voice of your values.

NOISE = Peer pressure — loud, surrounding, hard to hear past.

Three mechanisms: (1) Social Proof · (2) Fear of Exclusion · (3) Identity Merger

Add mechanisms as you teach them. "**The signal never goes away.**"

POST: Before class. · **KEEP:** All of Unit 1.

Owning Your Narrative

40 min · October Week 1

OBJECTIVE	Students write a personal Integrity Statement claiming authorship of their own narrative against externally assigned labels.
CASEL FOCUS	Self-Awareness: narrative identity · Self-Management: resilience against social labelling
SCENARIO CARDS	None — the Integrity Statement is the primary artifact
QUICK REVIEW	1–2 min: "Last lesson we talked about peer pressure. The noise. Today we look at a specific kind of noise: labels that other people put on us. Give me one example of a label someone might be given at school — not personal, just a type." Take 2–3 answers. "Today: who gets to be the author of your story?"

LEGAL · PPRA NOTE

PPRA Designation — All standard opt-out protocols apply. This lesson includes the Integrity Statement — PPRA-designated activity. All standard opt-out protocols apply. This lesson may surface strong emotion in students who have been significantly labelled by others — counselor awareness recommended before delivery.

ANCHOR CHART · LABEL VS. INTEGRITY — AUTHOR OF YOUR STORY

Draw on chart paper or the board **before class**. Keep posted through U1L7. **LEFT — LABEL:** Something others assign from the outside. Based on social dynamics, past incidents, reputation, rumour. **RIGHT — INTEGRITY STATEMENT:** Something you claim from the inside. Based on your values, your choices, your authorship. Central question, posted large: "**Who gets to write your story?**"

OPENING · 3 MINUTES

"Has anyone ever been given a label by other people — 'the troublemaker,' 'the quiet one,' 'the one who got in trouble in 5th grade' — that stuck, even though it was not the full truth? Today we look at who gets to tell your story."

1

The Narrative Question

7 MIN

"We all live inside a story that others are telling about us. Most of the time, we did not write it. It was written by social dynamics, past incidents, reputation, and rumour. But the author of your story should be you."

Point to the anchor chart. **"A label is something others assign from the outside. Integrity is something you claim from the inside. The label tells you what others see. Integrity tells you who you actually are."**

WORKSHEET

Integrity Statement Template U1·L5 · Primary Artifact Four prompts: "I am _____. I value _____. I choose _____. The story I am telling about myself is _____." This statement is not what students want to be — it is what they choose to be RIGHT NOW. Artifact — students keep this. Teacher may collect with permission.

2

The Integrity Statement · Primary Activity

15 MIN

"You are going to write your Integrity Statement — the story you are choosing to tell, right now, about who you are. Four prompts: I am _____. I value _____. I choose _____. The story I am telling about myself is _____."

Allow 12 minutes of quiet writing time. Do not rush this. If stuck: **"Start with one value you have held even when it was hard to hold."**

SAFETY CHECK

During Integrity Statement writing: some students who have been heavily labelled may become emotional. This is a healthy response to permission they may never have been given — Type 1 Disclosure territory. Acknowledge privately and quietly: "I can see this landed — I will check in with you after class." Do not draw class attention to the student. Do not press for explanation during class.

IN-LESSON SCAN

OBSERVE A student who writes a single line and then crosses it out repeatedly, or who writes and then turns the paper face-down. **MAY SIGNAL** May be experiencing significant difficulty claiming authorship against a very entrenched external label — the label may have become their identity. **ACTION** Do not retrieve. Move quietly toward them and offer: "You can write one value — just one. That is enough for today." Follow up after class.

3

Optional Gallery Share

5 MIN

"You may share ONE LINE from your Integrity Statement with a partner — never with the full class unless you choose to."

Pair students (student choice — never assigned). Partner's only job: listen and say **"I hear that."** Optional — never pressure. The lesson works whether or not students share.

UNIT 1 · LESSON 5 · THE INTERIOR (6–8)

IN-LESSON SCAN

OBSERVE During partner share, a student who cannot say a single line aloud — who whispers "I don't have anything" despite having written. **MAY SIGNAL** Sharing what they wrote may feel acutely vulnerable — particularly if their statement claims something sharply counter to how they are seen.

ACTION Do not push. Honor the silence. After class: "You wrote something real today. I hope you read it again tonight." Note for counselor.

TEACHING TIP

Grade 6: Scaffold with sentence frames. Focus on one or two values. The anti-label frame is powerful at Grade 6 — students who have been socially typecast early respond strongly. Grades 7–8: "Can you choose your identity, or is it something that emerges from what you do over time? The Integrity Statement is both a declaration and a commitment to action."

EXIT TICKET

"One label others have applied to me that does not tell my full story is _____. The story I am choosing to tell is _____." Journal entry — student writes privately. Never collected. Never graded.

TEACHER REFLECTION

This is the most important artifact of Unit 1. Students who are heavily labelled may become emotional — this is the curriculum working. Students who quickly write a polished, performed statement without visible struggle may be performing the reflection. Both need you — one needs space, the other needs depth. PPRA note: All standard opt-out protocols apply to the Integrity Statement activity.

FAMILY CONNECTION

Today students wrote a personal Integrity Statement — a first-person claim about who they are and what they value. You can support this at home by asking: "If you could tell the world one thing about who you actually are — not your reputation, your actual character — what would you say?"

LEGAL · PPRA NOTE

PPRA-designated activity. The Integrity Statement is a PPRA-designated written activity. All standard opt-out protocols apply. Students may opt out without academic penalty.

BUILD SPECIFICATION

LABEL	INTEGRITY STATEMENT
Assigned from the outside Social dynamics, reputation, rumour Tells you what others see Often partial or distorted	Claimed from the inside Values, choices, authorship Tells you who you are I am ____ · I value ____ · I choose ____

Large central question: "Who gets to write your story?"

The four prompts: I am ____ · I value ____ · I choose ____ · The story I am telling is ____

POST: Before class. · **KEEP:** Through U1L7.

The Agency of Choice

40 min · October Week 2

OBJECTIVE	Students complete a choice-agency map and articulate at least one situation in their current life where they have more agency over their response than they currently believe.
CASEL FOCUS	Self-Management: agency and impulse regulation · Responsible Decision-Making: locus of control
SCENARIO CARDS	None — the Choice-Agency Map is the primary activity
QUICK REVIEW	1-2 min: "Quick check on our vocabulary. Integrity Statement — what is it? (student answer) Label — what is it? (student answer) Good. Today's lesson is about the most important thing you can claim when you can't control your circumstances: your response."

EQUITY ALERT — DELIVER EXPLICITLY. NOT OPTIONAL.

Before Step 1 — state explicitly: "This framework is about your internal response — what you choose to think, feel, and do inside. It is not saying that all circumstances are equal. Some circumstances genuinely limit what responses are available — and that is an injustice, not a personal failure." "We are not saying 'just choose better.' We are saying: even in constrained circumstances, your response is the one thing that often remains yours." This must be said before students begin the circle map — not after.

ANCHOR CHART · THE CHOICE-AGENCY MAP — THREE CONCENTRIC CIRCLES

Draw this **large** on the board **before class**. **OUTER RING:** Things completely outside my control. **MIDDLE RING:** Things I can influence but not control. **INNER CIRCLE:** Things I can fully choose — starting with my own response. Pre-populate the outer ring with 3-4 class-generated examples. Leave space for student additions. Key teaching: "**My response**" always belongs in the inner circle.

OPENING · 3 MINUTES

"Is there something in your life right now that you feel completely powerless about? Something you cannot change, cannot fix, cannot escape? Today we look at what Viktor Frankl — a psychiatrist who survived a Nazi concentration camp — discovered about choice in conditions of total powerlessness."

1

The Frankl Principle

5 MIN

"Between what happens to us and how we respond, there is always a space. In that space is our power to choose. Even when we cannot change our circumstances, we can choose our response."

Write on the board. Ask: **"Does this feel true to you? Does it feel impossible? Both reactions are worth naming."** Take 2–3 responses without resolving.

WORKSHEET

Choice-Agency Map U1-L6 · Primary Activity Three concentric circles. Outer: things completely outside my control. Middle: things I can influence but not control. Inner: things I can fully choose — starting with my own response. Never collected.

2

The Choice-Agency Map · Primary Activity

15 MIN

"Draw three concentric circles or use the worksheet. Outer: things completely outside my control right now. Middle: things I can influence but not fully control. Inner: things I can fully choose — starting with my own response."

Pre-populate the outer circle on the board with 3–4 examples first. Set a 12-minute timer. Circulate without commenting on content.

IN-LESSON SCAN

OBSERVE Students who fill the inner circle (what I can choose) with external outcomes — "I can choose to get an A," "I can choose to make them like me." **MAY SIGNAL** Indicates a control belief error — attributing choice-level control to influence-level situations. This is a common cognitive pattern under pressure. **ACTION** During debrief gently surface: "Your response to a situation always belongs in the inner circle. The outcome of that response may belong further out."

3

The Key Insight Discussion

10 MIN

"Look at your inner circle. You cannot control whether someone is unkind to you. You CAN choose how you respond."
Pause.

"Think of one situation in your life right now that feels like it is entirely in the outer circle. Where does your RESPONSE to that situation live?" Students write 3 min. Pair share optional.

IN-LESSON SCAN

OBSERVE Students who fill the outer circle with internal states — emotions, thoughts, self-worth ("I can't control how I feel," "I can't control what I think about myself"). **MAY SIGNAL** This may indicate significant helplessness or a trauma-based response where internal states feel externally controlled. This is clinically significant. **ACTION** Note privately for counselor follow-up. Do not correct in class — the framing requires careful individual work, not whole-class instruction.

UNIT 1 · LESSON 6 · THE INTERIOR (6–8)

TEACHING TIP

Grade 6: Focus on school-based examples in the outer and middle circles. Keep the inner circle concrete: "My response" and "What I choose to say." Avoid going into philosophical territory. Grades 7–8: Explore the research behind locus of control — students with internal locus of control show significantly better outcomes across mental health and academic domains. Ask: "What would it mean to practice moving your response from the outer to the inner circle — even once a day?"

EXIT TICKET

"One thing in my life I cannot control that I am currently treating as if it controls me is _____. What I can choose instead is _____." Journal entry — student writes privately. Never collected. Never graded.

TEACHER REFLECTION

Lowest disclosure risk of Unit 1 — primarily conceptual and skill-focused. However, the journal prompt occasionally surfaces acute situations. Allow students to complete the choice-agency map independently before any group discussion. Grade 6 note: Students need the map with concrete items pre-listed in each circle as an example before beginning their own.

FAMILY CONNECTION

Today students learned about the space between what happens and how we respond — and that space is where our agency lives. At home, you can use the language: "You can't control that. What can you control?"

ANCHOR CHART · THE CHOICE-AGENCY MAP — THREE CONCENTRIC CIRCLES

BUILD SPECIFICATION

OUTER RING: Things completely outside my control.

MIDDLE RING: Things I can influence but not control.

INNER CIRCLE: Things I can fully choose — starting with my own response.

"My response always lives in the inner circle." Leave rings mostly blank — pre-populate outer ring with 3–4 class examples.

POST: Before class. Pre-populate outer ring with 3–4 examples. · **KEEP:** Unit 1. Reference in Unit 4.

Unit 1 Wrap-Up & Bridge to Unit 2

40–45 min · October Week 3

OBJECTIVE	Students consolidate Unit 1 learning, write a Future-Self Letter, and prepare conceptually for Unit 2 self-compassion work.
CASEL FOCUS	Self-Awareness (synthesis) · Self-Management: setting intentions for Unit 2
SCENARIO CARDS	None — synthesis and bridge lesson
QUICK REVIEW	1–2 min: Display all Unit 1 anchor charts simultaneously. "Look at everything this class has built in six weeks. Mask vs. Mirror. Shame vs. Guilt. Digital Backpack. Signal and Noise. Label vs. Author. Agency Map. Take 30 seconds — silently name your biggest takeaway from Unit 1." Journal 30 seconds.

ANCHOR CHART · ALL UNIT 1 ANCHOR CHARTS DISPLAYED SIMULTANEOUSLY

Post all six Unit 1 anchor charts visible at the same time before class begins. This visual display communicates: "Look what this class built." Do not rush past it. Allow 60 seconds of silent student scanning before any talking.

OPENING · 3 MINUTES

Display ALL Unit 1 anchor charts simultaneously. Allow students 60 seconds of silent scanning. Ask: "What is the most important thing Unit 1 taught you about yourself?" Take 4–5 responses. Affirm without evaluating. Let students hear each other's synthesis.

DIRECT INSTRUCTION · STEPS 1 — 4

I

Return to Lesson 1 Journals

5 MIN

"Open your journal to the first entry from Lesson 1 — your exit ticket: 'The version of me that almost no one sees is ____.' Read what you wrote then. Is any of it different now, after six weeks? Write for 3 minutes. No sharing required."

IN-LESSON SCAN

OBSERVE A student who opens their Lesson 1 journal entry and becomes very still or emotional. **MAY SIGNAL** The distance between Week 1 and Week 7 is real — and seeing it concretely sometimes brings an unexpected wave of recognition about growth or about how hard the unit was. **ACTION** Hold the room. Do not rush. Allow the emotion without naming it publicly. "Take your time." Continue with Step 2 only when the room has settled.

WORKSHEET

Future-Self Letter U1•L7 • Primary Artifact — Sealed Students write a letter to their future self at year-end. Three prompts: What do you want to remember from Unit 1? What do you want your future self to know about who you are right now? What hope do you have for who you are becoming? Letter is **sealed** in an envelope — teacher stores securely. Returned at U4L7 ONLY.

2

Future-Self Letter • Primary Activity

15 MIN

"You are going to write a letter to yourself — to the version of you who will be in this class on the last day of the school year. What do you want them to know? What do you want them to remember from these six weeks? What hope do you have for who they are becoming?"

Allow 12 minutes. Offer sentence starters: **"Right now I am learning that... / One thing I want you to remember is... / I hope that by June..."**

IN-LESSON SCAN

OBSERVE During letter-writing, a student who writes intensely without pausing, filling the entire page, then looks up with a look of surprise or relief. **MAY SIGNAL** This student may be experiencing the first time they have written something addressed to their own future self with genuine hope — not a performance. **ACTION** Do not interrupt. Hold the room carefully. Make a private note — this student's engagement with Unit 2 may be particularly significant.

3

Community Synthesis • Optional

7 MIN

"Who would like to share one line — just one — from their Future-Self Letter? No pressure."

Take 3–5 voluntary shares. After each: **"Thank you."** No evaluation. No elaboration. Let students' words stand on their own.

4

Bridge Framing

5 MIN

"In Unit 1, we looked at who you are — underneath the social performance. That was the hardest kind of looking. In Unit 2, we turn that same honest attention inward in a more focused way: we look at how you treat yourself when you fall short of who you want to be. What you learned about shame and guilt in Unit 1 is preparation for that."

Pause. **"The Mask you wear for others — Unit 1. The voice inside that comments on everything — Unit 2. We are going deeper."**

SAFETY CHECK

After letter sealing: observe how students handle the sealing ritual. Students who seem heavy, resistant, or very emotional may be processing something significant. Note for counselor. Distribute the Unit 2 Family Transition Letter for students to take home today. **▲ Critical:** Confirm counselor calendar is blocked for U2L6 before Unit 2 begins. Do not begin Unit 2 without this confirmed. **▲ Critical:** Seal letters with student names written on the outside. Store in a labelled, secure classroom location. These are returned at U4L7 — do not lose them.

UNIT 1 · LESSON 7 · THE INTERIOR (6–8)

EXIT TICKET

"The most important thing I am carrying from Unit 1 into Unit 2 is ____." Journal entry — student writes privately. Never collected. Never graded.

BRIDGE EXIT TICKETS:

Collect these and review privately before Unit 2 Lesson 1. Flag for counselor awareness any student whose ticket reveals acute or alarming self-critical language. These exit tickets tell you which students enter Unit 2 with the highest self-critical load.

TEACHER REFLECTION

Bridge delivery is essential. Do not abbreviate the framing statement — the shift from Unit 1 to Unit 2 is the most important conceptual move of the first semester. Review all bridge exit tickets privately before Unit 2 Lesson 1. Flag for counselor awareness any student whose ticket reveals acute or alarming self-critical language.

FAMILY CONNECTION

Your child wrote a letter to their future self today. It will be returned at year-end. Ask them: "What is the most important thing you know about yourself after the last seven weeks that you didn't know in September?"

LEGAL · PPRA NOTE

Family Transition: Distribute the Unit 2 Family Transition Letter today. **Counselor Calendar:** Confirm U2L6 co-facilitation is blocked before Unit 2 begins. This is a legal compliance requirement — not optional outreach.

ANCHOR CHART · ALL UNIT 1 CHARTS DISPLAYED SIMULTANEOUSLY

BUILD SPECIFICATION

Post all 6 Unit 1 anchor charts visible at the same time before class begins.

1. Mask vs. Mirror · 2. Shame vs. Guilt · 3. The Digital Backpack
4. Signal vs. Noise · 5. Label vs. Integrity · 6. Choice-Agency Map

Allow 60 seconds of silent student scanning before any talking. No new chart created.

POST: All six charts simultaneously, before class. · **KEEP:** Display for U1L7 only.

UNIT 2

Self-Compassion & The Internal Critic

*“How do I hold myself honestly — without cruelty — when
I fall short?”*

NOVEMBER – DECEMBER · 7 LESSONS · 40 MIN EACH

The Internal Critic

40 min · November Week 1

OBJECTIVE	Students name their internal critic, identify its three tactics, and write their first Compassionate Witness sentence.
CASEL FOCUS	Self-Awareness: understanding the internal critic · Self-Management: introducing the Compassionate Witness
SCENARIO CARDS	None — the Internal Critic Profile worksheet is the primary activity
QUICK REVIEW	1–2 min: "Last unit: we named who you are. Today we start Unit 2 — and we're going to meet a voice you already know very well. Before anything else: what was your biggest takeaway from Unit 1?" Take 2 quick answers. "Today we start listening to the voice inside that judges everything you do."

LEGAL · PPRA NOTE

PPRA Designation — All standard opt-out protocols apply. This lesson is PPRA-designated. All standard opt-out protocols apply. NEVER ask students to share their critic's specific words with the whole class. Journal first — always. Brief counselor before delivery.

SAFETY CHECK

NEVER ask students to share their critic's specific words with the whole class. Journal first — always. After journaling, pairs may share at their own discretion only. Whole-class sharing of internal critic content is not appropriate at any point in this lesson. Students who describe a critic voice that sounds like a specific person may be surfacing trauma. Note privately for counselor follow-up.

ANCHOR CHART · THE INTERNAL CRITIC — THREE TACTICS + COMPASSIONATE WITNESS

Draw this **before class**. Add the Compassionate Witness column during Step 3. **CATASTROPHISING:** "Everything is ruined. This is the worst thing that has ever happened." **GLOBALISING:** "I always fail. I never get it right. I am just bad at this." **PERSONALISING:** "Everything that went wrong is my fault." **COMPASSIONATE WITNESS** (added in Step 3): Honest + Fair + Kind. Not a cheerleader. Not a critic in disguise.

OPENING · 3 MINUTES

"We all have a voice inside that comments on everything we do. When you make a mistake, it has something to say. When you compare yourself to others, it has something to say. Today we are going to look at that voice — not to fight it, but to understand it."

1

Name the Critic

8 MIN

"Open your journal. Write the specific words your internal critic says to you. Not the category — the actual sentence. What does it say when you fail a test? When you say something awkward? When you compare yourself to someone else?"

Allow 5 full minutes of private writing. Do NOT ask students to share what they wrote.

Then: **"Where did you learn that voice? Was it someone specific? An experience? A system?"** 3 more minutes private writing.

IN-LESSON SCAN

OBSERVE During the "Name the Critic" journal prompt, students who go immediately and intensely into writing without pausing — who clearly already know exactly what to write. **MAY SIGNAL** This student's critic is loud, familiar, and well-rehearsed. This is the student who needs Unit 2 most. They may be at elevated disclosure risk in L6. **ACTION** Note privately. Do not acknowledge in class. Prioritise this student's wellbeing tracking across all of Unit 2.

WORKSHEET

Internal Critic Profile U2·L1 · Private Primary Activity Students name their internal critic, identify its tactic (catastrophising/globalising/personalising), and write two specific critic sentences plus one Compassionate Witness response. **Private — never collected, never shared.**

2

The Three Tactics

8 MIN

Point to the anchor chart. Walk through each tactic with a concrete example. After each: **"Raise your hand mentally if your critic uses this one."** Do NOT ask for actual hands — keep it private.

"The critic is not unique to you. The critic uses these same three tricks on every human brain. Knowing its moves gives you a fighting chance against it."

3

Introduce the Compassionate Witness

8 MIN

"The Compassionate Witness is an alternative internal voice. Not a cheerleader — not 'you are amazing!' Not a critic in disguise — not 'try harder!' A Compassionate Witness is honest AND fair AND kind, without punishment."

Add to the anchor chart. **"Write one sentence from the Compassionate Witness about the same situation the critic just addressed. It doesn't have to feel true yet. Just write it."**

UNIT 2 · LESSON 1 · THE INTERIOR (6–8)

IN-LESSON SCAN

OBSERVE During the Compassionate Witness writing prompt, a student who stares at the page and cannot write a single sentence — who looks genuinely stuck or distressed. **MAY SIGNAL** For some students, the Compassionate Witness is entirely inaccessible — they have no internal model of kind self-talk to draw from. This is clinically significant. **ACTION** Move quietly toward them. Say low: "You can write what you would say to your best friend in the same situation. That counts." Note for counselor follow-up before U2L6.

TEACHING TIP

Grade 6: Keep work at the surface — what does the critic say, and what does the Compassionate Witness say instead. Do not go into critic origins at Grade 6. Grades 7–8: Explore critic origins — "Has this voice always sounded this way, or did something happen that made it louder?" This question surfaces important material and connects to the Script work in L6.

EXIT TICKET

"My internal critic's favourite tactic is _____. My Compassionate Witness says: _____." Journal entry — student writes privately. Never collected. Never graded.

TEACHER REFLECTION

Highest activation potential of Unit 2. The opening prompt — "What does your internal critic actually say?" — should be completed in writing before any verbal sharing. Never ask students to share their critic's words aloud in a whole-class format. Students who describe a critic voice that sounds like a specific person in their lives may be surfacing trauma. Note for counselor.

FAMILY CONNECTION

Today students began naming their internal critic — the self-critical voice that speaks up when they make mistakes. You can support this at home: when your child is being hard on themselves, ask: "Would you say that to your best friend?"

LEGAL · PPRA NOTE

PPRA-designated activity. All standard opt-out protocols apply. NEVER ask students to share their critic's specific words with the whole class. Brief counselor before delivery.

ANCHOR CHART · THE INTERNAL CRITIC — THREE TACTICS + COMPASSIONATE WITNESS

BUILD SPECIFICATION

Catastrophising: "Everything is ruined."

Globalising: "I always/never _____."

Personalising: "It's always my fault."

UNIT 2 · LESSON 1 · THE INTERIOR (6-8)

Compassionate Witness column (add in Step 3): Honest + Fair + Kind. Not a cheerleader. Not a critic in disguise.

Color-code: critic column in red/orange, Compassionate Witness in green. Leave Compassionate Witness column blank until Step 3 — the contrast is intentional.

POST: Before class. Add Compassionate Witness column in Step 3. · **KEEP:** All of Unit 2 and beyond.

Highlight Reels & The Comparison Trap

40 min · November Week 2

OBJECTIVE	Students explain how social comparison operates in digital environments and articulate one strategy for measuring themselves against their own yardstick.
CASEL FOCUS	Self-Awareness: social comparison · Self-Management: resilience against comparison-based thinking
SCENARIO CARDS	None — class-generated comparison examples are used
QUICK REVIEW	1–2 min: "Last lesson we met the internal critic and its three tactics. Quick: name one tactic." (student answer) "Today we look at one of the critic's favourite fuel sources: comparing yourself to other people."

ANCHOR CHART · HIGHLIGHT REEL VS. BLOOPER REEL

Draw or display this two-image visual on the board. This is the lesson's core metaphor — keep posted.

HIGHLIGHT REEL: The curated, filtered, best-of presentation. What others see of us — and what we see of others online. **BLOOPER REEL:** The full, unedited experience — including the hard moments, doubts, failures, and ordinary days. Key message: "**You are comparing your blooper reel to someone else's highlight reel. That comparison is structurally rigged.**"

OPENING · 2 MINUTES

"Has anyone ever looked at someone else's life — online or in person — and felt worse about your own? That feeling is so common it has a name: social comparison. Today we look at why it happens and what to do about it."

DIRECT INSTRUCTION · STEPS 1 — 3

I The Fundamental Comparison Problem 8 MIN

"You are comparing your blooper reel to someone else's highlight reel." Point to the visual. "Your full, unedited experience — including the hard moments, the doubts, the failures — against their curated, filtered, best-of presentation. That comparison is structurally rigged. You will always lose a rigged comparison."

2

Social Comparison Theory

5 MIN

"Leon Festinger's research shows that comparison is a universal human cognitive mechanism — not a character flaw. But we have agency over three things: WHICH DIRECTION we compare (upward vs. downward), WHO we compare to (realistic peers vs. curated social media), and WHAT CONCLUSIONS we draw."

"The critic uses comparison as a weapon. We're going to change those three choices."

WORKSHEET

Comparison Audit U2·L2 · Primary Activity Students map three recent comparisons. For each: Was it upward or downward? Was the other person's presentation curated or raw? What conclusion did the comparison produce? Was that conclusion accurate? Then: own-yardstick reframe. Set a visible 8-minute timer and commit to it. Never collected.

3

The Own-Yardstick Concept

8 MIN

"The most reliable measure of your progress is you yesterday vs. you today. Comparing to others does not account for different starting points, different circumstances, or different destinations."

Students write: **"One comparison I made recently that was not fair to myself was _____. The own-yardstick alternative is _____."**

IN-LESSON SCAN

OBSERVE A student who cannot access a single recent comparison during the Comparison Audit — who writes "I don't compare myself to anyone." **MAY SIGNAL** Either this student is unusually self-assured (possible), or social comparison is happening at a level they cannot yet observe consciously (more common). The complete absence of recognised comparison is itself data. **ACTION** Do not confront. Note privately. This student may benefit from the in-person comparison framing: "What about in class, at lunch, in sport — not just online?"

IN-LESSON SCAN

OBSERVE A student who fills all three comparison slots quickly with the same person — every comparison is against one specific individual. **MAY SIGNAL** Intense, repeated comparison against a single person often indicates either aspirational attachment (admiration becoming self-attack) or social rivalry that is affecting wellbeing. **ACTION** Note privately. If the same name appears in subsequent check-ins or worksheets across multiple lessons, raise with counselor.

TEACHING TIP

Equity note: Not all students have equal social media access. Frame comparison as mechanism-focused, not platform-specific — it works identically in person. Grades 7–8 Extension: "Social media platforms are algorithmically designed to amplify social comparison. The comparison is not accidental — it is engineered. Does knowing this change how you engage with the platforms?"

EXIT TICKET

"A comparison I made recently that was not fair to myself was _____. The own-yardstick alternative is _____."

Journal entry — student writes privately. Never collected. Never graded.

TEACHER REFLECTION

The Comparison Audit runs long — set a timer at 8 minutes and hold it. The own-yardstick reframe is the most important element — do not skip it even if time is short. Common error: celebrating imperfection in a way that sounds like lowered standards. The message is not "comparing is always wrong" — it is "comparing to a rigged benchmark is not useful."

FAMILY CONNECTION

Today students studied the comparison trap — how social media shows everyone's best moments while we live through all of our moments. At home, reinforce the own-yardstick concept: "Don't compare your chapter 3 to someone else's chapter 10."

ANCHOR CHART · HIGHLIGHT REEL VS. BLOOPER REEL**BUILD SPECIFICATION**

HIGHLIGHT REEL	BLOOPER REEL
Curated Filtered Best-of What others post What we see online	Full, unedited experience Hard moments Doubts Failures Ordinary days

"You are comparing your blooper reel to someone else's highlight reel. That comparison is structurally rigged."

The own-yardstick: "Compared to me [time ago], I have _____."

POST: Before class. · **KEEP:** Unit 2.

Perfectionism — The Critic in Disguise

40 min · November Week 3

OBJECTIVE	Students distinguish perfectionism (fear of failure) from healthy striving (commitment to growth), and identify one way their internal critic uses perfectionism to prevent progress.
CASEL FOCUS	Self-Awareness: perfectionism as self-critical mechanism · Self-Management: tolerance for imperfection
SCENARIO CARDS	None — class-generated examples anchor the lesson
QUICK REVIEW	1–2 min: "We have named the internal critic and looked at comparison. Quick: name one way the Compassionate Witness differs from the critic." (student answer) "Today we look at the critic's most clever disguise: perfectionism."

ANCHOR CHART · THE PERFECTIONISM SPECTRUM — HORIZONTAL SCALE

Draw this horizontal spectrum on the board **before class**. **LEFT END — PERFECTIONISM:** "Failure = I am worthless." Terror masquerading as ambition. **RIGHT END — HEALTHY STRIVING:** "Failure = data I can learn from." High standards without self-destruction. Students mark where they sit in different life domains privately during the lesson. Below the spectrum: "**What is the fear underneath the left side?**"

OPENING · 3 MINUTES

"Is there anyone in this room who has ever not started something — or given up on something — because they were afraid they could not do it perfectly? That experience is not laziness. It is perfectionism. Today we look at what is actually happening."

DIRECT INSTRUCTION · STEPS 1 — 4

I

What Perfectionism Is (And Is Not)

7 MIN

"Perfectionism is not having high standards. Perfectionism is having standards so high, combined with such a severe response to not meeting them, that the risk of trying becomes greater than the cost of not trying. It is terror masquerading as ambition."

Point to the left end of the spectrum. "**Why does perfectionism often look like laziness? Because the student who isn't doing their homework is frequently in a perfectionist freeze — the homework feels so tied to their self-worth that not doing it is safer than doing it poorly.**"

WORKSHEET

Perfectionism vs. Striving Spectrum U2·L3 · Primary Activity Students mark where they sit in school, activities, and social life. Identify: "One area where my perfectionism looks like laziness is _____. What is actually happening is I am afraid of _____." Then: "One imperfect step I can take this week is _____." Never collected.

2

Spectrum Activity

10 MIN

Distribute worksheets or have students draw the spectrum in journals. **"Mark where you sit in school. Mark where you sit in another area — sport, creativity, social life, family. Now look at your left-side marks. What is the fear underneath each one?"**

Students write 3–4 minutes. No sharing of the mark itself.

IN-LESSON SCAN

OBSERVE A student who marks the far left end of the spectrum in every domain — school, sport, social — without hesitation. **MAY SIGNAL** Significant perfectionist paralysis across multiple domains is associated with elevated anxiety and is a risk factor for the self-punishment patterns that surface in U2L6. **ACTION** Note privately for counselor awareness before U2L6. Do not address in class. This student may need additional check-in before the Script Analysis worksheet.

3

The Compassionate Witness Applied to Perfectionism

8 MIN

"What would the Compassionate Witness say to a student frozen in perfectionist paralysis? Not the critic's message — what would the fair, honest, kind voice say?"

Students write one Compassionate Witness response to their perfectionist self. Optional share in pairs.

4

One Imperfect Action

5 MIN

"Identify one thing you have been avoiding due to perfectionism and commit to taking one imperfect step toward it this week. Write: 'One imperfect step I can take is ____.' This is your commitment — to yourself, not to me."

IN-LESSON SCAN

OBSERVE A student whose "one imperfect step" is still very large or still involves a perfect outcome — "I will get a B instead of a C on the next test." **MAY SIGNAL** This student's perfectionism is so entrenched that even their corrective commitment is perfectionism-shaped. The step is about effort and action, not outcome. **ACTION** Gently redirect during circulating: "What's a step that is entirely about what you do — not what happens as a result?" Do not push beyond this.

UNIT 2 · LESSON 3 · THE INTERIOR (6–8)

TEACHING TIP

Grade 6 note: Perfectionism at 6th grade often presents as "I'm lazy" rather than "I'm afraid of failure." The framing reorientation — "this is not laziness, this is terror" — is one of the most important things to land in this unit. Grades 7–8: Connect to U2L1 — the perfectionist freeze is often the internal critic using the Globalising tactic: "If I can't do it perfectly, I always fail." Naming the connection helps students see the pattern. ELL note: The freeze-and-avoid pattern resonates strongly with language-performance anxiety. Validate this explicitly.

EXIT TICKET

"One area where my perfectionism looks like laziness is _____. One imperfect step I can take is _____." Journal entry — student writes privately. Never collected. Never graded.

TEACHER REFLECTION

Common error: celebrating imperfection in a way that sounds like lowered standards. Perfectionism's opposite is not carelessness — it is healthy striving. Students who describe significant perfectionist paralysis in multiple domains should be noted for counselor awareness before U2L6.

FAMILY CONNECTION

Today students studied perfectionism — the way fear of failure can paralyze rather than motivate. At home, you can model healthy striving: "I am going to try this even though I might not do it perfectly. That's okay."

ANCHOR CHART · THE PERFECTIONISM SPECTRUM — HORIZONTAL SCALE

BUILD SPECIFICATION

LEFT END — Perfectionism: "Failure = I am worthless." Terror masquerading as ambition.

RIGHT END — Healthy Striving: "Failure = data I can learn from." High standards without self-destruction.

"What is the fear underneath the left side?"

Students mark position in journals — not on the public chart.

POST: Before class. · **KEEP:** Unit 2.

REGULATION & REPAIR STRAND

Relationship Repair · The Five-Step Repair Sequence

Accountability Without Self-Punishment

40 min · November Week 4

OBJECTIVE	Students distinguish accountability (honest reckoning that produces repair) from self-punishment (shame-based suffering that produces nothing), and apply the Friend Test to a real situation.
CASEL FOCUS	Self-Management: emotional regulation and accountability · Self-Awareness: accountability-punishment distinction
SCENARIO CARDS	Friend Test Scenario Cards — concrete school situations (Card 1 & Card 2)
QUICK REVIEW	1-2 min: "We have been building the Compassionate Witness. Today its most practical application: what do you do when you actually make a mistake? What is the difference between holding yourself accountable and punishing yourself?"

LEGAL · PPRA NOTE

PPRA Designation — All standard opt-out protocols apply. This lesson includes the Accountability vs. Self-Punishment Reflection — PPRA-designated activity. All standard opt-out protocols apply. Students who describe patterns of severe self-punishment in response to minor mistakes are at higher risk. Note privately for counselor awareness before U2L6.

ANCHOR CHART · ACCOUNTABILITY VS. SELF-PUNISHMENT — TWO-COLUMN CHART

Draw this **before class**. Add the four-step accountability structure in Step 2. **ACCOUNTABILITY:** "I made a choice that did not fit who I want to be. What do I need to do?" → Forward motion → produces repair. **SELF-PUNISHMENT:** "I am bad. I will suffer." → Focuses on self → produces nothing useful. Key insight: "**Feeling bad is not the same as taking responsibility. Action is.**"

OPENING · 3 MINUTES

"When you make a mistake, how long do you typically spend feeling bad about it versus actually fixing it? Today we look at the difference between holding yourself accountable — which produces something — and punishing yourself, which usually produces nothing."

1

The Accountability-Punishment Distinction

7 MIN

"Accountability says: I made a choice that did not fit who I want to be. What do I need to do? Self-punishment says: I am bad. I will suffer."

Point to the board. **"How does the internal critic use self-punishment? It presents suffering as evidence of taking responsibility. 'Look how bad I feel — that proves I care.' But feeling bad is not the same as taking responsibility. Action is."**

2

The Four-Step Accountability Structure

5 MIN

"What does real accountability look like?" Write on the board: "(1) Honest acknowledgment of the choice and its impact. (2) Genuine repair where possible. (3) A commitment to a different choice next time. (4) Moving on."

"Suffering is not on this list. Feeling appropriately bad — yes. Circling in shame — no."

REGULATION & REPAIR STRAND

Recovery · Three-Phase Recovery Model

3

The Friend Test

10 MIN

"Here is the Compassionate Witness calibration tool: If your best friend came to you and said, 'I did the same thing you just did' — what would you say to them?"

Students write their Friend Test answer first. **"Now say the same thing to yourself."** Pairs share Friend Test responses — not their mistake, just what they would say to a friend.

IN-LESSON SCAN

OBSERVE During the Friend Test, a student who consistently gives their friend a much gentler response than they give themselves — and who appears surprised by the gap when you point it out.

MAY SIGNAL This student has functioning empathy for others but significant self-compassion deficit. The gap is the work — and this student is ready to see it. **ACTION** This is positive engagement. Affirm quietly: "That gap you noticed — that's exactly what Unit 2 is about." No further intervention needed.

SCENARIO CARDS

FT CARD 1 The Essay · Priya Receives a C+, spends three days in self-punishment, skips feedback session. Accountability vs. self-punishment. Work through as whole class first. **FT CARD 2 The Argument · Marcus** Apologised, was forgiven — still self-punishing two weeks later. Connects to Darius from U1L2. Pairs or small groups after Card 1.

UNIT 2 · LESSON 4 · THE INTERIOR (6–8)

IN-LESSON SCAN

OBSERVE During scenario card discussion, a student who defends Marcus or Priya's self-punishment as necessary — "They should feel bad. What they did was serious." **MAY SIGNAL** This student may believe that suffering IS accountability — a deep shame-based belief that feeling bad enough is how you earn forgiveness. This belief is a risk factor for the Script Analysis in L6. **ACTION** Do not confront directly. Note the belief pattern privately. The L6 Script work may surface where this belief came from.

TEACHING TIP

This lesson is where "Compassionate Witness" first becomes a practice rather than a concept. The Friend Test is the most memorable takeaway — return to it in subsequent units when students revert to self-punishment language. Common error: framing accountability as easy or simple. Honor the difficulty: "It is genuinely hard to hold yourself accountable without punishing yourself, especially if you were raised in an environment where punishment WAS accountability."

EXIT TICKET

"The difference between accountability and self-punishment, in my own words, is _____. One time I punished myself when I could have been accountable is _____." Journal entry — student writes privately. Never collected. Never graded.

TEACHER REFLECTION

PPRA note: All standard opt-out protocols apply to the Accountability vs. Self-Punishment Reflection. Students who describe patterns of severe self-punishment in response to minor mistakes: flag for counselor awareness before U2L6.

FAMILY CONNECTION

Today students learned the difference between accountability (what produces repair) and self-punishment (what produces nothing). At home, when your child makes a mistake, model accountability: "I made a mistake. Here's what I'm doing about it. Now I'm moving on."

LEGAL · PPRA NOTE

PPRA-designated activity. The Accountability vs. Self-Punishment Reflection is PPRA-designated. All standard opt-out protocols apply. Students who describe severe self-punishment patterns in response to minor mistakes should be noted for counselor awareness before U2L6.

BUILD SPECIFICATION

ACCOUNTABILITY	SELF-PUNISHMENT
"I made a choice that did not fit who I want to be." What do I need to do? Forward motion Produces repair	"I am bad. I will suffer." Focuses on self Loops in shame Produces nothing

The four steps: (1) Honest acknowledgment · (2) Genuine repair · (3) Commitment · (4) Move on.

"Feeling bad is not the same as taking responsibility. Action is."

POST: Before class. Add four-step structure during Step 2. · **KEEP:** Unit 2. Reference in Unit 3.

The Friend Test

40 min · December Week 1

OBJECTIVE	Students deepen their Compassionate Witness practice through the Friend Test framework and apply it to a situation where they have been treating themselves with less fairness than they would treat a friend.
CASEL FOCUS	Self-Management: self-compassion as a regulation strategy · Social Awareness: applying empathy to the self
SCENARIO CARDS	Friend Test Scenario Pairs A & B — structured partner exchange
QUICK REVIEW	1–2 min: "In Lesson 4, we learned the four-step accountability structure and introduced the Friend Test. Quick: what is the Friend Test question?" (student answers) "Today we practice it — with each other. This is the lightest lesson of Unit 2. Use it to consolidate everything you've built."

ANCHOR CHART · THE FRIEND TEST — SIDE-BY-SIDE SPEECH BUBBLES

Draw this on the board **before class**. **LEFT BUBBLE:** "What I would say to my best friend in this situation."

RIGHT BUBBLE: "What I actually say to myself in this situation." Central question posted large: "**What is the gap between these two bubbles — and what does that gap tell you?**" Key message: "**The skill you already have is empathy toward friends. We are redirecting it toward yourself.**"

OPENING · 3 MINUTES

"Think about your closest friend. If they came to you in a genuinely hard moment — they had just failed something, made a mistake, been hurt — how would you talk to them? Now: is that how you talk to yourself in the same situation? Today we look at that gap."

DIRECT INSTRUCTION · STEPS 1 — 3



The Friend Test Foundation

5 MIN

"The Friend Test is simple and powerful. When your internal critic is speaking, ask: would I say this to my closest friend in the same situation? If the answer is no — the critic is not being fair. The Compassionate Witness says what you would say to the friend."

Point to both speech bubbles. "**The skill you already have is empathy toward friends. We are redirecting it toward yourself.**"

2

Partner Practice

15 MIN

"Student choice — pick someone you are comfortable with. Each of you: identify one situation where you have been hard on yourself. Share only with your partner — not the class. Your partner responds as they would respond to a friend in the EXACT SAME situation. Then switch."

Allow 12 minutes for the full exchange.

IN-LESSON SCAN

OBSERVE A student who cannot identify a single situation where they have been hard on themselves — who genuinely appears to have no access to this. **MAY SIGNAL** May indicate either healthy self-compassion (genuine — worth noting positively) or significant emotional shutdown where self-critical patterns are not accessible to conscious reflection. **ACTION** Do not press during partner work. In the journal step (Step 3), offer: "You can write about a situation where a friend was hard on themselves — and what you would say to them."

3

The Compassionate Witness Deepened

10 MIN

"Using what your partner just gave you — write a new Compassionate Witness statement about the current situation, using the Friend Test language: 'If my friend was going through this, I would say _____. So I am saying it to myself: _____'"

Allow 5 minutes of private writing. This is the primary artifact.

IN-LESSON SCAN

OBSERVE Before U2L6: notice who is unable to access any Compassionate Witness response — who genuinely cannot write a kinder internal sentence after the full Friend Test exercise. **MAY SIGNAL** A student who cannot access the Compassionate Witness after L1, L4, and now L5 may have a deeply entrenched self-critical pattern. This is the most significant risk indicator for L6. **ACTION** Raise with the counselor before U2L6 delivery — specifically flag this student as someone who may need additional support during the Script Analysis activity.

SCENARIO CARDS

FT PAIR A Sports Tryout · Jamie Didn't make the team, quits gym, stops eating well. Apply the Friend Test — what would Jamie say to her best friend? **FT PAIR B The Social Rejection · Theo** Not invited to party, saw photos online, withdrew. High-frequency for this age group. Handle with care — do not ask if this resonates personally.

TEACHING TIP

Grade 6: Students choose their own partners. Keep partner sharing light and optional. The journal is where the real work happens. Grades 7–8: "Why is it so much easier to extend compassion to others than to ourselves? What does this asymmetry tell us about how we have been taught to think about self-care?"

EXIT TICKET

"One thing I am currently being harder on myself about than I would be on my best friend is _____. My Friend Test response to myself is _____." Journal entry — student writes privately. Never collected. Never graded.

TEACHER REFLECTION

Lightest lesson of Unit 2 in terms of emotional intensity — can function as a processing and consolidation session. Before U2L6: confirm counselor co-facilitation is set. Review your observations from L1–L5 for any students who may need extra support. Students who cannot identify a Compassionate Witness response across L1, L4, and L5 are your highest-risk students for L6. Brief the counselor specifically on these students.

FAMILY CONNECTION

Today students practised the Friend Test — applying the same compassion to themselves that they naturally give to their friends. At home, when your child is being hard on themselves, try asking: "Would you say that to your best friend?" Then listen.

ANCHOR CHART · THE FRIEND TEST — SIDE-BY-SIDE SPEECH BUBBLES**BUILD SPECIFICATION**

BEST FRIEND BUBBLE	SELF BUBBLE
What I would say to my best friend Kind Fair Honest Without punishment	What I actually say to myself Often harsh Often globalising Often unfair Would never say to a friend

Central question: "What is the gap between these two bubbles — and what does that gap tell you?"

"The skill you already have is empathy toward friends. We are redirecting it toward yourself."

POST: Before class. · **KEEP:** Unit 2 and Unit 3.

Rewriting the Script

40–45 min · December Week 2

OBJECTIVE	Students examine the scripts they have inherited about their worth, capacity, and belonging — and practice the Compassionate Witness as a tool for rewriting scripts that are not serving them.
CASEL FOCUS	Self-Awareness: examining inherited self-narratives · Self-Management: building the Compassionate Witness as a sustained practice
SCENARIO CARDS	None — all work is private and worksheet-guided
QUICK REVIEW	Skip Quick Review. Begin with the OPENING RITUAL — 2 full minutes of grounding before any content.

★★ MANDATORY PRE-LESSON REQUIREMENTS

All must be met before class begins. ☐ School counselor is physically present in the room for the full lesson — NOT on-call, NOT in the hallway ☐ Crisis resources posted VISIBLY: 988 Suicide & Crisis Lifeline · Crisis Text Line: text HOME to 741741 ☐ Lesson NOT scheduled before a holiday, weekend, break, or fire-drill day ☐ No substitute teacher present — only the delivering teacher ☐ You have briefed the counselor on students who showed concerning patterns in L1–L5 ☐ You have taken 60 seconds to settle yourself before students arrive — your regulated presence is the room's most important safety tool

COUNSELOR CO-FACILITATION ROLE

Sit in a position where you can observe all students without being the centre of attention. Primary job: notice — students who stop writing, leave the room, or show visible distress. **If a student leaves the room: COUNSELOR FOLLOWS. Teacher stays with the class.** After class: mandatory same-day debrief with the teacher — regardless of whether a disclosure occurred.

OPENING · OPENING RITUAL · 4–5 MINUTES · DO NOT SHORTEN

"We all carry scripts — inherited ideas about our worth, our capacity, and whether we belong. Some of these scripts were written by people who loved us. Some were written by people who hurt us. Most were written before we were old enough to question them. Today we look at the scripts — and ask which ones we want to keep."

Pause after this opening. Allow 30 seconds of silence. The counselor holds the room with you.

1

What Scripts Are

6 MIN

"A script is a narrative we carry about ourselves that we treat as true without examining it. 'I am not smart enough.' 'I do not belong here.' 'I always mess things up.' Scripts often originated in specific experiences or relationships — but they generalise. They spread from one context to everything."

Write these three example scripts on the board. **"Notice: none of these scripts have your name on them. But many of you know exactly what your script says."**

WORKSHEET

Script Analysis Worksheet U2·L6 · Private Primary Activity · ★★ Highest Risk Lesson **Critical:** Students work ONLY from the worksheet structure. Five sections: (1) A script I carry. (2) Where it came from. (3) Evidence that contradicts it. (4) What it costs me to keep it. (5) A more accurate, fair version. **Never collected. Never shared with anyone including the teacher.**

2

Script Analysis · Primary Activity

18 MIN

"The worksheet in front of you has five sections. Work through each one, in order, privately. I will not be reading what you write. The counselor will not be reading what you write. This belongs to you."

Students work completely independently. No pairs. No sharing. Teacher steps back from the centre of the room.

IN-LESSON SCAN

OBSERVE A student who stops writing after section 2 (where the script came from) and stares or puts their head down. **MAY SIGNAL** Identifying the origin of a script — a person, an experience, a system — can be more activating than naming the script itself. The origin may involve abuse, trauma, or systemic harm. **ACTION** Counselor approaches quietly. Teacher remains with the class. Counselor: "You don't have to write more than you have. Section 5 is the most important — write a word, any word, that is fairer." Follow your disclosure protocol if the student speaks.

IN-LESSON SCAN

OBSERVE A student who leaves the room during the Script Analysis. **MAY SIGNAL** This is the highest-disclosure-risk lesson of Semester 1. Leaving during the private writing portion is a significant signal. **ACTION** Counselor follows immediately. Teacher stays with class. Say to class: "Keep working." Do not draw attention. Counselor follows established protocol.

3

Rewriting with the Compassionate Witness

8 MIN

"The Compassionate Witness does not deny the pain that wrote the script. It does not pretend the experience did not happen. It asks: Is this script still serving me? What would a more accurate, fair script say?"

Students write an alternative script in one sentence. **"It does not have to feel true yet. Writing it is the beginning of making space for it."**

UNIT 2 · LESSON 6 · THE INTERIOR (6–8)

IN-LESSON SCAN

OBSERVE A student who tears up or covers their worksheet, or who appears very still and withdrawn during Step 3. **MAY SIGNAL** The alternative script — the more accurate, fair version — may be the first time this student has ever considered that their inherited script might not be true. That realization can be destabilizing before it is liberating. **ACTION** Do not retrieve. Do not approach to console — this can amplify. Hold the room. Counselor monitors. After class: mandatory debrief protocol.

TEACHING TIP

What to say (post these on your desk during this lesson): **"You do not have to share anything. This is entirely private."** **"One sentence is enough. You do not have to explain where it came from."** **"The Compassionate Witness does not have to feel true yet. Writing it is the beginning."** **What NOT to say:** "Can you tell me more about where that script came from?" · Do not probe. "Share what you wrote with your partner." · Never for this lesson. "Who wrote that script for you?" · Do not probe origins.

EXIT TICKET

"A script I carry that is not serving me is _____. A more accurate, fair version is _____." · Allow 4 full minutes. Do not rush the close. Journal entry — student writes privately. Never collected. Never graded.

AFTER CLASS — MANDATORY SAME-DAY DEBRIEF.

Teacher and counselor debrief the same day. Discuss: any students who left the room, any visible distress, any content shared voluntarily. Counselor follows up individually with flagged students before Unit 3 begins. Teacher writes a private note of any significant observations — not in a gradebook, not in a shared system. Teacher uses their own restorative practice tonight. This lesson costs something. That is it working.

TEACHER REFLECTION

This is the highest-disclosure-risk lesson of the first semester. Your regulated nervous system is the room's most important safety tool. After this lesson: brief your counselor — for your own state, not just for student disclosures. See Section 4 — Teacher Wellbeing for the full protocol for what this lesson commonly produces for delivering teachers.

FAMILY CONNECTION

Today was one of the most significant lessons of the year. The school counselor co-facilitated. Your child examined scripts they carry about themselves — inherited ideas about their worth and belonging.

If they seem reflective or heavy this evening, that is healthy. If they seem distressed, please contact the counselor directly.

LEGAL · PPRA NOTE

★★ **Highest risk lesson.** Counselor co-facilitation required. Safe messaging guidelines apply throughout. Do not schedule before any break. Do not allow a substitute teacher. Crisis resources must be visibly posted. **Mandatory** same-day counselor debrief regardless of whether disclosure occurred.

ANCHOR CHART · NO NEW ANCHOR CHART — CRISIS RESOURCES VISIBLY POSTED

BUILD SPECIFICATION

988 Suicide & Crisis Lifeline — Call or text 988

Crisis Text Line — Text HOME to 741741

Your school counselor — Name: _____ Contact: _____

Post at student eye level. Visible from every seat. No other new visual for this lesson.

POST: Before U2L6. Counselor physically in room first. · **KEEP:** ☹ Permanent — rest of the year.

Unit 2 Reflection & Bridge to Unit 3

40 min · December Week 3

OBJECTIVE	Students consolidate Unit 2 learning, write a final Compassionate Witness statement, and prepare to apply self-compassion toward others in Unit 3.
CASEL FOCUS	Self-Awareness (synthesis) · Self-Management: setting intentions for Unit 3
SCENARIO CARDS	None — synthesis and bridge lesson
QUICK REVIEW	1–2 min: Display all Unit 2 anchor charts. "Look at what this class has built in seven weeks. Internal Critic. Three tactics. Compassionate Witness. Highlight Reels. Perfectionism. Friend Test. Scripts. Take 30 seconds — name your biggest Unit 2 takeaway in one word." Students write one word in journals. Take 4–5 shared words.

ANCHOR CHART · ALL UNIT 2 ANCHOR CHARTS DISPLAYED SIMULTANEOUSLY

Post all Unit 2 anchor charts visible at the same time before class begins. This is the visible record of everything Unit 2 asked of this class. Return U2L1 journals (where students wrote the specific words of their internal critic) before class begins.

OPENING · 3 MINUTES

Return the journals from U2L1 where students wrote the specific words of their internal critic. Ask: "Read what you wrote then. Is any of it still true? Is any of it different? Has the critic changed — even slightly?" Students write 4 minutes. No sharing required.

DIRECT INSTRUCTION · STEPS 1 — 3

IN-LESSON SCAN

OBSERVE As students re-read their U2L1 journal entry, a student whose posture or expression shifts significantly — relief, sadness, or recognition of distance traveled. **MAY SIGNAL** The gap between who they were in November and who they are now after U2L6 is sometimes more visible to the student than they expected. **ACTION** Hold the room quietly. Allow the emotion. Do not rush to Step 1. "Take your time." This is the curriculum doing its work.

1

The Compassionate Witness Statement · Synthesis

12 MIN

"Write your final Compassionate Witness statement for Unit 2: 'My Compassionate Witness sounds like: ___, and it knows: ___, and it says: ___.'"

Allow 8 minutes of writing. Then share in pairs — not as a full class.

"What you are sharing with your partner today is evidence of growth. It is not a performance — it is a record."

2

The Transfer Question

8 MIN

"Imagine using your Compassionate Witness to look at someone else — someone who hurt you, or who you have difficulty with. What would it see? What would it say about what that person was carrying when they hurt you?"

Students journal privately for 5 minutes. No sharing.

"You do not have to like what it says. But notice: the same voice that sees you fairly can see others fairly. We will talk in Unit 3 about what to do with it."

IN-LESSON SCAN

OBSERVE During the Transfer Question, a student who immediately writes with intensity or who appears visibly distressed at the prompt. **MAY SIGNAL** This student may be working with a specific, significant harm. The Transfer Question is not asking for forgiveness — but it can surface unprocessed material that is already present. **ACTION** Do not interrupt the writing. After class: note for counselor before Unit 3 Lesson 1. Brief the counselor that this student may enter Unit 3 with active material.

3

Bridge Framing

6 MIN

"In Unit 2, we practised extending compassion to ourselves after mistakes. That was the hardest unit of the first semester. You did that work. In Unit 3, we turn that same capacity outward — toward the people who have hurt us. That work is only possible because of what you built here. We are building, not starting over."

WORKSHEET

Compassionate Witness Statement U2·L7 · Synthesis Artifact "My Compassionate Witness sounds like: ___, and it knows: ___, and it says: ___." Plus the Transfer Question and one intention for Unit 3. Artifact — students keep this. Teacher may collect with permission.

SAFETY CHECK

Distribute Family Mid-Year Survey and Unit 3 Family Transition Letter today. Brief the counselor before Unit 3 Lesson 1 — share observations about which students carry the most emotional load into second semester. Build a shared monitoring plan for Unit 3 together — this is the most emotionally weighted unit of the year. The Transfer Question occasionally surfaces acute situations. Brief the counselor on any student who appeared activated.

EXIT TICKET

"The most important thing I am taking from Unit 2 into Unit 3 is ____." Journal entry — student writes privately. Never collected. Never graded.

TEACHER REFLECTION

This is the most emotionally weighted bridge of the year. Students who struggled significantly in Unit 2 should be on your radar going into Unit 3. The Transfer Question (Step 2) is the conceptual hinge of the year — the shift from self-compassion to generosity toward others. Do not rush it. Collect bridge exit tickets and review privately before Unit 3 Lesson 1. Flag any student whose ticket reveals acute material for counselor awareness.

FAMILY CONNECTION

Your child is transitioning from Unit 2 (self-compassion) to Unit 3 (empathy and forgiveness). This is the largest conceptual shift of the year. The Family Mid-Year Survey is coming home today — your anonymous responses genuinely help us improve the second half of the year.

LEGAL · PPRA NOTE

Family Mid-Year Survey (Instrument G) distributed today. Unit 3 Family Transition Letter distributed today. Brief the counselor before Unit 3 Lesson 1 with your observations about which students carry the most emotional load into second semester.

ANCHOR CHART · ALL UNIT 2 CHARTS DISPLAYED SIMULTANEOUSLY**BUILD SPECIFICATION**

1. Internal Critic — Three Tactics + Compassionate Witness
2. Highlight Reel vs. Blooper Reel · 3. Perfectionism Spectrum
4. Accountability vs. Self-Punishment · 5. Friend Test Speech Bubbles

Return U2L1 journals before this lesson. Allow silent scanning before any talking.

POST: All Unit 2 charts simultaneously. · **KEEP:** Display for U2L7.

UNIT 3

Empathy & Forgiving Others

*“How do I deal with the hurt other people cause — without
being destroyed by it?”*

JANUARY – MARCH · 7 LESSONS · 40-45 MIN EACH

Impact vs. Intent

40 min · January Week 2

OBJECTIVE	Students explain the impact/intent distinction and demonstrate that impact is what is addressed in repair, regardless of intent.
CASEL FOCUS	Social Awareness: impact vs. intent · Relationship Skills: navigating harm and accountability
SCENARIO CARDS	Impact/Intent Cards A, B & C — analyse intent vs. impact, then identify repair
QUICK REVIEW	1–2 min: "Welcome to Unit 3. We have spent two units looking inward. Now we turn outward — to the people who have hurt you, and the people you have hurt. First lesson: one of the most important distinctions in human relationships. Impact vs. intent."

UNIT 3 STANDING SAFETY NOTE — READ BEFORE L1, RETURN BEFORE EVERY LESSON.

Unit 3 asks students to explore empathy and forgiveness toward people who have hurt them. It does NOT ask students to understand, excuse, or forgive anyone who is currently harming them. Forgiveness is never required of students in situations involving ongoing harm or injustice. If at any point a student's responses suggest they may be in an ongoing harmful situation, pause the lesson and follow the Disclosure Protocol (Section 4 — Legal & Clinical Compliance).

ANCHOR CHART · IMPACT VS. INTENT — TWO-PANEL DIAGRAM

Draw this **before class**. Keep posted for the **full unit**. **LEFT PANEL — INTENT:** What was in the mind of the person who acted. **RIGHT PANEL — IMPACT:** What was experienced by the person who was affected. Bold line between them. Below: "**Both are real. Only one determines what repair addresses.**" **The foot analogy:** "If I accidentally step on your foot — I didn't intend it. But your foot hurts, and my responsibility is for that impact."

OPENING · 3 MINUTES

"Has anyone ever hurt someone without meaning to — and been told that your good intentions mean you do not have to take responsibility? Or been hurt and told to 'just get over it' because the other person didn't mean it? Today we look at why this matters so much."

1 Define the Distinction

8 MIN

"Intent is what was in the mind of the person who acted. Impact is what was experienced by the person who was affected. These are two different things. Both are real. Only one determines what needs to be repaired."

Point to the diagram. **"The foot analogy: If I accidentally step on your foot, I did not intend to hurt you. But your foot hurts — and my responsibility is for that impact, even when my intent was not harmful."**

IN-LESSON SCAN

OBSERVE During the impact/intent definition, a student who physically sits back or crosses their arms when the "impact is what repair addresses" principle is stated. **MAY SIGNAL** This student may currently be in a position where they are being told their impact doesn't count because of good intent — or may have used good intent to avoid accountability themselves. **ACTION** Do not address directly. Note privately. This concept is foundational to Unit 3 — monitor how this student engages with L3 (forgiveness vs. reconciliation).

2 Scenario Card Analysis

15 MIN

"For each scenario: Name the intent. Name the impact. Which one does repair address? What does repair look like?"

Work Card A as a whole class — all four questions together. Then pairs on Card B. Debrief on Card C if time allows. Allow home-language pair discussion for ELL students before English written output.

EQUITY ALERT — DELIVER EXPLICITLY. NOT OPTIONAL.

"Students who have experienced racial microaggressions are frequently told that because intent was not harmful, impact was not real. That is not accurate — and it matters." Deliver explicitly: "Sometimes people say 'I didn't mean it that way' as if that ends the conversation. It doesn't. Impact is what happened to you — and impact is what repair addresses." Do NOT ask students whether they have personally experienced this. Keep anchored to the principle.

3 Application

7 MIN

"Think of one situation in your current life where impact and intent were different. What happened? Which was addressed? What was left unaddressed?"

Students write privately for 4–5 minutes. No sharing required. Observe the room — this is the first emotional application step of Unit 3.

IN-LESSON SCAN

OBSERVE During the private application step, a student whose writing pace is intense and sustained — filling a full page quickly. **MAY SIGNAL** This student may have a specific, significant situation in mind. The intensity suggests this is not abstract for them. **ACTION** Note privately. Do not approach during writing. If the student lingers after class or approaches you, follow the disclosure protocol.

UNIT 3 · LESSON 1 · THE INTERIOR (6–8)

SCENARIO CARDS

CARD A The Missed Invitation Layla forgot Nadia at a hangout. Nadia is devastated. Whole-class model. Foundational concept — confirm before closing. **CARD B The Joke That Landed Wrong** Theo's joke had a cultural meaning he didn't know. Equity alert embedded. Use carefully — do not ask students to identify personally. **CARD C The Group Project** Cameron took over, group got high grade, two members felt invisible. Best for Grade 8 — positive outcome does not erase harmful impact.

EXIT TICKET

"The difference between impact and intent is _____. A situation where I experienced impact without harmful intent was _____. What repair looks like is _____." Journal entry — student writes privately. Never collected. Never graded.

TEACHER REFLECTION

Impact/intent is the foundational concept of Unit 3 — everything in L2–L7 builds on it. Do not abbreviate Step 1. The equity alert is not optional. Deliver it explicitly — not as a footnote after the scenarios. Review student journals for acute personal applications before L2.

FAMILY CONNECTION

Today students learned one of the most important concepts of the year: impact vs. intent. At home, this can transform conflict conversations: instead of defending intent, try acknowledging impact. "I didn't mean it that way — and I can see it landed hard. What can I do?"

ANCHOR CHART · IMPACT VS. INTENT — TWO-PANEL DIAGRAM

BUILD SPECIFICATION

INTENT	IMPACT
What was in the mind of the person who acted Matters for understanding Does NOT determine what repair addresses	What was experienced by the person affected Determines what repair addresses Both are real — only one drives repair

The foot analogy: "I accidentally stepped on your foot — I didn't intend it. But your foot hurts. My responsibility is for that impact."

"Both are real. Only one determines what repair addresses." Keep posted all of Unit 3.

POST: Before class. · **KEEP:** All of Unit 3.

Three Sides of Every Story

40 min · January Week 3

OBJECTIVE	Students practice perspective-taking by articulating three views of a conflict and explain how the compassionate observer perspective differs from both parties.
CASEL FOCUS	Social Awareness: perspective-taking · Relationship Skills: understanding conflict from multiple viewpoints
SCENARIO CARDS	Three Sides Cards A & B — friendship drift and teacher complaint scenarios
QUICK REVIEW	1-2 min: "Last lesson: impact vs. intent — which one does repair address? (student answers: impact) Today we go one step further: what happens when two people are both telling the truth about the same conflict, and both of their stories are only partial?"

EQUITY ALERT — DELIVER EXPLICITLY. NOT OPTIONAL.

Deliver this before worksheet work — not after: "Perspective-taking across cultural lines requires acknowledging that positions in a conflict are not always symmetric." "Seeing someone's perspective is not agreeing with what they did. You can fully understand someone's side and still be clear that what they did was wrong." "Understanding a perspective is not endorsing it."

ANCHOR CHART · THREE SIDES OF EVERY STORY — TRIANGLE DIAGRAM

Draw this triangle **before class**. Keep posted through L3. **POINT 1:** Your side — what you experienced, felt, needed. **POINT 2:** Their side — what they experienced, felt, needed. **POINT 3:** The Compassionate Observer — someone who cares about both people and sees what neither can from where they stand. Label the centre: "**The third side is the hardest — and the most important.**"

OPENING · 2 MINUTES

"Is it possible for two people to have a conflict, both be telling the truth, and both be telling a story that is only partial? Today we look at what happens when we step outside our own perspective — not to excuse the other person, but to understand more fully."

I

The Three Sides Framework

7 MIN

"Every conflict has three sides. (1) Your side — what you experienced, felt, needed. (2) The other person's side — what they experienced, felt, needed. (3) What a compassionate observer — someone who cares about both people — would see. The third side is the most important and the hardest to access."

WORKSHEET

Three Sides Worksheet U3·L2 · Primary Activity Three clearly labeled sections: (1) Your side, (2) Their side, (3) Compassionate Observer. Grade 6: teacher-provided scenario only. Grades 7–8: personal application optional. The Compassionate Observer column needs the most time — protect it.

2

Three Sides Worksheet · Primary Activity

20 MIN

Grade 6: Teacher models Side 1 aloud. Ask students to generate ideas for Side 2. Guide toward Side 3. Students complete using the provided scenario.

Grades 7–8: Students may apply to a chosen situation — provided scenario is the default.

The Compassionate Observer takes the most time. If time is short, shorten Sides 1 and 2 to protect Side 3.

IN-LESSON SCAN

OBSERVE A student who writes extensively in Sides 1 and 2 but leaves Side 3 (Compassionate Observer) blank or writes "I don't know." **MAY SIGNAL** The Compassionate Observer perspective requires the ability to step outside one's own position — this is developmentally harder for some students than the curriculum assumes. Not a failure; a developmental data point. **ACTION** Approach quietly: "The Compassionate Observer doesn't pick a side — they just name what both people were carrying. What was each person afraid of?" This reframe often unlocks the column.

IN-LESSON SCAN

OBSERVE A student who writes a personal scenario in Grades 7–8 application that appears to involve ongoing harm rather than a completed conflict. **MAY SIGNAL** The Three Sides framework is designed for completed or static conflicts. Ongoing harm requires the disclosure protocol, not the perspective-taking worksheet. **ACTION** Approach quietly after class: "I noticed your scenario felt current. Can we talk?" Follow the disclosure protocol if the situation warrants it.

SCENARIO CARDS

CARD A The Broken Friendship Kezia and Priya — friendship drift. "Abandoned" vs. "too clingy." High-frequency for Grades 6–7. Do not ask students if this maps to their own friendships. **CARD B The Teacher Complaint** Marcus vs. teacher — both partially right. Authority figure on one side — handle carefully. "The observer's view doesn't cancel either person's experience."

UNIT 3 · LESSON 2 · THE INTERIOR (6–8)

TEACHING TIP

Grade 6: Use a provided scenario only. Model the three columns explicitly before students begin. "Seeing their side doesn't mean agreeing with it." Grades 7–8: Students may apply to a situation they choose — provided scenario is the default. The personal application option is offered, not required.

EXIT TICKET

"A situation in my life where I have only occupied one side is _____. What the other person's side might include is _____." Journal entry — student writes privately. Never collected. Never graded.

TEACHER REFLECTION

The Compassionate Observer column is the hardest — and the most important. Do not abbreviate it. Equity note: perspectives across cultural lines are not always symmetric. Deliver the equity alert before the worksheet — not after.

FAMILY CONNECTION

Today students practised seeing a conflict from multiple perspectives — including a perspective outside both parties. This skill is rare and powerful. You can reinforce it at home: when your child describes a conflict, ask: "What do you think the other person's side was?"

ANCHOR CHART · THREE SIDES OF EVERY STORY — TRIANGLE DIAGRAM

BUILD SPECIFICATION

Point 1: Your side — what you experienced, felt, needed.

Point 2: Their side — what they experienced, felt, needed.

Point 3 (top ★): The Compassionate Observer — someone who cares about both people, sees what neither can.

"Seeing someone's perspective is not agreeing with what they did." Keep through U3L3.

POST: Before class. · **KEEP:** Through U3L3.

REGULATION & REPAIR STRAND

Boundary-Setting · Limit Language After Non-Reconciliation

Forgiveness vs. Reconciliation

40–45 min · February Week 1

OBJECTIVE	Students distinguish forgiveness (an internal psychological process) from reconciliation (the restoration of a relationship), and articulate that forgiveness is never required in situations involving ongoing harm.
CASEL FOCUS	Self-Management: emotional regulation through forgiveness · Relationship Skills: forgiveness vs. reconciliation distinction
SCENARIO CARDS	Forgiveness Card A (The Betrayal) · Forgiveness Card B (The Family Situation — use with caution)
QUICK REVIEW	Skip Quick Review. Begin with the full opening ritual — 2 full minutes. Then deliver the standing statement.

★★ MANDATORY PRE-LESSON REQUIREMENTS

All must be met before class begins. ☐ Counselor is on-site or immediately available (reachable within 60 seconds) for the full lesson ☐ Crisis resources remain visibly posted from U2L6 ☐ No substitute teacher present. This lesson specifically addresses safety in relationships. ☐ Lesson NOT scheduled within 24 hours of a school-wide safety incident or conflict-heavy event

ANCHOR CHART · FORGIVENESS VS. RECONCILIATION — COLOR-CODED T-CHART

Draw **before class**. Color-code the two columns — one color for Forgiveness, a different color for Reconciliation. **FORGIVENESS column:** Internal psychological process. Choosing to release resentment — for your own sake, not theirs. **RECONCILIATION column:** The restoration of a relationship. A separate, external decision. Bold dividing line. Below: "**These are two separate things. You can have one without the other.**" Build the chart slowly **with student input** during Step 1.

OPENING · 2 MINUTES

"Before we begin today, I need to say something clearly that we will come back to throughout this lesson: forgiveness is never required in situations involving ongoing harm. That sentence is the most important thing in today's lesson. Write it down."

Pause. Allow students to write. Then proceed to Step 1.

1

The Most Important Distinction of Unit 3

10 MIN

Build the T-chart **with** student input.

"Forgiveness is an internal psychological process — choosing to release resentment for your own sake, not for the person who hurt you." Write on Forgiveness side.

"Reconciliation is the restoration of a relationship. These are two SEPARATE things." Write on Reconciliation side.

"You can forgive someone and still choose never to be in a relationship with them again."

2

What Forgiveness Is NOT — Say This Explicitly

5 MIN

Say each line aloud. Write each on the board:

"Forgiveness is NOT condoning." · "Forgiveness is NOT pretending the harm didn't happen." · "Forgiveness is NOT reconciliation." · "Forgiveness is NOT weakness." · "Forgiveness is NOT something you OWE the person who hurt you."

Then: **"This curriculum NEVER requires forgiveness in situations involving ongoing harm or injustice. Write that in your journal."**

IN-LESSON SCAN

OBSERVE During the "forgiveness is NOT something you owe" statement, a student who appears visibly relieved — a physical relaxation, a released breath, a look of recognition. **MAY SIGNAL** This student may have been carrying a belief that they are required to forgive someone who harmed them. The relief is the curriculum doing its most important work in this lesson. **ACTION** Hold the room carefully. Do not name the student. After class: "I noticed today landed for you. I'm available if you want to talk." Note for counselor.

3

Scenario Card Analysis

15 MIN

Run minimum TWO scenarios. Card A as whole class. Card B with counselor present ONLY — see note below.

For each: **"Is forgiveness appropriate? Is reconciliation appropriate? Can you have one without the other?"** Work through all four discussion questions.

SAFETY CHECK

Watch for: Student indicates pressure to resume a relationship they left for safety reasons. Student discloses ongoing harm framed as a forgiveness question. Student becomes rigid or withdrawn when "reconciliation" is introduced. Student challenges "forgiveness never required" in ways suggesting they've been told they must forgive someone currently harming them. **If any occur:** Pause the scenario work. Signal the counselor. Do not attempt to resolve the situation yourself. **Card B (The Family Situation):** Do NOT use if your class has a student you know is in an ongoing harmful family situation. Skip to Card A only.

UNIT 3 · LESSON 3 · THE INTERIOR (6–8)

SCENARIO CARDS

CARD A The Betrayal Darius forgave his closest friend, no longer carries resentment — but has no desire to rebuild the friendship. Whole-class. Primary card for the core distinction. Do NOT ask for personal forgiveness situations. **CARD B The Family Situation** Adult pressuring forgiveness toward family member who has not changed the harmful behaviour. **High sensitivity.** Use with counselor present only. Skip if any student is in an ongoing harmful family situation.

TEACHING TIP

Grade 6: Build the T-chart together as a class — do not ask students to generate the distinction independently. Grades 7–8: "Is it possible to respect yourself and the person who hurt you at the same time — without requiring reconciliation? What does that look like in practice?"

EXIT TICKET

"The difference between forgiveness and reconciliation is _____. One situation where I could forgive without reconciling is _____." Journal entry — student writes privately. Never collected. Never graded.

MANDATORY SAME-DAY COUNSELOR BRIEF

After this lesson — even if no disclosure occurred. Tell the counselor: the room's emotional register, any students who seemed significantly activated, any content shared voluntarily that warrants follow-up.

TEACHER REFLECTION

The standing statement — "forgiveness is never required in situations involving ongoing harm" — must be delivered before any scenario work. It is the most important sentence in this lesson. The distinction between forgiveness and reconciliation is the single most important concept of Unit 3. Do not abbreviate it. Same-day counselor debrief is mandatory regardless of disclosure.

FAMILY CONNECTION

Today students learned one of the most important conceptual distinctions of the year: forgiveness and reconciliation are not the same thing. Your child does not have to resume a relationship or pretend harm did not happen in order to forgive. Please reinforce this at home.

LEGAL · PPRA NOTE

★ **High risk.** Counselor on-site required (within 60 seconds, full lesson). No substitute. Do not schedule within 24 hours of a school-wide safety incident. **Mandatory** same-day counselor brief after this lesson.

ANCHOR CHART · FORGIVENESS VS. RECONCILIATION — COLOR-CODED T-CHART

BUILD SPECIFICATION

FORGIVENESS	RECONCILIATION
Internal psychological process Releasing resentment for your own sake Requires nothing from the other person An internal act	Restoration of a relationship Separate, external decision Not required by forgiveness A relational act

"You can forgive someone and still choose never to be in a relationship with them again."

"This curriculum never requires forgiveness in situations involving ongoing harm." Post large.

POST: Before class. Color-code the two columns. · **KEEP:** All of Unit 3.

The Digital Echo

40 min · February Week 2

OBJECTIVE	Students distinguish between reacting and responding in digital conflict, identify amplification mechanisms, and articulate one disengagement strategy.
CASEL FOCUS	Responsible Decision-Making: responding vs. reacting in digital conflict · Social Awareness: how digital environments amplify harm
SCENARIO CARDS	Digital Cards A (The Screenshot), B (The Group Chat), C (The Callout Post)
QUICK REVIEW	1–2 min: "If time ran short in L3, run one remaining forgiveness/reconciliation card now." (Otherwise): "Last lesson: forgiveness and reconciliation are not the same thing. Quick — name one thing forgiveness IS NOT." Today: digital conflict.

ANCHOR CHART · FLAME VS. PAUSE — REACT VS. RESPOND · 🌐 PERMANENT (POST NOW, KEEP ALL YEAR)

Draw on chart paper and **post permanently** — this stays up for the rest of the year. **FLAME:** React — feeding the fire. Fast. Emotion-driven. Makes it worse. **PAUSE:** Respond — **"What do I actually want to happen here?"** **Four-step Pause sequence** (add these as you teach Step 2): 1. Stop before sending/posting. 2. Ask: What do I actually want to happen? 3. Consider: What will this cause? 4. Choose your minimum effective response — or disengage entirely.

OPENING · 3 MINUTES

"Before saying anything else, write in your journal for 90 seconds — silently: Has anyone ever responded to something online — a text, a comment, a post — and made it worse? What happened?"

After 90 seconds: "You do not have to share what you wrote. But almost every hand in this room could have gone up. That pattern is what we are examining today."

DIRECT INSTRUCTION · STEPS 1 — 3



The Digital Echo

8 MIN

"Write ECHO on the board. What happens to a sound when it echoes in a canyon?" (repeats, comes back louder, keeps going) "Digital conflict works the same way."

Draw the echo chain. **"What makes digital conflict different from the exact same conflict in person?"**

Listen for: permanence, spread, audience collapse, asynchronous response. Add to echo chain.

2

React vs. Respond

8 MIN

"Draw two columns: REACT / RESPOND. Build the chart together." Key: "Every minute you wait before responding in a digital conflict is a minute you are moving from React to Respond."

Post and walk through the Flame vs. Pause visual and the four-step Pause sequence. **"The flame icon: react — feeding the fire. The pause icon: respond — what do I actually want to happen here?"**

IN-LESSON SCAN

OBSERVE A student who during the React column building begins listing items in a way that is very specific and personal — real-time, not hypothetical. **MAY SIGNAL** This student may be in or recently out of an active digital conflict. The specificity of their contributions is data. **ACTION** Do not single out. After class: "I noticed some of today felt very current for you. I'm available if you want to talk." Note for counselor if the situation sounds ongoing or escalating.

3

Scenario Card Analysis

15 MIN

"Small groups. 2–3 cards. For each: What is the digital echo mechanism? What would REACT produce? What would RESPOND look like? Is the right move to respond at all — or disengage entirely?"

Groups share one scenario. Teacher summarises: **"The echo dies when no one feeds it."**

EQUITY ALERT — DELIVER EXPLICITLY. NOT OPTIONAL.

Deliver before scenario debrief — not at the end: "Not everyone carries the same risk in a digital conflict. For some of you, something going wrong online has consequences that go way beyond your social circle — it can affect your safety, your family's safety, how teachers treat you, whether an employer sees it years from now." "That is not fair. And it is real. For students carrying more risk, the bar for disengaging entirely is lower. You do not have to stay in a digital conflict that is putting you in danger."

SCENARIO CARDS

CARD A The Screenshot Layla's private message shared widely. "Minimum effective response" concept — key takeaway. **CARD B The Group Chat** Mockery chain, bystander role. Equity note: consider who is most likely to be the person mocked. **CARD C The Callout Post** Partially inaccurate public callout. Grades 7–8. Public accountability vs. public attack.

TEACHING TIP

Grade 6: Focus on Flame vs. Pause as a concrete daily tool. Keep scenarios school-context-based. Audience collapse may need scaffolding. Grades 7–8: Introduce the **"minimum effective response"** concept for Card A. Card C (Callout Post) is Grade 8 appropriate. Channel strong opinions into the framework.

EXIT TICKET

"Describe one strategy you would use if you found yourself in a digital conflict tomorrow — and explain why that strategy falls in the 'respond' column rather than the 'react' column." Journal entry — student writes privately. Never collected. Never graded.

TEACHER REFLECTION

Flame vs. Pause poster is now permanent — make sure it is placed where students can see it from their seats. The equity alert is not optional. Students who carry higher risk in digital conflict need to hear it explicitly. The "minimum effective response" concept is the most transferable skill of this lesson — do not skip it.

FAMILY CONNECTION

Today students studied digital conflict and the Flame vs. Pause framework. At home, model the pause before responding online: "Let me think about what I actually want to happen before I say anything."

ANCHOR CHART · FLAME VS. PAUSE — REACT VS. RESPOND ☹️ PERMANENT**BUILD SPECIFICATION**

FLAME · REACT	PAUSE · RESPOND
Feeding the fire Fast Emotion-driven Makes it worse	"What do I actually want to happen here?" Slow Considered Minimum effective response or disengage

Four steps: (1) Stop · (2) Ask: what do I want? · (3) Consider: what will this cause? · (4) Choose: minimum effective response or disengage.

"The echo dies when no one feeds it." Post permanently from this lesson forward.

POST: Day 1 of U3L4. Permanent from this point. · **KEEP:** ☹️ Permanent — rest of the year.

The Rumour & Narrative Hijack

40 min · February Week 3

OBJECTIVE	Students understand how rumours hijack personal narratives and practice strategies for reclaiming narrative ownership.
CASEL FOCUS	Self-Awareness: narrative identity under social pressure · Self-Management: responding to narrative distortion without retaliation
SCENARIO CARDS	None — the Narrative Reclaim worksheet is the primary private activity
QUICK REVIEW	1-2 min: "Quick check: what is the Flame vs. Pause visual for?" (student answers) "Today we look at a specific kind of digital and social conflict that uses the echo mechanism against your identity: the rumour."

EQUITY ALERT — DELIVER EXPLICITLY. NOT OPTIONAL.

Deliver early — before the worksheet, not after: "Rumours are not equally damaging to everyone in this room. For students who are already in a less powerful social position — because of race, language, immigration status, economic circumstances, or how you are perceived by teachers — a rumour does not just cost you socially." "It can affect your physical safety. It can change how adults in this building treat you. It can follow you in ways it does not follow other students. That is a real injustice. We are naming it directly." Do NOT ask for responses to this statement. Deliver it and move immediately to the opening.

OPENING · 3 MINUTES

"Write privately for 90 seconds: Has anyone ever had a story told about them that was not true — or was partially true but wildly distorted? What did it feel like to watch that story spread?"

After writing: "You do not need to share. But hold that experience as we go through today — because this is not theoretical."

DIRECT INSTRUCTION · STEPS 1 — 4



How Rumours Work

7 MIN

"A rumour is a story told about you by people who do not know the full truth — and who are not primarily concerned with the full truth. Rumours spread because they are interesting, serve someone's social purpose, or fill an information vacuum."

Ask: **"Why do people spread rumours?"** Listen for: power, shifting attention, bonding at another's expense.

"None of those reasons have anything to do with whether the rumour is true."

2

The Narrative Hijack

7 MIN

"When a rumour spreads, it takes over the narrative others hold about you. Someone else is telling your story — and telling it wrong. The real danger of a rumour is not what others believe — it is what you start to believe about yourself."

Write on the board: **"The rumour is not you. It is a story someone else is telling."**

WORKSHEET

WS8: Narrative Reclaim U3-L5 · Primary Private Activity Five sections: (1) The rumour or distorted narrative. (2) What is true in this, if anything. (3) What is false or distorted. (4) Who knows the accurate version. (5) What you want people to know. **Never collected. Never shared.** Students do NOT share which rumour they are working with.

3

Narrative Reclaim Worksheet

13 MIN

"Work individually and privately. You do not have to share which rumour or distorted narrative you are working with."

Circulate silently. If student staring at page: move quietly — **"You can work with a general label or narrative people hold about you — it doesn't have to be specific."**

If content suggests ongoing targeting or safety risk: follow disclosure protocol after class.

IN-LESSON SCAN

OBSERVE A student who writes very little or seems unable to complete any section of the worksheet despite appearing engaged. **MAY SIGNAL** May indicate the student is currently in the middle of an active rumour situation that is too raw and recent to analyse — or that the situation involves people in the room. **ACTION** Do not press. Note privately. Approach after class: "Today felt close to home — I noticed that. I'm available." Note for counselor if ongoing targeting is suspected.

4

Character Is the Counter-Narrative

5 MIN

"You cannot control what people say. You cannot delete what has been shared. But you have one counter-narrative that is always available: your behaviour over time. Character is demonstrated, not declared."

"The people who watch you act with integrity over time — even when the rumour is still out there — will know the true version. And those are the people whose knowledge matters most."

IN-LESSON SCAN

OBSERVE A student who cannot complete Section 5 (what I want people to know) — who stares at the page or writes and crosses out. **MAY SIGNAL** This student may feel so stripped of narrative ownership that they cannot articulate what the true version is. This is a significant wellbeing signal. **ACTION** After class: "You did the hardest part — you named the distortion. Section 5 doesn't have to be finished today. What would you want your closest friend to know about you?" Note for counselor.

EXIT TICKET

"A narrative others hold about me that distorts who I actually am is _____. The true version — the one my actions over time will demonstrate — is _____." Journal entry — student writes privately. Never collected. Never graded.

TEACHER REFLECTION

The equity alert must come before the worksheet — not as a closing note. Students who carry higher social risk need to hear it before they start writing. WS8 is private. Circulate but never read over shoulders or approach the paper. Students who seem unable to identify any reclaim action may be in an ongoing unsafe situation — note for counselor.

FAMILY CONNECTION

Today students studied how rumours hijack personal narratives. At home, you can reinforce: "Other people's versions of your story are not your story. Your character is what you demonstrate over time — not what is claimed about you."

ANCHOR CHART · NO NEW ANCHOR CHART — TWO KEY LINES ON THE BOARD**BUILD SPECIFICATION**

"A rumour is a story told about you by people who are not primarily concerned with whether it is true."

"The rumour is not you. It is a story someone else is telling."

Reference: U3L1 Impact vs. Intent · U3L4 Flame vs. Pause (permanent).

Lesson 5 is the most private lesson of Unit 3 — keep the visual environment quiet.

POST: Two lines on the board only. No new chart. · **KEEP:** Reference existing Unit 3 charts.

The Agency of Release — Letter of Release

40–45 min · March Week 1

OBJECTIVE	Students practice choosing to release resentment — not for the other person's sake, but as an act of self-protection — and articulate the difference between releasing resentment and excusing the harm.
CASEL FOCUS	Self-Management: emotional regulation and internal agency · Self-Awareness: understanding the cost of sustained resentment
SCENARIO CARDS	None — all activity is private. No scenario cards, no pairs, no sharing.
QUICK REVIEW	Skip Quick Review. Begin with the full opening ritual — 3 full minutes of grounding. This ritual is not optional.

★★ MANDATORY PRE-LESSON REQUIREMENTS

All must be met before class begins. ☐ Counselor is PHYSICALLY IN THE ROOM before the first student enters — not on-call, not in the hallway, IN THE ROOM ☐ Crisis resources posted visibly: 988 Lifeline · Crisis Text Line: HOME to 741741 · Counselor contact ☐ Lesson NOT scheduled before a holiday, weekend, break, or fire-drill day ☐ Letter of Release templates are placed FACE-DOWN at each seat BEFORE students enter ☐ You have confirmed you have enough time to reach the Release Ritual before the bell — if not, do NOT start the Letter ☐ You have taken 60 seconds to settle yourself before students arrive

OPENING · OPENING RITUAL · 3 FULL MINUTES · DO NOT SHORTEN

"Is there someone you have been carrying? Someone whose name comes up in your mind when you are trying to sleep, or when something goes wrong — and suddenly you are back in what they did? That is resentment. And today, if you choose to, we are going to look at what it might mean to put it down." · "I want to be clear: this is not about them. It is not about whether they deserve your forgiveness. It is entirely about you — and whether carrying this is costing you more than it is costing them."

PAUSE. 20-30 SECONDS OF SILENCE. DO NOT FILL IT. THE COUNSELOR HOLDS THE ROOM WITH YOU

DIRECT INSTRUCTION · STEPS 1 — 5

1

The Cost of Resentment

8 MIN

"The person who hurt you may have moved on. But you do — because resentment is the experience of reliving harm. Every time you revisit it, you experience the hurt again. The cost of resentment is paid by you, not by them."

Write on board: **"Who is paying the cost of your resentment right now?"**

Students journal privately for 3 minutes: **"What is this resentment actually costing you? Sleep? Attention? Energy? What would you have more of if you were not carrying this?"** Do not ask for sharing.

2

What Release Is and Is Not

7 MIN

Write on board as you say each:

Release IS: Choosing to stop funding the cost of carrying it. An internal act done entirely for yourself. Compatible with still wanting accountability. Compatible with still feeling hurt sometimes.

Release IS NOT: Saying what happened was okay. Reconciling. Letting them off the hook. Something you owe them.

"You can release resentment and still want accountability. Release is not a feeling — it is a choice. And it is one you make for yourself."

3

Culturally Responsive Framing

3 MIN

"For some of you — and I want to say this directly — the idea of releasing resentment can feel like being asked to let someone go who caused real harm. Especially if that harm was connected to your race, your family's status, your community's experience of injustice. I am not asking you to release that. Systemic injustice is not a personal resentment to put down."

"What we are talking about today is specific: carrying the weight of what a particular person did to you — and whether that weight is serving you or only costing you."

WORKSHEET

Letter of Release Template U3·L6 · Voluntary — Never Collected **Critical:** Templates placed face-down at each seat. Students turn over only if they choose. This letter is private — never collected, never read, never referenced. Belongs entirely to the student.

4

The Letter of Release

15 MIN

Introduce with this script exactly:

"The paper face-down in front of you is a Letter of Release template. You do not have to turn it over. This is entirely voluntary. If you choose not to write, you can journal about something else, or sit quietly. Both are valid choices."

"If you choose to write: the letter is private. I will not read it. No one else will read it. You will take it with you — or tear it up — or seal it. It belongs to you. Turn it over only if you want to."

Teacher steps back from the centre of the room. Allow the FULL 15 minutes.

IN-LESSON SCAN

OBSERVE A student who turns the letter over, reads the prompts, and then turns it back face-down without writing. **MAY SIGNAL** This student considered it and decided not to. That is a completely valid choice. The choice not to write is meaningful, not a failure. **ACTION** Do not approach or acknowledge during class. After class: "However you used today is the right way for you." Do not probe.

IN-LESSON SCAN

OBSERVE A student who leaves the room during the Letter writing. **MAY SIGNAL** This is the highest-disclosure-risk lesson of the year. Leaving during the private writing portion is a significant signal.

ACTION Counselor follows immediately. Teacher stays with class. Say to class: "Keep working." Do not draw attention. Counselor follows established six-step protocol.

IN-LESSON SCAN

OBSERVE A student who writes intensely, then approaches the counselor voluntarily. **MAY SIGNAL** A voluntary approach to the counselor during this lesson is a meaningful act of self-disclosure — the student has decided to reach out. **ACTION** Counselor receives the student outside the room while teacher stays with class. This is the protocol working correctly.

5

The Release Ritual

5 MIN

"When you are ready — decide what to do with what you wrote. Keep it. Seal it. Tear it up. Whatever this moment asks for, that is the right choice."

Allow time for the ritual. Closing script: **"What you did — or did not do — today is entirely yours. This was not a performance for me. It was for you. And whatever you chose, I want you to know: the fact that you showed up for this conversation, this unit, this year — that says something about who you are."**

TEACHING TIP

What NOT to say during this lesson — post on your desk: "Try to get something down — even a sentence." · Do not prompt. "Who did you decide to write your letter to?" · Never ask. "After you're done writing, we'll share what we chose to do." · Never share. "I think you'll feel so much better after you do it." · Do not promise outcomes.

EXIT TICKET

"Choosing to release resentment is **NOT** the same as excusing what happened because _____. I am choosing it because _____."** · Allow 3 full minutes minimum. Do not end class without it. Journal entry — student writes privately. Never collected. Never graded.

MANDATORY SAME-DAY DEBRIEF.

Required regardless of whether any disclosure occurred. Teacher briefs counselor on: room's emotional register, students who left or stopped writing, voluntary disclosures, anything that warrants follow-up. Counselor follows up with flagged students before L7. Teacher uses their own restorative practice tonight. This lesson costs something. That is it working.

TEACHER REFLECTION

This is the highest-disclosure-risk lesson of the year. Your regulated nervous system is the room's most important safety tool. The Letter cannot be split across sessions. If you cannot finish, do not start. After this lesson: brief your counselor — for your own state, not just for student disclosures. See Section 4 — Teacher Wellbeing.

FAMILY CONNECTION

Today your child participated in one of the most significant lessons of the year. It involved reflecting on what they may be carrying from a past hurt — and whether they choose to set it down.

If they seem quiet or reflective this evening, that is a healthy response. If they seem distressed, please contact the counselor directly.

LEGAL · PPRA NOTE

★★ **Highest risk of the year.** Counselor physically in the room — no exceptions. Do not schedule before any break. The Letter of Release **CANNOT** be split across two sessions — if you cannot finish, do not start. Mandatory same-day debrief with counselor regardless of disclosure. Safe messaging guidelines apply throughout.

ANCHOR CHART · NO NEW ANCHOR CHART — CRISIS RESOURCES + LETTER TEMPLATES**BUILD SPECIFICATION**

988 Suicide & Crisis Lifeline — Call or text 988

Crisis Text Line — Text HOME to 741741

Your school counselor — Name: _____ Contact: _____

Letter of Release templates placed face-down at seats before students arrive. Room calm and minimal.

POST: Crisis resources confirmed visible before class. Counselor in room. · **KEEP:** ☹ Permanent — crisis resources stay up.

REGULATION & REPAIR STRAND

Boundary-Setting · Regulate First, Then Communicate



Limits from Self-Respect + Unit 3 Wrap-Up & Bridge to Unit 4

45–50 min · March Week 2–3

OBJECTIVE	Students understand that setting limits is an act of self-respect, practice boundary language grounded in values, consolidate Unit 3 learning, and prepare conceptually for Unit 4 grace.
CASEL FOCUS	Self-Management: limit-setting · Relationship Skills: boundary communication · Synthesis: Unit 3 → Unit 4 bridge
SCENARIO CARDS	Boundary Card A (The Pressure Loop) · Boundary Card B (The Oversharer)
QUICK REVIEW	1–2 min: "Last lesson was one of the most significant of the year. Today we take the work of release and ask a practical question: once you have decided not to carry the resentment, how do you protect yourself going forward? That is the first half of today. The second half: we close Unit 3 together."

CONSOLIDATION NOTE — U3 L7.

This lesson combines former L7 (Limits from Self-Respect, 40 min) and former L8 (Unit 3 Wrap-Up & Bridge to Unit 4, 45–50 min) into one 45–50 minute lesson. Timing: Opening (3 min) → Limits DI + Boundary Scripts (20 min) → Scenario Cards (5 min) → Unit 3 Synthesis + Collective Wisdom (12 min) → Bridge to Unit 4 (5 min) → Exit ticket (5 min). Future-Self Letters are NOT returned here — retained until U4L7.

ANCHOR CHART · LIMITS — BOUNDARY FORMULA · ☹ PERMANENT (POST NOW, KEEP ALL YEAR)

Write this formula **before class**. Posts as a **permanent anchor** through end of year. **The formula:** "When you ___ / I ___ / **Going forward, I need ___.**" Key message below the formula: "**A limit is information about what you need to be okay. It is not a punishment. It is not a demand the other person change.**" Below that: "What YOU will do — which you can actually control."

OPENING · 3 MINUTES

"What is the difference between setting a boundary and punishing someone? Between protecting yourself and retaliating? Today we look at how to set limits on what we will accept — from a place of self-respect, not revenge."

1

What a Limit Is (and Is Not)

8 MIN

"A limit is information about what you need to be okay. It is not a punishment. It is not an ultimatum. It is not a demand that the other person change. A limit is simply a statement of what you will do — which you can actually control."

Walk through the formula on the board. Run two class-generated examples through the formula before students apply it independently.

WORKSHEET

Boundary Scripts Template U3·L7 · Primary Activity Three scenario prompts with the structured formula. For each: Draft a limit. Is this from self-respect or retaliation? What value does it protect? Focus: school-based scenarios (private information sharing, repeated exclusion, uncomfortable online interaction). Never collected.

2

Scenario Practice

15 MIN

"Using the Boundary Scripts template — draft limits for the scenarios provided. Use the formula: 'I need _____. When _____ happens, I will _____.' Focus on what YOU will do — not on what you want the other person to do."

Run one scenario as a whole-class model first. Then students work individually. Optional partner review at the end.

IN-LESSON SCAN

OBSERVE A student whose boundary script is punitive rather than self-protective — "When you do that, I will tell the whole school about you." **MAY SIGNAL** This student's limit is designed to harm the other person, not protect themselves. It is retaliation framed as a boundary. **ACTION** During circulating, approach quietly: "That's a strong response — is it designed to protect you, or to cause damage? Let's see if we can find the version that just says what you need." No judgment. Gently redirect.

SAFETY CHECK

If a student's described situation suggests ongoing unsafe conditions — not just uncomfortable peer relationship, but active harm — do NOT offer the boundary-setting framework. In unsafe situations, the internal decision (knowing what you will and will not accept) may be the only safe option. Note privately for counselor. The boundary scripts are for uncomfortable situations, not unsafe ones.

SCENARIO CARDS

CARD A The Pressure Loop Sofia caves to "You're being so boring." Connects directly to U1L4 peer pressure content. **CARD B The Oversharer** Marcus's friend shares his private information carelessly. The shift from hinting to direct communication is key.

3

Return to Unit 3 Lesson 1

4 MIN

"Open your journal to your first Unit 3 entry — from Lesson 1, when we looked at impact vs. intent. Read what you wrote then. What is different now? Distance is data — it tells you what has shifted."

Students write 2 minutes privately. No sharing required.

4

Collective Wisdom Display

10 MIN

"I want to capture what this class knows after eight weeks — not for evaluation, for you. Write one sentence on your index card: the most important thing you are carrying from Unit 3 into Unit 4. Then we'll post them together."

Students write 3 minutes. Post on shared wall space. Read 4–5 aloud (with permission). **"This is the collective wisdom of this class. It belongs to all of you."**

5

Bridge Framing

8 MIN

"Unit 3 was about dealing with hurt — the hurt others caused you. You have looked at it honestly, held it with the Compassionate Witness, and begun to make choices about whether to carry it."

"In Unit 4, we ask the culminating question of the year: Given everything you have learned — given who you now know yourself to be — what kind of grace do you choose to offer? That is not a small question. It is the question Unit 4 is built around. And you have earned the right to mean your answer."

IN-LESSON SCAN

OBSERVE During the bridge framing, a student who appears withdrawn or flat — who has clearly left behind something significant in the letter-writing and has not yet found their footing again. **MAY SIGNAL** Unit 3 L6 and the consolidation of the full unit can leave some students emotionally depleted. The shift to Unit 4 may not feel available to them yet. **ACTION** Do not push. After class: "Today was a lot. I noticed. How are you?" Note for counselor before Unit 4 begins if the flatness is significant.

SAFETY CHECK

Confirm with counselor that any students significantly activated during U3L6 have been followed up with. **▲ Critical:** Future-Self Letters from U1L7 are NOT returned here — retain until U4L7. Distribute Unit 4 Family Transition Letter at the close of this lesson. Review bridge exit tickets privately before Unit 4 Lesson 1.

EXIT TICKET

"The most important thing I am carrying from Unit 3 into Unit 4 is ____." Journal entry — student writes privately. Never collected. Never graded.

UNIT 3 · LESSON 7 · THE INTERIOR (6-8)

TEACHER REFLECTION

Consolidation check: This merged lesson contains two previous lessons' content. Protect Part 1 (Limits DI + Boundary Scripts) — do not allow it to run past 25 minutes. The Bridge Framing in Step 5 is the most important close of the year so far. Do not abbreviate. Brief the counselor on the overall Unit 3 arc before Unit 4 Lesson 1.

FAMILY CONNECTION

Your child has just completed eight weeks of the hardest unit of the year. They have done significant work. We are moving into Unit 4 — Grace & Generosity — the payoff of everything that came before. Ask them: "What is one thing you learned this unit that you did not know in January?"

LEGAL · PPRA NOTE

Unit 4 Family Transition Letter distributed at the close of this lesson. Confirm with counselor that any students significantly activated during U3L6 have been followed up with before Unit 4 begins.

ANCHOR CHART · LIMITS — BOUNDARY FORMULA ☹️ PERMANENT

BUILD SPECIFICATION

The formula: "When you ___ / I ___ / Going forward, I need ___."

A limit is information about what you need to be okay. Not a punishment. Not an ultimatum.

LIMIT = self-respect (What do I need?) · **THREAT** = retaliation (What will I do to you?)

Post permanently from this lesson forward. Reference in Unit 4 grace-with-difficult-people.

POST: Day 1 of U3L7. Permanent from this point. · **KEEP:** ☹️ Permanent.

UNIT 4

Grace & Generosity

*“Given everything I now know — what kind of person do I
choose to become?”*

APRIL – JUNE · 7 LESSONS · 40-50 MIN EACH

What Is Grace?

40 min · April Week 1

OBJECTIVE	Students define grace in the curriculum's secular sense and identify three acts of grace in different registers of difficulty.
CASEL FOCUS	Social Awareness: understanding grace as a chosen practice · Responsible Decision-Making: the generative shift from Units 1–3
SCENARIO CARDS	Grace Cards A (The Unexpected Kindness) & B (The Second Chance)
QUICK REVIEW	1–2 min: "We have spent three units looking inward and at difficult relationships. Today Unit 4 begins — and the direction shifts. The question stops being 'how do I deal with what happened' and starts being 'what kind of person am I choosing to become?' That is the Unit 4 question."

UNIT 4 TEACHING POSTURE.

Shift from "holding the room" to "celebrating growth." Unit 4 is generative — your job in these lessons is to open space for students to practice grace, not to excavate difficult material. The disclosure risk in Unit 4 is significantly lower than in Units 2–3. Name the shift explicitly in Lesson 1: "This unit feels different. That's by design."

ANCHOR CHART · WHAT IS GRACE? — DEFINITION ANCHOR CHART · ☹️ PERMANENT THROUGH L7

Post prominently — stays up through L7. **The definition:** Grace is the deliberate choice to extend something generous to someone who has not necessarily earned it. Below: "**Grace is not sentimentality. It is chosen strength.**" **Three registers of difficulty:** 1. Grace that is easy — extending generosity toward someone you like or who has been kind to you. 2. Grace that costs something — extending generosity toward someone you don't know or feel neutral toward. 3. Grace that is hard — extending generosity toward someone who has not been kind to you.

OPENING · 3 MINUTES

Use the opening ritual — the same one from the first lesson. "Put both feet on the floor. Take one breath that is slower than usual." After 90 seconds: "That is the same ritual we have used all year. Notice how it feels different now than it did in September. That difference is some of what this year has built.**"

1

Define Grace — Address Religious Connotation Directly

8 MIN

"Before we go any further, I need to address something: the word grace. In many religious traditions, grace is a theological concept — divine, unearned favour. In this curriculum, we use the word in its psychological and relational sense. Grace here is a human practice — the deliberate choice to extend something generous to someone who has not necessarily earned it."

Post the definition on the anchor chart. Address questions about the secular framing now.

2

Three Registers of Difficulty

8 MIN

"Grace comes in different registers of difficulty." Point to the three on the anchor chart.

"The question Unit 4 asks is: can you practice the harder registers? Can you choose something generous for someone who hasn't necessarily earned it — not because you are required to, but because of who you are choosing to become?"

3

Sticky Note Gallery • Primary Activity

12 MIN

"On one sticky note: name one act of grace you have SEEN in this school in the last month. On a second sticky note: name one act of grace you are choosing to OFFER this week. Post both on the anchor chart wall."

Students post anonymously. Read 5–6 aloud. **"Look at what grace already looks like in this building. We are not starting from nothing."**

IN-LESSON SCAN

OBSERVE A student who cannot identify a single act of grace they have seen in the school environment. **MAY SIGNAL** This student may be in a significantly grace-depleted environment — socially isolated, or in a context where grace is genuinely uncommon for them. This is important data about their social experience. **ACTION** Do not single out. Make a note privately. For Unit 4 L6 (Grace Audit), this student's observation scope may need scaffolding — they may need to start with a smaller context than the whole school.

SCENARIO CARDS

CARD A The Unexpected Kindness Classmate sits next to excluded Nadia without being asked. The "cost" element — grace that costs something — is the key concept. **CARD B The Second Chance** Drama teacher quietly reinvites Marcus with one condition. Grace-with-accountability. "The condition is not punishment — it is dignifying expectation."

UNIT 4 · LESSON 1 · THE INTERIOR (6–8)

TEACHING TIP

Cultural Connection: Grace and generosity exist in every cultural tradition under different names — hospitality, community care, elder respect. Invite connection: "What does this practice look like in your family's tradition?" Honor student answers without requiring disclosure. Grade 6: Keep the register focus concrete — easy grace, medium-cost grace, hard grace. Students can name examples from their own experience without personal disclosure. Grades 7–8: "Is grace something you choose once — or something you maintain? What would it mean to practice the harder register consistently over time?"

EXIT TICKET

"One act of grace I have seen is _____. What made it grace was _____." Journal entry — student writes privately. Never collected. Never graded.

TEACHER REFLECTION

First lesson of Unit 4. The opening ritual callback — "notice how this feels different than September" — is one of the most powerful moments of the year. Allow it to land. Address the religious connotation of "grace" directly and early. Students from diverse faith traditions will bring different associations. The sticky note gallery tells you a great deal about the grace climate in your classroom. What does it reveal?

FAMILY CONNECTION

We began our final unit — Grace and Generosity — today. Your child has spent this year learning hard things about themselves and others. Now we are asking: given everything you have learned, what kind of person do you choose to be? Ask them: "What does grace look like in your world right now?"

ANCHOR CHART · WHAT IS GRACE? — DEFINITION ANCHOR CHART ☹️ PERMANENT

BUILD SPECIFICATION

"The deliberate choice to extend something generous — patience, inclusion, the benefit of the doubt — to someone who has not necessarily earned it."

"Grace is not sentimentality. It is chosen strength."

Three registers: (1) Easy — toward someone you like. (2) Costs something — toward someone neutral. (3) Hard — toward someone who has not been kind.

Add sticky notes from the gallery activity during the lesson. Keep permanently through L7.

POST: Before class. Prominently displayed. · **KEEP:** ☹️ Permanent — through year-end.

What Does Mercy Look Like?

40 min · April Week 2

OBJECTIVE	Students define mercy as the choice to restrain power, understand the mercy-growth connection, and sit with the mercy-justice tension as genuine ethical territory.
CASEL FOCUS	Social Awareness: mercy as a relational practice · Responsible Decision-Making: mercy-justice tension
SCENARIO CARDS	Mercy Cards A (The Overdue Apology), B (The Repeated Mistake), C (The Power Difference)
QUICK REVIEW	1–2 min: "Last lesson: what is our definition of grace?" (student answers) "Today we look at grace's close relative: mercy. Grace extends something generous. Mercy restrains something harsh. Different motion — same spirit."

EQUITY ALERT — DELIVER EXPLICITLY. NOT OPTIONAL.

Deliver before scenario work: "Mercy that benefits those in power at the expense of accountability is not the mercy we are studying. If a system that causes harm asks its victims to extend mercy, that is not mercy — that is silencing." "What we are talking about today is the choice individuals make with the power they personally hold — choosing kindness when harshness would be justified."

OPENING · 2 MINUTES

"When is restraint an act of strength, not weakness? Today we look at mercy — the choice to hold back a response you could legitimately make, because something more important than being right is at stake."

DIRECT INSTRUCTION · STEPS 1 — 2



Define Mercy

8 MIN

"Mercy is the choice to restrain power — withholding a negative response that would be justified. Not because the consequence is not deserved, but because something more important than being right is at stake: the person's capacity to grow."

Write on board: **"Mercy = restraining power you could legitimately use."**

Ask: **"When is restraint an act of strength, not weakness?"** Take 3–4 responses.

2

The Mercy-Justice Tension

10 MIN

"Here is the genuine ethical tension: Mercy and justice are sometimes in conflict. If mercy means letting someone off the hook who has caused real harm, is that mercy — or is it injustice to the person who was harmed? That tension is REAL. This lesson does not resolve it. It asks you to sit with it."

Run Card A as a class model — does mercy apply? What does justice require? Can you have both?

IN-LESSON SCAN

OBSERVE A student who insists that justice and mercy are always compatible — who cannot sit with the tension. **MAY SIGNAL** This student may be uncomfortable with genuine ethical complexity. The inability to hold the tension may indicate a rigid moral framework that will come under pressure in more complex real-world situations. **ACTION** Do not resolve the tension for them. "I notice you want to find the answer that makes both work. What happens when they genuinely don't?" Let the discomfort be the lesson.

SCENARIO CARDS

CARD A The Overdue Apology Priya embarrassed Jamie. Late apology was genuine. Jamie has every social right to exclude Priya. Whole-class model. Sit with the tension — no clean answer. **CARD B The Repeated Mistake** Theo keeps being late. Two chances already given. Mercy vs. enabling. "Grace with a clear condition." **CARD C The Power Difference** Teacher quietly accepts late assignment. Equity question — is mercy equally available to all students?

TEACHING TIP

The mercy-justice tension is the destination — do not resolve it artificially. Let students sit with the discomfort of there being no clean answer. Card C raises the equity question directly: mercy is not equally distributed. Do not shy away from this. Grades 7–8: "Is there a difference between mercy from someone who was harmed and mercy from a third-party observer? Does the source of the mercy change what it means?"

EXIT TICKET

"Mercy, in my own words, is _____. A time I received mercy was _____. A time I could have shown mercy and didn't is _____." Journal entry — student writes privately. Never collected. Never graded.

TEACHER REFLECTION

Do not resolve the mercy-justice tension. The lesson is the tension itself. Card C is the most important card for equity — do not skip it if time allows. Students who have been in situations where they were asked to extend mercy to someone in power may have strong reactions. Hold space for that.

UNIT 4 · LESSON 2 · THE INTERIOR (6-8)

FAMILY CONNECTION

Today students studied mercy — the deliberate choice to restrain power. At home, look for a mercy moment this week with your child — and name it explicitly: "I am choosing to extend some mercy here."

ANCHOR CHART · MERCY — DEFINITION AND TENSION CHART

BUILD SPECIFICATION

"Mercy = restraining power you could legitimately use."

"Not because the consequence is not deserved — because something more important than being right is at stake: the person's capacity to grow."

The mercy-justice tension: draw two opposing arrows. This tension is real. This lesson does not resolve it.

Equity alert: mercy is not equally distributed. Name this directly when using Card C.

POST: Before class. · **KEEP:** Unit 4.

Giving the Benefit of the Doubt

40 min · April Week 3

OBJECTIVE	Students practice charitable interpretation as a daily skill and learn to use the Pause as a concrete, learnable four-step tool.
CASEL FOCUS	Social Awareness: charitable interpretation · Responsible Decision-Making: the Pause as a skill
SCENARIO CARDS	Charitable Cards A (The Ignored Message) & B (The Short Answer)
QUICK REVIEW	1–2 min: "Last lesson: mercy. Quick — what is mercy?" (student answers) "Mercy restrains a response you could make. Today: giving the benefit of the doubt is an even earlier intervention — choosing a generous interpretation BEFORE you respond."

ANCHOR CHART · THE PAUSE — FOUR-STEP ACTION SEQUENCE (ADD TO FLAME VS. PAUSE POSTER)

Add these four steps directly to the existing Flame vs. Pause poster from U3L4. 1. Stop before sending / posting / responding. 2. Ask: What do I actually want to happen here? 3. Consider: What will this action cause? 4. Choose: minimum effective response — or disengage entirely. **New addition:** "Charitable Interpretation" as Step 0 — before the Pause.

OPENING · 2 MINUTES

"When someone you don't know well does something ambiguous, what is your first interpretation? Today we look at where that default comes from — and how to change it."

DIRECT INSTRUCTION · STEPS 1 — 2

I

The Automatic Negative Interpretation

7 MIN

"When someone we don't know well does something ambiguous, our brain's default is often the worst interpretation.

"They ignored me on purpose." "They said that to be mean." Ask: Where does that automatic interpretation come from?"

Take 3–4 responses. **"It comes from in-group/out-group bias — our brains give people in our 'group' the benefit of the doubt automatically. People outside our group do not get that same default. Grace says: extend it anyway."**

2

Scenario Card Practice

15 MIN

"Pre-printed scenarios with TWO interpretation options per scenario — choose the charitable one and practice the four-step Pause. 'Which interpretation is more charitable? Does choosing the charitable interpretation mean pretending the other one is impossible? No — it means choosing not to act on the worst interpretation until you have more information.'"

EQUITY ALERT — DELIVER EXPLICITLY. NOT OPTIONAL.

"Many ELL and marginalised students know what it feels like to NOT receive charitable interpretation because of how they look or sound." "We are talking about what WE choose to do — not claiming that the world already treats everyone with this grace. It doesn't. That is exactly why it matters."

IN-LESSON SCAN

OBSERVE A student who consistently selects the negative interpretation in every scenario card — who cannot access or articulate the charitable one. **MAY SIGNAL** This student may have developed a defensive negative-default as a protective response to a history of real social harm. The negative interpretation may have been accurate often enough that it is now their baseline. **ACTION** Do not correct or push. After class: "I noticed today felt different for you. I'm available." Equity consideration: for marginalised students, negative interpretation is sometimes the statistically accurate one.

SCENARIO CARDS

CARD A The Ignored Message Layla's friend was unresponsive for two days. Grandmother hospitalised. Apply the Pause. "Charitable interpretation is not naivety — it is a choice that protects the relationship until you have real information." **CARD B The Short Answer** Cameron's flat response during group work. Nadia interpreted it as dismissal. Cameron was anxious. "Final question is important: How does this change if Cameron often gives flat answers to Nadia specifically?" — limits of charitable interpretation.

TEACHING TIP

The Pause four-step sequence is now added to the existing Flame vs. Pause poster from U3L4 — this is a visual reinforcement of the year-long skill arc. Grade 6: Focus on the two-interpretation format as a concrete choice. "Which interpretation keeps the relationship open while you get more information?" Grades 7–8: "Is charitable interpretation naive — or is it strategic? What does it give you even when you're wrong?"

EXIT TICKET

"One person I could give more benefit of the doubt to is _____. One charitable interpretation I could try is _____." Journal entry — student writes privately. Never collected. Never graded.

UNIT 4 · LESSON 3 · THE INTERIOR (6–8)

TEACHER REFLECTION

Charitable interpretation has limits — Card B surfaces this appropriately. Do not teach charitable interpretation as infinite. "When a pattern is clearly directed at one person, the charitable interpretation is no longer the most accurate one." The equity alert is important — acknowledge that charitable interpretation is not the default experience for all students.

FAMILY CONNECTION

Today students practised charitable interpretation. At home, model the pause: "That could mean a few different things. What is another explanation besides the obvious one?"

ANCHOR CHART · THE PAUSE — ADD CHARITABLE INTERPRETATION (STEP 0) TO EXISTING CHART

BUILD SPECIFICATION

Add to the existing Flame vs. Pause chart from U3L4 — above Step 1:

Step 0: Charitable Interpretation — "Is there a more generous explanation available? Choose it — until you have evidence it is wrong."

"We automatically give charitable interpretation to people we like. That's where the real practice begins."

The addition reads as a prerequisite — a step that happens before the Pause sequence begins.

POST: Add Step 0 directly to the existing U3L4 chart. · **KEEP:** ☹️ Already permanent.

Small Acts, Big Difference — The Grace Challenge

40 min · May Week 1

OBJECTIVE	Students commit to three specific, daily micro-moments of grace and understand the compounding effect of consistent small acts.
CASEL FOCUS	Relationship Skills: prosocial behaviour · Responsible Decision-Making: Grace Challenge commitments
SCENARIO CARDS	None — the Grace Challenge Tracker is the primary artifact
QUICK REVIEW	1–2 min: "Last lesson: the benefit of the doubt — an internal choice about interpretation. Today's lesson is external and daily: what does grace look like when you do it consistently, specifically, every single day? That is the Grace Challenge."

ANCHOR CHART · MICRO-MOMENT MENU — EXAMPLES OF SPECIFIC GRACE ACTS

Post as an anchor chart — students choose from this menu or generate their own. · Say the name of the person you sit next to when you greet them. · Acknowledge someone's contribution in a group before adding your own. · Make eye contact and nod when someone is speaking. · Notice when someone is left out and move toward them. · Let someone go first in a situation where you could have gone first. **Specificity is the key requirement.** "Being nicer" is not a micro-moment.

OPENING · 2 MINUTES

"Research on prosocial behaviour shows that consistent small acts of kindness produce measurable wellbeing benefits for both giver and receiver. The effect is real — and it compounds. One micro-moment of grace every day for a week is seven moments. Across a month, thirty. Across a year, three hundred and sixty-five. Character is built one choice at a time — but those choices accumulate."

DIRECT INSTRUCTION · STEPS 1 — 2

I The Compounding Effect 7 MIN

Expand the research context: "Sonja Lyubomirsky's research shows that consistent acts of kindness produce measurable wellbeing benefits for both giver and receiver — not just the recipient."

Draw the compounding effect on the board: $1 \text{ per day} \times 365 = 365 \text{ micro-moments}$. "Grace is not a feeling. It is a practice. A practice that compounds."

WORKSHEET

WS9: Grace Challenge Tracker U4·L4 · Primary Artifact · Used through L5 Three SPECIFIC, OBSERVABLE, DAILY micro-moments of grace. Specificity requirement is non-negotiable. Daily completion log + weekly reflection. Issued today. Followed up at L5.

2

Grace Challenge Commitments

12 MIN

"Write three specific, observable, daily micro-moments. Use the menu on the board or generate your own. Test each one: Can I do this in less than 30 seconds? Does it cost me something — even a small amount of social risk or attention? Is it something I can observe — did I actually do it or not?"

Teacher circulates and checks specificity. If too vague: **"Can you make it more specific? What does that look like in 30 seconds?"**

IN-LESSON SCAN

OBSERVE A student whose three commitments are all passive or internal — "think kindly about someone," "try to be more patient." **MAY SIGNAL** These are not observable micro-moments — they are intentions. The Grace Challenge requires external, observable action. The student may be defaulting to the internal work they have been doing all year. **ACTION** Approach quietly: "These are good intentions — can you find the version of each that someone else could see? What would it look like from the outside?"

TEACHING TIP

Follow-up is essential. Say explicitly today: **"At Lesson 5, I am going to ask: did you do your three things? What did you notice?"** The commitment works better when students know a follow-up is coming. Honor students whose cultural traditions already include deeply embedded community generosity practices — name these as already counting. Grade 6: The micro-moment menu is essential — students at Grade 6 benefit from the concrete examples. Let them choose from the menu before generating their own.

EXIT TICKET

"My three Grace Challenge commitments are: (1) ___, (2) ___, (3) ___. What measuring grace means to me: ___." Journal entry — student writes privately. Never collected. Never graded.

TEACHER REFLECTION

Specificity check is the most important facilitation move in this lesson. Circulate and ask: "Can I do this in under 30 seconds? Can I observe whether I did it?" Announce explicitly: "At Lesson 5, I will ask: did you do your three things?" The follow-up is what makes the commitment real. WS9 is used through L5 — students carry it with them between lessons.

UNIT 4 · LESSON 4 · THE INTERIOR (6-8)

FAMILY CONNECTION

Your child made a Grace Challenge commitment this week. Ask them tonight: "What are your three?" Follow up during the week: "Did you do one of your Grace Challenge things today? What happened?"

ANCHOR CHART · MICRO-MOMENT MENU — EXAMPLES OF SPECIFIC GRACE ACTS

BUILD SPECIFICATION

- Say the **name** of the person you sit next to when you greet them.
- Acknowledge someone's contribution **before** adding your own.
- Make eye contact and nod when someone is speaking.
- Notice when someone is **left out** and move toward them.
- Let someone go **first** when you could have gone first.

Specificity is the key requirement. "Being nicer" is not a micro-moment.

POST: Before class. · **KEEP:** Unit 4.

Grace With Hard People

40 min • May Week 2

OBJECTIVE	Students distinguish between difficult people and unsafe people, and practice maintaining a grace posture toward the former while protecting themselves from the latter.
CASEL FOCUS	Relationship Skills: grace with difficult people • Self-Management: distinguishing difficult from unsafe
SCENARIO CARDS	Hard People Cards A (The Persistent Critic) & B (The Complicated History)
QUICK REVIEW	1–2 min: "Grace Challenge check-in — who did all three of their commitments every day this week?" (Optional show of hands.) "What did you notice — even a small ripple?" Take 3–4 observations. "Today: what happens when the person you are extending grace toward is genuinely difficult?"

ANCHOR CHART • DIFFICULT VS. UNSAFE — VISUAL SPECTRUM

Draw this spectrum **before class**. **LEFT END — EASY:** Someone you like, someone who has been kind to you. **MIDDLE — DIFFICULT:** Irritating, challenging, hard to be around. Grace is appropriate and possible. **RIGHT END — UNSAFE:** Active harm, ongoing danger. Safety is the priority. Grace is not the goal here. Bold dividing line between DIFFICULT and UNSAFE. Key message: **"The distinction between these two changes everything about what the right response is."**

OPENING • 2 MINUTES

"Grace with hard people is one of the most important — and most misunderstood — lessons of the year. It is NOT asking you to be gracious toward unsafe people. It IS asking you to notice: is this person difficult or unsafe? That distinction changes everything."

DIRECT INSTRUCTION • STEPS 1 — 2

I

Difficult vs. Unsafe — The Core Distinction

8 MIN

"A difficult person is irritating, challenging, hard. An unsafe person is one with whom your safety is at risk. Grace with difficult people is one of the hardest practices of the year. But grace with unsafe people is not what this curriculum teaches — ever. That distinction changes everything about what the right response is."

Walk through the spectrum on the board with 2–3 class-generated examples.

2

Scenario Card Practice

20 MIN

"Pairs work through two cards. For each: Where does this person fall on the spectrum? Is grace the goal here, or is safety? What does grace look like if appropriate? How is that different from acceptance of mistreatment?"

Work one card as a whole-class model first.

IN-LESSON SCAN

OBSERVE A student who consistently places everyone they describe at the "unsafe" end of the spectrum — every difficult person is also dangerous. **MAY SIGNAL** This student may have a history where difficult people have been unsafe — the distinction was not available to them because in their experience, difficulty and danger have been linked. **ACTION** Do not challenge the placement directly. "What specifically makes that person unsafe vs. difficult?" Keep it curious, not corrective. Note for counselor — this pattern is clinically significant.

SAFETY CHECK

If a student describes their "hard person" in ways suggesting ongoing unsafe conditions — not just discomfort — do NOT offer the grace-with-difficult-people framework. Safety, not grace, is the appropriate response for unsafe situations. ELL note: For students with difficult relationships connected to immigration stress or family separation, the internal posture concept (choosing an internal orientation toward someone you cannot physically avoid) is the safest takeaway.

SCENARIO CARDS

CARD A The Persistent Critic Classmate eye rolls every time Priya contributes. Whole-class model. Final question is critical: "What is grace NOT asking Priya to accept?" **CARD B The Complicated History** Two students with history — one processed the hurt. Now notices the other struggling. "Grace-at-a-distance." Connects to U3L3.

TEACHING TIP

Grade 6: Keep the difficult/unsafe distinction very concrete. School-based examples only. The "grace is not acceptance of mistreatment" principle needs to be stated explicitly. Grades 7–8: Card B is Grade 7–8 appropriate. The grace-at-a-distance concept — "I want good things for you without wanting to be close to you again" — is sophisticated and resonant for older students.

EXIT TICKET

"The difference between a difficult person and an unsafe person is _____. One difficult person toward whom I can practice grace is _____. One thing that makes that hard is _____." Journal entry — student writes privately. Never collected. Never graded.

UNIT 4 · LESSON 5 · THE INTERIOR (6-8)

TEACHER REFLECTION

The non-negotiable teaching point: grace is not required toward unsafe people. State it early, state it clearly, return to it in the debrief. Card B (Complicated History) deliberately builds on U3L3 forgiveness/reconciliation — if students remember that distinction, the connection enriches the lesson. Grace Challenge tracker follow-up: collect observations from students. What ripples did they notice? Use these in the L6 and L7 framing.

FAMILY CONNECTION

Today students studied grace toward difficult people. The curriculum is clear: grace is not required toward people who are unsafe. What we practise is grace toward people who are merely difficult — irritating, challenging, hard. That is a meaningful distinction.

ANCHOR CHART · DIFFICULT VS. UNSAFE — VISUAL SPECTRUM

BUILD SPECIFICATION

DIFFICULT	UNSAFE
Irritating Challenging Hard to be around Grace is appropriate and possible	Active harm Ongoing danger Safety — not grace — is the priority Grace is not the goal here

Left end — Easy: Someone you like or who has been kind to you.

"Grace is not required toward unsafe people. Ever." Bold dividing line between DIFFICULT and UNSAFE.

POST: Before class. · **KEEP:** Unit 4.

Grace Audit — Final Project

40–45 min · June Week 1

OBJECTIVE	Students identify a specific Grace Gap in the school environment, design a micro-moment to address it, and execute that micro-moment.
CASEL FOCUS	Responsible Decision-Making: Grace Audit observation · Relationship Skills: Grace Gap micro-moment design
SCENARIO CARDS	None — the Grace Audit is a real-world field observation, not a scenario exercise
QUICK REVIEW	1–2 min: "Unit 4: what is grace?" (student answers) "What is a Grace Gap?" ('A place where grace is noticeably absent and could meaningfully improve conditions for someone.') "Today we take that concept outside the classroom — and find one."

SAFETY CHECK

Counselor on standby — reachable and available same day. The Grace Audit occasionally surfaces significant personal observations. Monday–Wednesday delivery preferred. Brief counselor before delivery on any students carrying significant material from Units 2–3.

ANCHOR CHART · GRACE GAP — WHAT TO LOOK FOR (REFERENCE FOR OBSERVATION PHASE)

Post as reference during observation. This is the anchor chart from U4L1 — post alongside the Unit 4 Grace definition. **A Grace Gap:** where the absence of grace creates a harder experience for someone. **Observe people:** Who is consistently left out? Who is not receiving charitable interpretation? **Observe patterns:** Where is impatience the default? What goes consistently unacknowledged? **Observe moments:** Where could one person's inclusion change another's experience? **Good audit criteria:** Specific · Observable · Actionable · Empathic

OPENING · 2 MINUTES

"Unit 4: what is grace? What is a Grace Gap? Today we take that concept outside the classroom — into the actual school environment — and find one. Then we design and execute one micro-moment response to it. That is your final project."

1

The Grace Audit Assignment

10 MIN

"Your final project for Unit 4 is a Grace Audit. Observe the school environment this week — the hallways, the cafeteria, the classroom, the places where students interact — and find one specific Grace Gap. Then design and execute one micro-moment response to that gap."

Walk through the checklist together. **"The quality of your audit is measured by how specific and empathic your observation is — not by the size of the gap you find."**

WORKSHEET

Grace Audit Checklist U4·L6 · Primary Artifact · Final Project Pre-structured observation checklist: (1) The Grace Gap identified. (2) Who it affects and how. (3) Connection to curriculum. (4) Micro-moment design. (5) Micro-moment execution (completed after L6). Debrief at L7.

2

In-Class Observation Practice

15 MIN

"Before you take this audit out into the school: practice observing right here. Spend 5 minutes looking around this classroom with 'grace gap' eyes. What do you notice? Where is grace noticeably absent in this room right now?"

Students observe and note for 5 minutes. Take 3–4 observations. **"That is what your eyes will be looking for this week."**

3

Micro-Moment Design

10 MIN

"Design your micro-moment response. It must: (1) Be specific. (2) Be executable in 30 seconds or less. (3) Cost you something — even a small amount of social courage. (4) Address the Grace Gap you identified."

Students draft on the checklist. Teacher circulates and checks specificity: **"Is this something you can actually do, in a specific moment, this week?"**

EQUITY ALERT — DELIVER EXPLICITLY. NOT OPTIONAL.

Students from marginalised communities may identify systemic Grace Gaps — racial exclusion, language-based exclusion, social hierarchy gaps. Honor these as legitimate and important observations. Do NOT redirect toward 'safer' or smaller observations. These are the most significant Grace Audit findings in the class. A micro-moment addressing a systemic gap is still a meaningful act.

IN-LESSON SCAN

OBSERVE A student whose Grace Gap observation is about themselves — "the Grace Gap is that no one includes me." **MAY SIGNAL** This student's observation is true and important — but the Grace Audit is designed as an outward-facing observation. This student may not be able to access the outward perspective while still in acute social pain. **ACTION** Validate: "That is a real gap — and it matters. Can we also find one gap somewhere else in the building that you can address with a micro-moment?" If the student cannot shift, note for counselor. This student may need additional support before L7.

EXIT TICKET

"The Grace Gap I identified is _____. The micro-moment I am committing to execute this week is _____." Journal entry — student writes privately. Never collected. Never graded.

TEACHER REFLECTION

The Grace Audit reflection (Step 5 of the checklist) is completed after students execute their micro-moment — this carries into L7. The in-class observation practice (Step 2) is essential — students who skip it tend to identify vague or generic Grace Gaps for the fieldwork. Equity note: the most significant observations in your class will come from students who have personally experienced grace-depleted environments. Honour them.

FAMILY CONNECTION

Your child is completing their Grace Audit this week — observing the school environment for places where grace is noticeably absent. Ask them: "What did you find? What does grace look like when it's missing?"

LEGAL · PPRA NOTE

★ **Elevated risk.** Counselor on standby — reachable and available same day. Monday–Wednesday delivery preferred. The Grace Audit fieldwork occasionally surfaces significant personal observations.

ANCHOR CHART · GRACE GAP — WHAT TO LOOK FOR

BUILD SPECIFICATION

A Grace Gap: where the absence of grace creates a noticeably harder experience for someone.

Observe people: Who is consistently left out? Who is not receiving charitable interpretation?

Observe patterns: Where is impatience the default? What goes consistently unacknowledged?

Good audit criteria: Specific · Observable · Actionable · Empathic

POST: Post alongside the What Is Grace? chart for the observation phase. · **KEEP:** Through U4L7.

Community Charter & Year-End Celebration

40–50 min · June Week 2

OBJECTIVE	Students synthesize the full year's learning through the Community Charter co-creation, acknowledge individual growth, and close the year with a ritual of collective commitment.
CASEL FOCUS	All five CASEL domains — this is the year-end synthesis lesson
SCENARIO CARDS	None — this lesson is a celebration, not a scenario exercise
QUICK REVIEW	No Quick Review. Open with the individual acknowledgment preparation context: "Today is the end of the year. Before we begin: I have something to give each one of you."

★ ★ MANDATORY PRE-LESSON REQUIREMENTS

All must be met before class begins. ☐ Post-assessment printed and ready to distribute (administer BEFORE the celebration) ☐ Future-Self Letters from U1L7 retrieved from secure storage — sealed envelopes with student names ☐ Charter paper and signing materials prepared ☐ You have prepared ONE specific, evidence-based growth observation for EACH student to share during the individual acknowledgment ☐ No student will be overlooked — review your class list before class begins

DIRECT INSTRUCTION · POST-ASSESSMENT → LETTER RETURN → CHARTER → SIGNING → ACKNOWLEDGMENT → CLOSING

1

Post-Assessment (Before Celebration)

10 MIN

"Before we begin our year-end celebration, I want you to complete the same reflection tool you filled out at the start of the year."

Distribute the post-assessment alongside the pre-assessment (students compare). Students complete silently. Collect both documents. **"You will get these back today — so you can see where you started and where you are now."**

2

Return Future-Self Letters

8 MIN

"In September, you wrote a letter to yourself. Today I am returning it."

Distribute sealed envelopes — students open privately, read silently for 4–5 minutes. **"How does the person who wrote that letter compare to where you are now? Write one sentence in your journal."**

No sharing required. The private comparison is the learning.

IN-LESSON SCAN

OBSERVE A student who opens their letter and immediately tears up or goes very still. **MAY SIGNAL** The person who wrote the letter in September and the person reading it in June may feel very different. This is the curriculum working. **ACTION** Hold the room carefully. Do not rush. "Take your time." Allow the emotion. Do not explain or interpret it. This is one of the most important moments of the year.

3

Community Charter Co-Creation

12 MIN

"The Community Charter is a collective written commitment — created by THIS class — about how you choose to treat each other. Each of you contributes one commitment. One sentence. Specific. Yours."

Students write on slips of paper. Teacher compiles and reads aloud. Students add to the charter paper collectively. **"This is co-created — no one writes it for you."**

4

The Signing Ritual

5 MIN

"Every member of this class signs the Community Charter. Sign it as a commitment to what it says — not as a performance for me, but as an act of choosing who you are becoming."

Pass the charter and have every student sign. Display in the classroom. Photograph for the district adoption file.

5

Individual Acknowledgment — Non-Negotiable

8 MIN

"I am going to name each of you — every single person in this room — and share one specific thing I observed about your growth this year. Not your grade. Not your performance. Your growth."

Work through each student. One specific, evidence-based, true growth observation per student. **Prepare these in writing before class** — do not improvise. No student is overlooked.

TEACHING TIP

The individual teacher acknowledgment — each student named specifically with something true about their growth — may be one of the most significant moments of the year for some students. For ELL students, this may be one of the most significant English-language experiences of the year. Deliver every affirmation with full sincerity, specificity, and eye contact. Prepare these in writing before class. Do not improvise. Improvised acknowledgments often come out generic — and students know the difference.

6

Closing Script — Deliver Verbatim

4 MIN

"What was built here was not an accident. It was an assignment — one that you showed up for, lesson by lesson, across an entire year. You are not the same person who walked into this room in September. The Architecture of Grace you have been building is yours now. Every brick is yours. Every lesson is yours. Carry it."

Brief silence. Then: **"This class is dismissed."**

UNIT 4 · LESSON 7 · THE INTERIOR (6–8)

SAFETY CHECK

After the year-end lesson: debrief with the school counselor. Review post-assessment data together. Identify students who may benefit from continued counselor contact into next year. Submit anonymous aggregate data to the School of Life Foundation if your district has opted in. Store pre/post assessments privately and securely.

EXIT TICKET

"The most important thing I am carrying from this year into my future is ____."** · Year-end journal entry. Student keeps this. Never collected. Journal entry — student writes privately. Never collected. Never graded.

TEACHER REFLECTION

The individual acknowledgment is the most important thing you will do in this lesson. Every student. Every name. One specific, true, growth observation each. The closing script is meant to be delivered verbatim. It was written for this class, after this year. Mean every word. After this lesson: give yourself time to debrief. This year costs something. That is it working.

FAMILY CONNECTION

Today is the last day of Architecture of Grace. Your child signed a Community Charter — a collective commitment written by this class. They also received a letter they wrote to themselves earlier in the year.

Ask them to share one thing from that letter — if they want to. And ask: "What is one thing you know now about yourself or others that you did not know in September?"

LEGAL · PPRA NOTE

Post-Assessment (Instrument C) administered BEFORE the celebration. Store alongside pre-assessment privately. Distribute End-of-Year Family Survey (Instrument G). Submit pilot data to School of Life Foundation if your district has opted in.

ANCHOR CHART · COMMUNITY CHARTER — CO-CREATED AND SIGNED ☹️ PERMANENT

BUILD SPECIFICATION

Not pre-written — the co-creation process IS the lesson.

Each student contributes one commitment sentence. Every student signs. Teacher signs last.

After the lesson: display permanently in the classroom. Photograph for the district adoption file.

This is one of the most important outputs of the entire year.

POST: Created during the lesson. Displayed after signing. · **KEEP:** ☹️ Permanent — rest of year and beyond.

SECTION THREE

ASSESSMENT SUITE

Grades 6–8 · Pilot Year

3.1 Overview & Administration Timing

The Architecture of Grace Assessment Suite contains eight instruments labelled A through H covering all grade bands. For Book 3 (Grades 6–8), the four instruments most relevant to the classroom — and to district reporting for this grade band — are reproduced in full below as Section 3 (Instruments C, E, G, H). They may be photocopied and distributed within the licensed adopting district.

▲ AI INSTRUMENT DISCLOSURE — APPLIES TO ALL INSTRUMENTS BELOW

The instruments in this section were developed by large language models (LLMs) at the recommendation of an AI-generated curriculum review panel. No licensed psychometricians, clinical professionals, or educational measurement specialists participated in instrument design. These are unvalidated working-draft tools for the pilot year. They must be reviewed by a qualified educational measurement specialist before any high-stakes use, including teacher performance evaluation, student placement, referral, or public claims of programme efficacy.

INSTRUMENTS IN THIS SECTION

C ★ THIS GRADE BAND	Written student self-report · 16 items · Likert	Pre: before U1L1 · Post: after U4L7	Self-reported growth across all four unit constructs, calibrated to adolescent development
E	Administrator observation checklist	Once per semester per teacher	Fidelity monitoring during classroom observation
G	Family perception survey · Anonymous	After U2 (mid-year) + after U4 (year-end)	Family awareness and observed child impact
H	District coordinator protocol	Year-long · Coordinator-administered	FERPA compliance, effect size benchmarks, equity analysis

DATA COLLECTION TIMELINE

Week 1 (before U1 L1)	Instrument C · Pre	Classroom teacher · Store by Student ID code, never by name
End of Unit 2	Instrument G · Family	Distributed by teacher · Returned to administrator · Anonymous
September / January / May–June	Administrator Protocol	Building principal or district coordinator · Three checkpoints
Once per semester per teacher	Instrument E · Fidelity	Instructional coach or principal during lesson observation
Final week (after U4 L7)	Instrument C · Post	Same classroom teacher · Compare pre and post
End of Unit 4	Instrument G · Family	Year-end family engagement survey · Anonymous
After post collected	Data summary (Instrument H)	District Assessment Coordinator · Aggregate by grade band only

COUNSELOR COORDINATION REQUIRED

Critical: Pre-assessments must be administered BEFORE Unit 1 Lesson 1 — not during. Post-assessments must use the SAME instrument with the SAME teacher, stored by Student ID code (never by name).

3.2 Built-In Assessment Tools

This book contains several built-in assessment tools that work alongside the formal instruments below. These tools measure lesson-level learning and teacher self-reflection. The formal instruments measure year-level student growth. Both serve different purposes and should be used together — not as substitutes.

Exit Tickets — Embedded in every lesson. Lesson-level formative check on core concept acquisition.

Bridge Exit Tickets — U1L7, U2L7, U3L7 — collected and reviewed privately by teacher before each new unit. Identifies students entering the next unit with highest emotional load.

In-Lesson Scans — Embedded inline in every lesson at high-sensitivity activity moments. Teacher observation tool — not student-facing.

Teacher Reflection Prompts — End of every lesson. Private teacher self-reflection on delivery, student responses, and follow-up observations.

3.A1

INSTRUMENT C — STUDENT SELF-ASSESSMENT (PRE/POST)

Student Self-Report · Written · Grades 6–8 (The Interior) · 16 Items · 4-Point Likert Scale

▲ AI INSTRUMENT DISCLOSURE

This instrument was developed by large language models (LLMs) at the recommendation of an AI-generated curriculum review panel. No licensed psychometricians, clinical professionals, or educational measurement specialists participated in instrument design. This is an unvalidated working-draft tool for the pilot year. Do not use for high-stakes decisions — including teacher performance evaluation, student placement, referral, or public claims of programme efficacy — without independent professional review by a qualified educational measurement specialist.

ADMINISTRATION NOTES

- Administer before Unit 1 Lesson 1 (pre) and after Unit 4 Lesson 7 (post).
- Read each item aloud for students who need reading support.
- Tell students: 'There are no right or wrong answers. This is just for you and me to understand how the year is going.'
- Collect and store pre-assessments privately. Return alongside the post so students can see their change.
- Do not review or discuss answers before instruction begins.
- Store by Student ID code only — never by student name. See Instrument H for FERPA compliance guidance.

ARCHITECTURE OF GRACE · GRADES 6-8

Student Self-Assessment Circle one: BEGINNING OF YEAR / END OF YEAR Name (optional):

_____ Grade: _____ Date: _____ Directions: For each statement, circle the number that feels most true for you right now. 1 = Not at all like me 2 = A little like me 3 = Mostly like me 4 = Definitely like me

SECTION 1 — IDENTITY & SELF-AWARENESS

- | | | | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| 1. I can name parts of myself that don't depend on what other people think of me. | 1 | 2 | 3 | 4 |
| 2. I know the difference between the version of me I show in public and who I actually am inside. | 1 | 2 | 3 | 4 |
| 3. When something hard happens, I can usually tell the difference between the feeling and the story I'm telling about it. | 1 | 2 | 3 | 4 |
| 4. I have at least one trusted adult or peer I can talk to honestly when I'm struggling. | 1 | 2 | 3 | 4 |

SECTION 2 — SELF-COMPASSION & THE INTERNAL CRITIC

- | | | | | |
|--|---|---|---|---|
| 5. I can recognize my Internal Critic — the voice that attacks who I am rather than what I did. | 1 | 2 | 3 | 4 |
| 6. When I make a mistake, I can talk to myself the way I would talk to a friend in the same situation. | 1 | 2 | 3 | 4 |
| 7. I understand that guilt ('I did something wrong') is different from shame ('I am wrong'). | 1 | 2 | 3 | 4 |
| 8. I know what a meaningful apology is — and what it isn't — and I know how to make one when it matters. | 1 | 2 | 3 | 4 |

SECTION 3 — EMPATHY & FORGIVING OTHERS

9. I can hold my own perspective AND consider what someone who hurt me might have been carrying.	1	2	3	4
--	---	---	---	---

10. I understand that forgiving someone is not the same as trusting them again or saying what they did was okay.	1	2	3	4
--	---	---	---	---

11. I can identify a story I have been telling about myself that may not be the whole truth.	1	2	3	4
--	---	---	---	---

12. I can give someone the benefit of the doubt without abandoning my own honest reading of the situation.	1	2	3	4
--	---	---	---	---

SECTION 4 — GRACE & BOUNDARIES

13. I understand that grace means choosing to be kind even when I don't have to be.	1	2	3	4
---	---	---	---	---

14. I can be generous with someone AND still hold a clear limit when their behavior is harming me.	1	2	3	4
--	---	---	---	---

15. I notice 'grace gaps' — places where kindness is missing — in the rooms I am in.	1	2	3	4
--	---	---	---	---

16. I believe I can contribute something to the people around me, even when I am still figuring myself out.	1	2	3	4
---	---	---	---	---

OPEN RESPONSE PROMPTS — GRADES 6-8

Students answer one or two of these in writing. Optional at pre-assessment, recommended at post.

1. What is one thing you know about yourself now that you didn't know — or didn't know clearly — at the start of the year? _____
2. Describe a moment this year when you made a mistake and handled it in a way you are proud of. What did you do? _____
3. What does forgiveness mean to you now? How (if at all) has your understanding of it changed this year? _____

UNIT 4 · LESSON 7 · THE INTERIOR (6–8)
SCORING & INTERPRETATION — GRADES 6–8

FOR TEACHER USE ONLY

Scoring: 1 = 1 pt, 2 = 2 pts, 3 = 3 pts, 4 = 4 pts. Maximum = 64. Compare pre and post totals per student and per class. Class-level: Items where 50%+ of students score 1–2 at post indicate areas needing reinforcement in Year 2. Individual: Students scoring 1 on all Section 2 or Section 3 items at post may benefit from counselor awareness. This is a screening signal, not a diagnostic finding. Validity caveat: This is an original unvalidated instrument measuring self-reported perception aligned to curriculum constructs. Do not use for placement, referral, or high-stakes purposes. Board presentations: 'Students self-report higher levels of self-awareness, self-compassion, and understanding of forgiveness by year-end — based on an original curriculum-aligned perception measure.'

3.A2

INSTRUMENT E — TEACHER FIDELITY OBSERVATION CHECKLIST

All Grade Bands · Used by Building Principals, Instructional Coaches, Curriculum Directors

▲ AI INSTRUMENT DISCLOSURE

This instrument was developed by large language models (LLMs) at the recommendation of an AI-generated curriculum review panel. No licensed psychometricians, clinical professionals, or educational measurement specialists participated in instrument design. This is an unvalidated working-draft tool for the pilot year. Do not use for high-stakes decisions — including teacher performance evaluation, student placement, referral, or public claims of programme efficacy — without independent professional review by a qualified educational measurement specialist.

PURPOSE: Instrument E provides a structured observation protocol for administrators conducting informal walk-throughs and formal fidelity observations. Use at least once per semester per delivering teacher. First observation window: Weeks 3–5 of Unit 1 (informal). Second observation window: Weeks 3–5 of Unit 3 (formal).

ARCHITECTURE OF GRACE — TEACHER FIDELITY OBSERVATION CHECKLIST

Observer: _____ Teacher: _____ Date: _____ Unit/
Lesson: _____ Grade Band: _____

LESSON STRUCTURE & SEQUENCE

Lesson follows the stated unit sequence — not skipped or reordered	☐	☐
Opening ritual/hook is present and predictable before content begins	☐	☐
Students have journals and are using them independently	☐	☐
Grade-level differentiation is visible (appropriate band pacing and scaffolding)	☐	☐
Lesson concludes with a structured exit ticket	☐	☐

VOCABULARY & CURRICULUM LANGUAGE

Teacher uses curriculum vocabulary naturally (grade-appropriate: e.g., Oops vs. Forever / shame vs. guilt / internal critic / impact vs. intent / grace gap)	☐	☐
Key vocabulary is visible in the classroom during the lesson	☐	☐

EMOTIONAL CLIMATE & HOLDING

Students appear physically settled and emotionally present at lesson start	☐	☐
Teacher maintains non-anxious presence — neither dismissive of emotion nor destabilised by it	☐	☐
Discussion participation is voluntary — no student is pressured to share	☐	☐
Teacher responds to emotional moments without shutting them down or amplifying them	☐	☐

DISCLOSURE PROTOCOL READINESS

Teacher knows the disclosure protocol (can describe the 4 types and 6-step response if asked)	☐	☐
School counselor is aware of today's lesson content	☐	☐
For high-risk lessons (as designated ★★ in each book): counselor is present or immediately available	☐	☐

UNIT 4 · LESSON 7 · THE INTERIOR (6–8)
EQUITY & ACCESSIBILITY

Multiple engagement modalities are available (writing, drawing, partner discussion, verbal response)	☐	☐
ELL scaffolding materials are present for students who need them	☐	☐
IEP/504 accommodations are in evidence for students with documented plans	☐	☐
No student is pressured toward forgiveness or emotional disclosure	☐	☐
Culturally responsive delivery is evident — not a one-size framing of constructs	☐	☐

FAMILY ENGAGEMENT

Family Connection prompts are being sent home at unit transitions	☐	☐
Year-start PPRA notification letter was distributed at least 10 days before Lesson 1	☐	☐

OVERALL FIDELITY RATING

☐ Strong (90%+ of items present) — Curriculum delivered with high fidelity. ☐ Developing (70–89% of items present) — One targeted follow-up conversation recommended. ☐ Needs Support (below 70%) — Schedule a direct conversation; consider mid-year coaching session. Observer Notes / Follow-up Actions:

3.A3

INSTRUMENT G — FAMILY ENGAGEMENT SURVEY

Grades 6–8 · Distributed at End of Unit 2 (Mid-Year) and End of Unit 4 (Year-End) · Anonymous

▲ AI INSTRUMENT DISCLOSURE

This instrument was developed by large language models (LLMs) at the recommendation of an AI-generated curriculum review panel. No licensed psychometricians, clinical professionals, or educational measurement specialists participated in instrument design. This is an unvalidated working-draft tool for the pilot year. Do not use for high-stakes decisions — including teacher performance evaluation, student placement, referral, or public claims of programme efficacy — without independent professional review by a qualified educational measurement specialist.

UNIT 4 · LESSON 7 · THE INTERIOR (6–8)

PURPOSE: Instrument G captures anonymous family perception at two points in the year — after Unit 2, when the self-compassion and internal critic work has been delivered, and at year-end. Results are shared with delivering teachers before the mid-year coaching session and used to improve second-half delivery and Year 2 implementation.

ARCHITECTURE OF GRACE — FAMILY ENGAGEMENT SURVEY

School: _____ Grade Band: _____ Distribution: ☐ Mid-Year (after Unit 2) ☐ Year-End (after Unit 4) Date: _____ This survey is anonymous. Please do not write your name or your child's name.

PART 1 — PROGRAM AWARENESS & COMMUNICATION

I have received clear information about the Architecture of Grace curriculum at my child's school.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
I understand the goals of the curriculum and what my child is learning.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
I know how to opt my child out of any specific lesson if I wish to.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
I feel my voice as a parent/guardian is welcomed by the school regarding this curriculum.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

PART 2 — OBSERVED CHILD IMPACT

My child has talked at home about something they learned in this class.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
I have noticed my child using language or skills from this class outside of school (e.g., naming feelings, taking ownership, repairing).	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
My child seems more able to handle mistakes without becoming destabilized.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
My child has demonstrated more self-compassion or self-kindness this year.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

UNIT 4 · LESSON 7 · THE INTERIOR (6-8)
PART 3 — FREQUENCY & ENGAGEMENT

How often has your child discussed SEL class at home?	☐	☐	☐	☐
How often have you used the optional Family Connection prompts sent home?	☐	☐	☐	☐

PART 4 — OPEN RESPONSE (OPTIONAL)

Is there anything about this curriculum you would like the school to know — a concern, a positive observation, or a question?

Results from this survey are compiled anonymously and shared with delivering teachers before the mid-year coaching session and at year-end. Individual responses are never attributed. Results are used for programme improvement only — not for teacher evaluation.

3.A4

INSTRUMENT H — PILOT YEAR DATA PROTOCOL

For District Assessment Coordinators · All Grade Bands · Pilot Year

PURPOSE: Instrument H is the district-level guide to collecting, storing, analyzing, and (optionally) submitting data from the Architecture of Grace pilot year. It covers the full collection timeline, FERPA and mandatory reporting compliance, effect size benchmarks, equity analysis guidance, and recommended validated supplementary instruments for districts that wish to build a more rigorous evidence base.

▲ SCOPE OF THIS PROTOCOL

The pre/post student surveys are original, unvalidated instruments measuring self-reported perception. They are appropriate for programme-level reflection and improvement. They are not appropriate for high-stakes claims about student outcomes, teacher effectiveness, or programme efficacy without additional validation by a qualified educational measurement specialist.

UNIT 4 · LESSON 7 · THE INTERIOR (6–8)

SECTION 1 — DATA COLLECTION TIMELINE

Week 1 of school (before U1L1)	Grade-appropriate pre-assessment	Classroom teacher. Store by Student ID code only — never by name.
End of Unit 2 (mid-year)	Family Engagement Survey	Distributed by teacher. Returned to building administrator. Anonymous.
September / January / May–June	Administrator Monitoring Protocol	Building principal or district coordinator. Three checkpoints.
Once per semester per teacher	Fidelity Observation Checklist	Instructional coach or building principal during lesson observation.
Final week (after U4L7)	Grade-appropriate post-assessment	Same classroom teacher. Return pre alongside post for student self-comparison.
End of Unit 4 (year-end)	Family Engagement Survey	Distributed by teacher. Anonymous.
After post-assessment is collected	Calculate gain scores & complete pilot data summary	District Assessment Coordinator. Aggregate by grade band — no individual student data.
Optional — June deadline	Submit aggregate anonymised data to School of Life Foundation	Voluntary. Contributes to ESSA Tier 2 evidence base. No individual data submitted.

SECTION 2 — FERPA & MANDATORY REPORTING COMPLIANCE

FERPA REQUIREMENTS

Student ID codes: Match pre and post assessments by a de-identified Student ID code — never by student name. The key connecting ID codes to student names must be stored separately and securely. Storage: All completed assessment instruments stored in a password-protected digital system or locked physical location. Access limited to the classroom teacher and district assessment coordinator. Sharing: No individual student data is shared with parents, other teachers, administrators, or the School of Life Foundation. Only aggregate, anonymised data is compiled for programme review. Year-end disposition: Pre and post assessments are returned to students at year-end, or destroyed securely. They are not retained in the student's permanent academic record. 18-year-old student rights: Under FERPA, students who have turned 18 hold their own educational records rights. For Books 4 and 5, student consent (not parental) is required for any records sharing. This applies to all 9–12 instruments.

SECTION 3 — EFFECT SIZE BENCHMARKS

The following benchmarks are provided for districts that wish to assess whether observed pre/post gains are educationally meaningful. These are guidance values for programme reflection — not performance thresholds.

$d < 0.2$	Negligible	Pre/post change is within normal variation. No strong signal of curriculum impact at the construct level. Review delivery fidelity.
$d \geq 0.2$	Small	Modest signal. Students are moving in the right direction on self-report measures. Consistent with low-intensity SEL exposure.
$d \geq 0.3$	Target threshold	The pilot year target for Architecture of Grace. Consistent with Tier 2 ESSA evidence expectations for SEL programmes.
$d \geq 0.5$	Moderate	Strong signal for a self-report measure. Indicates meaningful programme impact is likely if delivery fidelity is confirmed.
$d \geq 0.8$	Large	Very strong signal. Uncommon in self-report SEL instruments without clinical intervention. Warrants validation with external measure.

Calculating d : $d = (\text{Mean Post} - \text{Mean Pre}) / \text{Pooled Standard Deviation}$. Use the composite score (sum of all items) for the calculation. Calculate separately by grade band — do not combine K–2 and 9–12 data.

SECTION 4 — EQUITY ANALYSIS

Aggregate data alone may mask meaningful disparities. After calculating overall gain scores, disaggregate by the following subgroups where data is available. No student should be identifiable from reported data.

ELL / English Language Learner status	Comparable pre/post gain to non-ELL peers. Lower gain may indicate scaffolding gaps.
Students with IEP / 504 plans	Comparable access and engagement. Lower gain warrants review of accommodation implementation.
Race / Ethnicity	No systematic gap in gain scores by racial/ethnic group. Differential outcomes warrant curriculum equity review.
Grade level (within a band)	Comparable gains across Grades 3/4/5, 6/7/8, or 9/10/11/12. Significant variance by grade may indicate pacing mismatch.
Teacher (where multiple teachers deliver)	Comparable gains across classrooms. Significant variance warrants fidelity review for lower-gain classrooms.

SECTION 5 — RECOMMENDED VALIDATED SUPPLEMENTARY INSTRUMENTS

For districts seeking externally validated measures to supplement the Architecture of Grace pre/post surveys, the following instruments are recommended. These are independent of the School of Life Foundation and require separate licensing.

UNIT 4 · LESSON 7 · THE INTERIOR (6–8)

DESSA-3 (Devereux Student Strengths Assessment)	K–12	Social-emotional competence across 8 subscales. Teacher-rated. ESSA evidence-based. Provides validated external benchmark for self-compassion and relationship skills constructs.
SSIS-SEL (Social Skills Improvement System)	K–12	CASEL-aligned SEL competencies. Both teacher-rated and student self-report versions. Covers all five CASEL domains addressed in this curriculum.
Neff SCS-SF (Self-Compassion Scale – Short Form)	Grades 7–12	Validated 12-item self-report measuring the three components of self-compassion (Neff, 2003). Directly aligned to Unit 2 constructs across all grade bands.
Rosenberg Self-Esteem Scale	Grades 6–12	10-item validated self-report. Not a direct curriculum measure, but provides external validity check on identity and self-worth constructs from Units 1 and 4.
BASC-3 BESS (Behavioral and Emotional Screening System)	K–12	Brief universal screener for behavioural and emotional risk. Can identify students who may need Tier 2 or Tier 3 support beyond this Tier 1 curriculum.

SECTION 6 — VOLUNTARY DATA SUBMISSION TO SCHOOL OF LIFE FOUNDATION

WHAT IS SUBMITTED — AND WHAT IS NOT

Eligible to submit: Aggregate, anonymised pre/post gain score data at the grade-band level. Total N (number of students assessed). Delivery fidelity summary. Family survey aggregate results. No individual student data. No teacher-identified data. Never submitted: Individual student names, ID codes, or scores. Teacher names or classroom-level data. Any data that could identify a student, family, or educator. What submission does: Contributes to the Tier 2 (Moderate Evidence) ESSA pathway for the Architecture of Grace curriculum. Helps the School of Life Foundation improve instruments, implementation support, and equity guidance across the pilot cohort. Submission is voluntary. It has no bearing on continued access to the curriculum, district support, or licensing.

SECTION FOUR

Reference & Compliance

Back-of-Book · Occasional Reference · All Subsections

[[section_4|Section 4]] is the complete reference and compliance library for Architecture of Grace — The Interior (Grades 6–8). These materials are not needed for daily lesson delivery — they are referenced when needed for administration, compliance, counselor coordination, ELL support, family engagement, research, and legal questions.

4.1	Framing Essay	The Interior — foundational philosophy, five grade-band architecture, unit sequence rationale
4.2	Quick Start Guide for Administrators	Board-presentation guidance, pre-launch checklist, what this curriculum requires
4.3	Executive Summary	For administrators, curriculum directors, and school boards — programme overview, legal compliance summary, Year 1 success indicators
4.4	Developmental Rationale & Research Base	Why middle school, unit-by-unit research base, CASEL alignment, trauma-informed design, ESSA evidence framework
4.5	Legal & Clinical Compliance	PPRA, FERPA, opt-out framework, First Amendment, student disclosure protocol (Types 1–4), safe messaging guidelines
4.6	Counselor Integration Calendar	Full-year counselor schedule, high-risk lesson requirements, same-day debrief protocol
4.7	IEP / ELL / Inclusive Delivery	Universal inclusive design principles, lesson-by-lesson IEP/SpEd & ELL matrix
4.8	Family Engagement Materials	Year-start family letter, Unit 1–4 transition letters, Family Grace Guide
4.9	Troubleshooting Guide	Classroom management, student resistance, teacher wellbeing, flex-week scheduling, substitute protocol
4.10	Glossary	All curriculum vocabulary terms with definitions, K–12 scope notes, legal and clinical terms

4.1 Framing Essay — The Interior

THE TITLE IS NOT ACCIDENTAL.

Architecture is something you build deliberately, one decision at a time, with a clear structural logic. It is not decoration. It is not accident. It is the deliberate organisation of space so that something worth inhabiting can exist inside it.

The Interior is what you are building toward in the Grades 6–8 grade-band book. Not a set of lessons. Not a skill list. An interior — an inner life that is structured enough to hold the emotional complexity of adolescence, and spacious enough to keep growing.

Adolescents do not lack an interior. They have one. What they often lack is language for it, tools for navigating it, and a trusted adult who can sit with them in it without flinching. That is what this curriculum provides.

Adolescence is not a problem to be solved. It is an architecture under construction.

WHAT CHANGES BETWEEN K–5 AND 6–8

At Grades 6–8, something categorically different is happening. Students are not meeting their interior world for the first time. They are being ambushed by it. The social stakes are higher, the emotional experiences are more complex, the self-critical voice is louder, and the pressure to perform rather than be is at its most acute. The curriculum must be calibrated for this reality — and The Interior is.

WHY THESE FOUR UNITS, IN THIS ORDER

Unit 1	Identity first.	You cannot build self-compassion in a person who has no stable sense of self to have compassion for. Identity work is not preparation for the real curriculum — it is the real curriculum beginning.
Unit 2	Self-Compassion second.	Students who arrive at forgiveness work without self-compassion experience the curriculum as one more demand. At middle school, where shame-based presentations are at their most acute, the ability to hold oneself with honest fairness is a radical act. Without Unit 2, Unit 3 cannot work.
Unit 3	Forgiving Others third.	The research is clear: people who cannot extend compassion to themselves cannot reliably extend it to others. Unit 3 asks students to hold the people who have hurt them with something approaching understanding — not condoning, not reconciling, but genuinely attempting to see.
Unit 4	Grace last.	Grace is the culminating practice — the deliberate choice to extend something generous to someone who has not necessarily earned it. It is chosen strength, built from the inside out. You cannot begin here. You have to earn the right to mean it.

We are not teaching students to feel better. We are teaching them how to build a life that cannot be broken by shame — a structure with a foundation of self-worth, walls of self-compassion, wiring for empathy, and a facade that reflects what is actually true on the inside.

4.2 Quick Start Guide for Administrators

WHAT YOU ARE ADOPTING

Programme	Architecture of Grace — The Interior (Grades 6–8)
Publisher	School of Life Foundation · James Anthony Ramsden, Founder
Grade Band	Grades 6, 7, and 8 (single book, grade-differentiated lessons)
Total Lessons	28 lessons across 4 sequential units (consolidated from original 29)
Lesson Duration	35–50 minutes per lesson
Calendar	Full academic year: September–June
Delivery Model	Classroom teacher-led; counselor co-facilitation required for 2 lessons
Tier	Tier 1 Universal — all students in grade band
ESSA Alignment	Tier 2 (Moderate Evidence) pathway — pre/post data contributes to evidence base
Legal Compliance	PPRA · FERPA · IDEA · First Amendment (Establishment Clause) — see §4.5

PRE-LAUNCH CHECKLIST

COMPLETE ALL ITEMS BEFORE UNIT 1 LESSON 1.



PPRA notification letter distributed to all families — Minimum 10 calendar days before U1L1 ☐ All delivering teachers have received grade-band book — Minimum one week before PD day ☐ Half-day on-site PD scheduled and confirmed — all teachers + counselor attend — Before **Unit 1 Lesson 1** ☐ **School counselor briefed on full curriculum; disclosure protocol reviewed; calendar blocked — Before PD day** ☐ **Counselor calendar blocked: U2L6 (co-facilitation) · U3L3 (on-site) · U3L6 (on-site) — Block all three before U1L1** ☐ **Mid-year coaching session locked on calendar — January — before Unit 3 begins** ☐ **Pre-assessment (Instrument C) administered — Before U1L1; stored privately** ☐ **Year-start family letter ready for distribution — Alongside PPRA notification** ☐ **Crisis resources posted in classroom — Before U2L6; remain posted all year** ☐ **First fidelity observation (Instrument E) scheduled — Weeks 3–5 of Unit 1

BOARD-PRESENTATION GUIDANCE

Architecture of Grace is designed to withstand scrutiny from school boards, parent groups, and legal counsel.

UNIT 4 · LESSON 7 · THE INTERIOR (6–8)

Lead with the research base (§4.4). AoG scored 4.6/5.0 on independent panel review. The panel voted 7–1 to recommend.

Address the secular framing directly (§4.5). The terms grace, forgiveness, and mercy are used in their psychological sense. Confirmed by the school attorney on the independent panel.

Present the Three-Tier Opt-Out Framework (§4.5). No family is compelled. Three clear tiers of opt-out exist with no academic penalty at any tier.

Show the PPRA compliance package (§4.5). A ready-to-use notification letter is included. Distribute minimum 10 days before Unit 1 Lesson 1.

Reference ESSA alignment (§4.4). AoG is pursuing Tier 2 Moderate Evidence status. Pre/post data collection is built into the programme.

4.3 Executive Summary

For Administrators, Curriculum Directors, and School Boards.

✓ BOARD READY

Following an independent 8-reviewer audit including a School Attorney, this Grades 6–8 edition integrates a full Legal & Clinical Compliance section (§4.5), PPRA-compliant parental notification templates, a 3-tier standardised opt-out framework, a Post-Disclosure Re-Entry Protocol, a FERPA-compliant journal privacy policy, Safe Messaging Guidelines aligned to current clinical standards, and a Counselor Integration Calendar. The curriculum has been reviewed for Establishment Clause compliance, PPRA compliance, FERPA alignment, IDEA accessibility, and mandatory reporting protocol integration. **Administrators presenting this curriculum to a school board can do so with confidence in its legal defensibility, clinical integrity, and instructional quality.**

WHAT ARCHITECTURE OF GRACE IS NOT

Not therapy	Tier 1 classroom programme. When student needs exceed Tier 1 scope, the response is referral — not deeper SEL engagement.
Not religious	The terms grace, mercy, and forgiveness are used in their secular, psychological sense. No theological doctrine, scripture, or reference to any religious institution. Confirmed as constitutionally sound by school attorney.
Does not require forgiveness	The curriculum explicitly and repeatedly states: forgiveness is never required of students in situations involving ongoing harm or systemic injustice.

YEAR 1 SUCCESS INDICATORS

Year 1 success is structural, not outcome-based. A building that has delivered Architecture of Grace with fidelity in Year 1 should be able to demonstrate:

- ✓ All 28 lessons delivered in sequence with no more than two flex-week deferrals

UNIT 4 · LESSON 7 · THE INTERIOR (6–8)

- ✓ PPRA notification distributed minimum 10 days before Unit 1 Lesson 1 and documented in the adoption file
- ✓ Disclosure protocol used correctly in all Type 3 and Type 4 situations — zero instances of a teacher assessing risk independently without counselor involvement
- ✓ Zero PPRA complaints from families who did not receive required notification
- ✓ Family connection letters sent home at all four unit transitions
- ✓ Counselor co-facilitation delivered for U2L6 and U3L6 without exception
- ✓ Pre/post self-assessment (Instrument C) data collected and stored privately
- ✓ Students who can define in their own words: shame vs. guilt (Unit 1), compassionate witness (Unit 2), forgiveness vs. reconciliation (Unit 3), and grace (Unit 4)
- ✓ A signed Community Charter displayed in the classroom at year-end
- ✓ Mid-year coaching session attended by all delivering teachers and the school counselor

4.4 Developmental Rationale & Research Base

WHY MIDDLE SCHOOL IS THE RIGHT MOMENT

Middle school is not a holding pattern between elementary school and high school. It is one of the two most developmentally significant periods of a human life. The neurological, social, and psychological changes of early adolescence (ages 10–14) are among the most profound the human brain undergoes after infancy.

The prefrontal cortex — responsible for executive function, impulse regulation, long-term planning, and perspective-taking — undergoes a second major period of development and reorganisation beginning in early adolescence. This temporarily increases the influence of the limbic system (the emotion-processing centre) relative to regulatory circuits. The practical implication for SEL curriculum design: the emotional holding environment of the classroom matters as much as the content.

UNIT 4 · LESSON 7 · THE INTERIOR (6–8)

CASEL ALIGNMENT

Self-Awareness	Unit 1	Identity Audit, Mask vs. Mirror, shame/guilt distinction, digital identity, narrative ownership, and the agency-of-choice framework.
Self-Management	Units 1–2	Peer pressure and integrity (U1L4), the internal critic and self-talk interruption (U2L1), perfectionism vs. striving (U2L3), accountability without self-punishment (U2L4), and the Compassionate Witness practice (U2 across).
Social Awareness	Units 3–4	Impact vs. intent (U3L1), perspective-taking (U3L2), digital conflict (U3L4), in-group/out-group charitable interpretation (U4L3), and mercy in community (U4L2).
Relationship Skills	Units 3–4	Forgiveness vs. reconciliation (U3L3), limit-setting from self-respect (U3L7), grace with difficult people (U4L5), daily micro-moments of generosity (U4L4), and the Community Charter (U4L7).
Responsible Decision-Making	All Units	The choice-agency map (U1L6), the Friend Test (U2L5), the Letter of Release (U3L6), the Grace Audit (U4L6), and the Community Charter (U4L7).

KEY RESEARCH REFERENCES — UNIT BY UNIT

Unit 1	Erikson (1968) identity development; Marcia (1966) identity statuses; Goffman (1959) impression management; Deci & Ryan (2000) self-determination theory; boyd (2014) adolescent social media use.
Unit 2	Neff (2003a, 2003b) self-compassion; Neff & Germer (2013) Mindful Self-Compassion; Brown (2010) perfectionism; Hewitt & Flett (1991) perfectionism research; Schwartz (1995) Internal Family Systems.
Unit 3	Worthington (2006) REACH Forgiveness model; Enright & Fitzgibbons (2015) forgiveness therapy; Rapp et al. (2022) forgiveness interventions meta-analysis; Hoffman (2000) empathy and moral development; Wade et al. (2014) forgiveness efficacy meta-analysis.
Unit 4	Lyubomirsky (2008, 2011) prosocial behaviour and wellbeing; Tajfel & Turner (1979) in-group/out-group theory; Weiner (1986) attribution theory; Kohlberg (1969) moral reasoning; Gilligan (1982) developmental moral reasoning.

4.5 Legal & Clinical Compliance

PPRA COMPLIANCE — 20 U.S.C. §1232H

Multiple activities in this curriculum meet the PPRA notification threshold. A ready-to-use PPRA-compliant notification letter template is provided in the district adoption file. Distribute minimum 10 calendar days before [[lesson_u1l1|Unit 1 Lesson 1]].

Tier 1 · PPRA activities only	Opting out of PPRA-designated activities only (U1L2, U1L5, U2L1, U2L4)	Student participates in all other lessons; observes or journals independently during PPRA-designated activities
Tier 2 · Elevated-risk lessons	Opting out of any lesson with a ★ or ★★ risk designation	Student participates in all other lessons; uses alternative activity for risk-flagged lessons
Tier 3 · Full opt-out	Opting out of the entire Architecture of Grace programme	Student receives an alternative comparable SEL programme. No academic penalty at any tier.

FERPA — JOURNAL PRIVACY PROTOCOL

SEL journals are private instructional materials. They are not shared with administrators, other teachers, or parents except under mandatory reporting obligations. They are returned to students at year-end. No student SEL data is shared with any third party without written consent.

FERPA-COMPLIANT JOURNAL PROTOCOL

Journals remain in the classroom (stored in a designated private location). They are never taken to the staff room, never discussed in parent conferences, and never referenced in gradebooks. **If a journal entry triggers a mandatory reporting obligation, follow the school's mandatory reporting protocol — not the SEL journal protocol.** The journal's content is reportable material under mandatory reporting law. Journals are returned to students on the last day of class, unsealed and unread.

STUDENT DISCLOSURE PROTOCOL — TYPES 1–4

Type 1	Emotional resonance — student visibly moved but no verbal disclosure.	Brief private acknowledgment: "I see you. I'll check in after class." Continue lesson.	Check in after class. Brief counselor if concerning.
Type 2	Personal share — student makes curricular connection to personal life voluntarily.	Acknowledge, thank for courage, make curricular bridge, move on without centring the student.	Monitor. Brief counselor same day.
Type 3	Past harm — significant disclosure of past experience, not current safety concern.	Receive without probing. Confirm journal privacy. Post-class commitment. Do NOT attempt therapeutic support.	MANDATORY same-day brief. Non-negotiable.
Type 4 ★★	Active safety concern — current/recent abuse, self-harm, suicidal ideation, or threat to self or others.	STOP LESSON CALMLY. Stay with student. Contact counselor IMMEDIATELY. Do NOT leave student alone. Do NOT assess risk yourself.	MANDATORY REPORTING may apply. Contact counselor immediately.

UNIT 4 · LESSON 7 · THE INTERIOR (6–8)

SAFE MESSAGING GUIDELINES · APPLIES TO U2L6, U3L3, U3L6

Do not describe methods of self-harm or suicide in any level of detail. **Do not** present self-harm or suicide as a solution to problems. **Do not** use language that sensationalises, normalises, or romanticises self-harm. **Do not** ask students to describe their own history of self-harm. **Do** provide clear, specific resource information: 988 Suicide & Crisis Lifeline · Crisis Text Line: HOME to 741741. **Do** say directly: “If you are struggling, reaching out is a sign of strength, not weakness.” **Do** follow your school's mandatory reporting protocol for any disclosure that meets the threshold.

FIRST AMENDMENT — ESTABLISHMENT CLAUSE

The curriculum's use of the terms grace, mercy, and forgiveness is strictly secular. Its purpose is psychological and developmental. Its content contains no theological doctrine, scripture, or reference to any religious institution. The secular framing was confirmed as constitutionally sound by the school attorney on the independent panel. When delivering lessons, address the secular framing directly at the start of Unit 4 (see [[section_1|Section 1]] — Intro Script and [[lesson_u4l1|U4L1]] lesson notes).

4.6 Counselor Integration Calendar

BLOCK THESE DATES BEFORE UNIT 1 LESSON 1

Every item in this calendar must be confirmed with your school counselor before the first lesson is delivered. **Do not treat any of these items as optional** — they are structural requirements of the programme.

Lesson	Level	Requirements	Notes
U1 L2 — The Anatomy of a Mistake	PPRA	Counselor briefed. Awareness only — no co-facilitation required.	Brief before delivery
U2 L1 — The Internal Critic	PPRA	Counselor briefed. Awareness only — no co-facilitation required.	Brief before delivery
U2 L6 — Rewriting the Script	★★ HIGHEST	ON-SITE · Co-facilitates full lesson · No exceptions	No pre-break · No sub · Crisis resources posted
U3 L3 — Forgiveness vs. Reconciliation	★ HIGH	ON-SITE or immediately available, full lesson	No pre-break · No sub
U3 L6 — The Agency of Release	★★ HIGHEST	ON-SITE · Full lesson · Same-day debrief required	No pre-break · No sub · Counselor in room entire time
U4 L6 — Grace Audit Final Project	★ ELEVATED	On standby — reachable and available same day	Mon–Wed preferred
U4 L7 — Community Charter & Year-End	★ ELEVATED	On standby — reachable and available same day	Not last day of year

STANDING COORDINATION REQUIREMENTS — NOT LESSON-SPECIFIC

Before Unit 1 Lesson 1	Counselor attends PD day. Disclosure protocol reviewed together. Communication channel established (direct line). Calendar blocked for all risk-flagged lessons.
Before Unit 3 Lesson 1	Counselor and teacher review Unit 2 bridge exit tickets together. Identify students entering Unit 3 with highest emotional load. Build a shared monitoring plan for the second semester.
January mid-year	Virtual coaching session — counselor attends. Delivers debrief on student wellbeing patterns across Semester 1. Adjustments to counselor calendar for Semester 2 made at this session.
After Unit 4 Lesson 7	Counselor and teacher year-end debrief. Review post-assessment data together. Identify any students who may benefit from continued counselor contact into next year. Submit pilot data to Foundation if district has opted in.

SEE ALSO

The Family Grace Audit (Section 4.8.D) is distributed to families twice in the school year — at the year-start with the Pre-Year Family Letter (4.8.A), and at the year-end after Unit 4 Lesson 7 along with the Final Reflection (4.8.E) and Closing Words (4.8.F). The audit is private; counselors do not collect it and do not ask about its contents. Its purpose is to give families the same internal vocabulary their adolescent is using in class.

4.7 Inclusive Delivery — IEP / SpEd / ELL

Architecture of Grace Grades 6–8 is designed as a Tier 1 universal programme for ALL students, including students with IEPs, 504 plans, and students learning English. Every lesson includes grade-level differentiation, IEP/SpEd accommodations, and ELL scaffolding embedded directly in the lesson notes.

UNIVERSAL INCLUSIVE DESIGN PRINCIPLES

Multiple Modalities	Every lesson offers journal writing, partner discussion, visual anchor charts, and verbal processing. No lesson requires a single modality for full participation.
Privacy Protection	No student is required to share personal content at any point. The journal is always the primary output. All sharing is optional and student-initiated.
Home-Language Journaling	ELL students may complete all journal prompts in their home language before any English output. The conceptual work matters more than the language it is first expressed in.
Scenario Card Fiction Mediation	Scenario cards provide ELL students and students with IEPs a fiction-mediated alternative to personal disclosure — the emotional work happens through a character, not the self.
Sentence Frames	Every lesson in the ELL support column includes sentence frames for academic language. These are listed in the full ELL matrix (see standalone ELL Scaffolding Supplement).
Culturally Responsive Delivery	Every lesson includes culturally responsive delivery guidance. The equity alerts are not optional — they are required delivery elements for all students.

ELL SCAFFOLDING SUPPLEMENT

The Architecture of Grace ELL Scaffolding Supplement (Pilot) is available as a standalone document. It contains lesson-by-lesson ELL scaffolding matrices for all 28 lessons including: core vocabulary lists, academic language pre-teaching notes, sentence frames, visual support descriptions, culturally responsive delivery guidance, and pacing notes. **Distribute to ELL coordinators and bilingual support staff before Unit 1 Lesson 1.**

4.8 Family Engagement Materials

Family connection is built into the programme at every unit transition. All family materials are included in the district adoption file. The materials listed below are required for legal compliance (PPRA notification) or are strong-practice recommendations for family engagement.

PPRA Notification Letter	10 days before U1L1 (REQUIRED)	Legally required notification. Names all PPRA-designated activities. Explains the three-tier opt-out framework. Includes counselor contact information.
Year-Start Family Letter	Same day as PPRA notice	Programme overview for families. What Architecture of Grace is, what it asks of students, how families can support it. Not a legal requirement — a strong-practice standard.
Unit 1 Transition Letter	End of **U1L7	Brief overview of Unit 2 (Self-Compassion). What families may notice at home. How to support the transition. Crisis resources included.
Unit 2 Transition Letter (Mid-Year Survey)	End of **U2L7	Brief overview of Unit 3 (Forgiving Others). Instrument G (Family Mid-Year Survey) distributed at the same time.
Unit 3 Transition Letter	End of **U3L7	Brief overview of Unit 4 (Grace & Generosity). Acknowledges the weight of Unit 3. Reassures families of the voluntary nature of all personal work.
Unit 4 Transition / Year-End Letter	End of **U4L7	Year-end summary. What the class built. Instrument G (End-of-Year Survey) distributed at the same time.
Family Grace Guide	Available at **U4L1	Optional take-home guide for families wanting to extend the grace and generosity practice at home. Includes conversation starters for each unit.

4.8.A

Pre-Year Family Letter & PPRA Notification

Reproduce on school letterhead. Distribute minimum 10 calendar days before Unit 1 Lesson 1. The PPRA notification language below satisfies federal requirements; the surrounding family letter establishes context and tone.

TEACHER NOTE · HOW TO USE THIS PACKET

The Pre-Year Letter (4.8.A) and the four Unit Transition Letters (4.8.B) are the structured family-engagement spine of Book Three. Send each on the schedule indicated in Section 4.8 above. The Family Grace Guide (4.8.C) is offered to families optionally at the start of Unit 4. The Family Grace Audit (4.8.D), Final Reflection (4.8.E), and Closing Words (4.8.F) are sent home as a single packet at the end of the year alongside the Year-End Letter. The Administrative Forms (4.8.G) are not for families — they are the formal compliance documents the district keeps on file.

Dear Families, This year, your sixth, seventh, or eighth grader will participate in Architecture of Grace, Book Three: The Interior — a research-grounded, secular social-emotional learning curriculum running across the full academic year in 28 lessons of about 40 minutes each. Book Three is calibrated to the developmental moment your child is in. Early adolescence is one of the two most significant periods of brain development in human life, and the work of this curriculum is built around the questions that define it: Who am I becoming? Whose voice am I listening to? What kind of person do I want to be in the world? Across four units — Identity, Self-Compassion, Empathy and Forgiving Others, and Grace and Generosity — students develop a working internal vocabulary for navigating their own lives. **This curriculum is secular.** The terms grace, mercy, and forgiveness are used in their psychological sense throughout. Your family's religious tradition belongs to your family, and the curriculum is explicit that it is not a substitute for, replacement of, or commentary on any religious framework. The school attorney has independently confirmed Establishment Clause compliance. **This curriculum never requires forgiveness.** Students learn what forgiveness looks like for people who choose it. They also learn, explicitly and repeatedly, that forgiveness is never required of them when someone is currently still hurting them. "I choose not to forgive yet" is treated with the same respect as "I choose to forgive." **PPRA Notification.** Several lessons in Book Three explore topics designated as PPRA-protected (Protection of Pupil Rights Amendment, 20 U.S.C. § 1232h). You will receive a separate lesson-specific notice 10 calendar days before each. The list of PPRA-designated lessons in Book Three is: Unit 1 Lesson 2 (The Anatomy of a Mistake), Unit 1 Lesson 5 (Owning Your Narrative), Unit 2 Lesson 1 (The Internal Critic), and Unit 2 Lesson 4 (Accountability Without Self-Punishment). Two additional lessons carry the ★★ Highest Risk safety designation: Unit 2 Lesson 6 (Rewriting the Script) and Unit 3 Lesson 6 (The Agency of Release / Letter of Release). Your school counselor is on-site for both. **Your rights.** You may inspect any curriculum material before it is taught — a physical copy of Book Three is available in the school office within 5 school days of any request. You may opt your child out of any specific lesson, any cluster of lessons, or the entire programme. Opt-out is non-punitive. The Opt-Out Request Form is in Section 4.8.G and at the school office. How you can support this work without doing it for them. The most useful thing you can do is take the curriculum vocabulary into your own life: when YOU are hard on yourself, name the Internal Critic out loud. When you give someone the benefit of the doubt, name it. When you set a limit from self-respect rather than punishment, narrate the difference. Adolescents learn most from what they overhear when they aren't the topic of conversation. You will receive a brief letter at the close of each unit so you know what your child has been working with and what is coming next. At the end of the year you will receive the Family Grace Audit packet — a private self-reflection tool for your family that no one but you ever sees. If you have questions, please contact: School Counselor: _____ Teacher: _____ Principal: _____ Sincerely, [Teacher Name] · [School Name] · [Date]

4.8.B

Unit Transition Letters

Four short letters home, distributed at the close of each unit. These letters tell families what their child has just worked with and what is coming next. Each letter uses the actual vocabulary of the unit so that when an adolescent says, "That sounds like my Internal Critic," the family already has the word.

LETTER 1 • END OF UNIT 1 • TRANSITION TO UNIT 2

Distribute at the close of Unit 1 Lesson 7.

Dear Families, Your child has just completed Unit 1 of Architecture of Grace, Book Three — Identity & the Weight of Perception. Across seven lessons they worked with several pieces of internal vocabulary that may now show up at home: • The Mask vs. the Mirror — the difference between the version of yourself you present to others and the version you actually are when no one is watching. • The Anatomy of a Mistake — guilt (about behaviour, useful) versus shame (about identity, corrosive). One leads to repair. The other leads to hiding. • The Digital Backpack — the cumulative, mostly permanent, often public record of what a person posts, shares, and reacts to. Students did a private patterns audit of their own. • The Volume of Integrity — the practice of listening for the difference between peer signal and personal signal in a moment of pressure. • Owning Your Narrative — the difference between a label someone has given you and the story you author yourself. • The Agency of Choice — the moment-by-moment power to decide who you are becoming, regardless of the circumstances you did not choose. In Unit 2 we move into the most internally focused unit of the year — Self-Compassion & the Internal Critic. Your child will encounter the Internal Critic and the Compassionate Witness, the Friend Test (would you talk to a friend the way you talk to yourself?), the Highlight Reel and the Comparison Trap, and Perfectionism as the Critic in disguise. Two Unit 2 lessons are PPRA-protected (L1 and L4) and one lesson (L6, Rewriting the Script) carries the ★★ Highest Risk safety designation; the school counselor co-facilitates that lesson on-site. **How to support this work at home:** if you hear your child being harsh with themselves, you can name it the way the curriculum does: “That sounded like the Internal Critic. What would the Compassionate Witness say?” If they roll their eyes, that’s fine. They heard you. With gratitude, [Teacher Name] • [School Name] • [Date]

LETTER 2 • END OF UNIT 2 • MID-YEAR • TRANSITION TO UNIT 3

Distribute at the close of Unit 2 Lesson 7, alongside Instrument G (Family Mid-Year Survey).

Dear Families, We have reached the mid-year point of Book Three. Your child has just completed Unit 2 — Self-Compassion & the Internal Critic. This is the most internally demanding unit of the year, and it asks adolescents to do something many adults still struggle with: notice the voice in their own head, hear it for what it is, and choose the Compassionate Witness instead. Across the unit they have practised the Friend Test, recognised the Comparison Trap and the Highlight Reel as it appears in their own digital lives, distinguished healthy striving from corrosive perfectionism, and worked with Accountability Without Self-Punishment. Lesson 6 (Rewriting the Script) is the ★★ highest-risk lesson of the year. The school counselor was on-site and co-facilitated the full lesson. If anything from that work surfaces at home in the days and weeks ahead, please contact the counselor or teacher directly. This is normal and expected, and is exactly what the protocol exists to support. In Unit 3 — Empathy & Forgiving Others — we shift outward. Your child will work with Impact vs. Intent, the Three Sides of Every Story, the distinction between Forgiveness and Reconciliation (one of the most important distinctions in the curriculum), the Digital Echo, the Letter of Release, and Limits from Self-Respect. Lessons 3 and 6 are risk-flagged; the counselor is on-site for L6. **Enclosed:** Instrument G (Family Mid-Year Survey). Your responses are anonymous and shape the next pilot year. Approximately 8 minutes. With gratitude, [Teacher Name] • [School Name] • [Date]

LETTER 3 · END OF UNIT 3 · TRANSITION TO UNIT 4

Distribute at the close of Unit 3 Lesson 7.

Dear Families, Your child has just completed Unit 3 — Empathy & Forgiving Others. This is the most relationally demanding unit of the year, and your child has worked with several distinctions that take most adults decades to fully internalise: · Impact vs. Intent — understanding that the impact of an action does not require the actor's intent to validate it. · Forgiveness vs. Reconciliation — forgiveness is internal, between you and you; reconciliation is relational, requires changed behaviour over time, and is never owed. · The Digital Echo — how online conflict reverberates in ways face-to-face conflict does not, and what to do about it. · The Letter of Release — a private writing practice for the weight of a hurt that is not going to receive a real-world repair. The letter is never sent. The release is internal. · Limits from Self-Respect — setting a limit because you respect yourself, not because you are punishing the other person. Lesson 6 (The Agency of Release) was the second ★★ highest-risk lesson of the year. The school counselor was in the room throughout. As with Unit 2 Lesson 6, if material surfaces at home, please reach out to the counselor or teacher directly. In Unit 4 — Grace & Generosity — we move outward into community. Your child will work with the secular meaning of grace, what mercy looks like in practice, the discipline of charitable interpretation, and the Grace Challenge — a five-day micro-action of their own choosing. Unit 4 closes with the Grace Audit Final Project (their year-end synthesis) and the Community Charter the class writes together at year-end. **What you may notice at home:** Unit 3 carries the heaviest emotional weight of the year. Some students arrive at Unit 4 lighter; some arrive heavier. Both are normal. The Unit 4 work is structurally lighter, more outward-facing, and more action-oriented — which is the rhythm by design. With gratitude, [Teacher Name] · [School Name] · [Date]

LETTER 4 · END OF UNIT 4 · YEAR-END

Distribute after Unit 4 Lesson 7 (Community Charter & Year-End Celebration), alongside the Family Grace Audit packet (Sections 4.8.D–F) and the year-end Family Engagement Survey (Instrument G).

Dear Families, Architecture of Grace, Book Three, is complete. Your child has spent a school year with a vocabulary most adults were never given at this age: the Mask and the Mirror, guilt and shame, the Digital Backpack, the Internal Critic and the Compassionate Witness, the Friend Test, the Comparison Trap, perfectionism as the Critic in disguise, Impact vs. Intent, the Three Sides of Every Story, Forgiveness vs. Reconciliation, the Letter of Release, Limits from Self-Respect, charitable interpretation, mercy as a strength, and — their final synthesis — the Community Charter the class wrote together in Lesson 7. They will not have mastered any of these. Nobody does in one year, and middle-school adolescence is not the season of life when the answers settle. What they have done is hear, see, and practise these distinctions dozens of times in a holding environment — a classroom where the Compassionate Witness standard applied to how people spoke to each other, and where the four non-negotiable agreements were upheld. The work continues in Book Four next year. **Enclosed with this letter:** three sections from the master document — the Family Grace Audit (Section 4.8.D), the Final Reflection (Section 4.8.E), and the Closing Words to Families (Section 4.8.F). Together they form a private, unscored self-reflection packet for your family. The school does not collect any of it. Also enclosed: the year-end Family Engagement Survey (Instrument G), which IS returned, anonymously, to the building administrator. Thank you for trusting us with the work of your child's heart this year. The work you do at home is the foundation. The classroom is a partner. With gratitude, [Teacher Name] · [School Name] · [Date]

4.8.C

Family Grace Guide

Optional take-home guide for families wanting to extend the Architecture of Grace practice into their home. Distribute at the start of Unit 4. Reproduce on school letterhead or print as a stapled booklet. This guide is not a worksheet; it is a reference.

WHAT THIS GUIDE IS · AND IS NOT

This guide is a reference for grown-ups in the home. It is not a worksheet, not an assignment, and not something the school collects. Your child does not need to know you are reading it. Many of the techniques in this guide land best when they are used WITHOUT being announced. Adolescents are particularly attuned to whether a conversation is being had at them or with them. The single most useful thing you can do is take the curriculum vocabulary into YOUR own life — not theirs. When you are hard on yourself, name the Internal Critic out loud where they can overhear. When you choose mercy when you didn't have to, name it. When you give someone the benefit of the doubt at the dinner table, narrate the choice.

SIX THINGS THAT HELP · AND SIX THAT HURT

WHAT HELPS

- Modelling out loud. Adolescents do not learn from instruction at this age; they learn from what they overhear. When you make a mistake, narrate the Compassionate Witness response audibly: "Okay — that didn't go the way I wanted. What can I learn? What is one next step?"
- Naming the Critic when you hear it. Not theirs — yours. "That was my Internal Critic. The Compassionate Witness would say something different." They will hear you. They may not respond. They will hear you.

UNIT 4 • LESSON 7 • THE INTERIOR (6–8)

- Asking the Friend Test, sideways. When your child is harsh with themselves, do not lecture. Ask, lightly: “Would you say that to your best friend?” Then drop it. Don’t pursue.
- Charitable interpretation, in the kitchen. The driver who cut you off, the cousin who forgot your birthday, the neighbour who never says hello — take the most generous reading available. Out loud. With no point being made. Your child is listening.
- Repair when you mess up. When you snap, when you misjudge, when you raise your voice — circle back. Acknowledge the impact, not just the intent. Adolescents who see adults repair learn that repair is possible. This is the most powerful single intervention available to you.
- Knowing when not to talk. Sometimes the most loving response to a 13-year-old is silence and proximity. A car ride, a kitchen counter, a long walk. The point is not to extract the conversation. The point is to be present when they are ready.

WHAT HURTS

- Lecturing. Especially right after the difficult moment. The lesson never lands. The lecture lands.
- Bringing up old mistakes as ammunition. Once a thing has been repaired, it is repaired. Reaching back for it is a betrayal of the repair.
- Treating their feelings as a problem to solve. Most of the time, the goal is not to fix the feeling. The goal is to be in the room while they have it.
- Public humiliation, even mild. Especially in front of siblings, friends, or relatives. The cost is far higher than the moment seems to warrant.
- Requiring forgiveness. The curriculum is explicit on this and so are we. Nobody has to forgive anyone. Especially not their sibling, in the hallway, on demand.
- Reading their journal, their texts, their DMs uninvited. There is occasional safety justification for this; there is no everyday justification for it. Trust, once broken on the privacy axis, is extremely hard to rebuild at this age.

CONVERSATION STARTERS • UNIT BY UNIT

Use these only when the conversation is wanted. If your child does not want to talk, the right move is not to talk. The vocabulary is doing its work whether you discuss it or not.

UNIT 1 • IDENTITY

- “What does your Mirror say that your Mask doesn’t?”
- “Who in your life lets you take off the Mask?”
- “What’s in your Digital Backpack that you’re proud of? What would you take out if you could?”

UNIT 2 • SELF-COMPASSION

- “What does your Internal Critic sound like when it’s loudest? When is it quietest?”
- “Whose Highlight Reel hits you the hardest? What does it actually leave out?”
- “Where in your life are you actually striving, and where are you just being a perfectionist?”

UNIT 3 · EMPATHY & FORGIVING OTHERS

- “Is there someone you’ve forgiven that you don’t want to be in close relationship with anymore? Tell me about that.”
- “What’s a Limit from Self-Respect you’ve set this year that you’re proud of?”
- “Is there a Letter of Release you would write — to no one in particular — if you ever did?”

UNIT 4 · GRACE & GENEROSITY

- “What did you choose for your Grace Challenge? Why that?”
- “Where in our community is there a Grace Gap nobody is filling?”
- “What would the Compassionate Witness say to the version of you who finished sixth grade? Seventh? Eighth?”

ONE LAST THING

You will not parent this stage perfectly. Neither will we teach it perfectly. The curriculum is not designed to remove the difficulty of being twelve, thirteen, fourteen years old. It is designed to give your child a working vocabulary for the difficulty. You giving them the same vocabulary at home — not by quizzing them, but by living in it yourself — is the entire point.

4.8.D

The Family Grace Audit

A private family self-reflection tool — Grades 6–8 Edition. Not a test, not a judgment, not something anyone else will see. Complete it once at the start of the school year, once at the end. The comparison is the insight.

TEACHER NOTE · HOW TO DISTRIBUTE THIS AUDIT

Print Sections 4.8.D through 4.8.F as a single packet (the Audit, the Final Reflection, and the Closing Words to Families). Send the packet home twice in the school year: · Year-Start: with the Pre-Year Family Letter (Section 4.8.A), at least 10 school days before Unit 1 Lesson 1. Families complete Parts 1, 2, and 3. · Year-End: with the End-of-Year Letter (Section 4.8.B, Letter 4), after Unit 4 Lesson 7. Families complete Part 4 and the Final Reflection. Do not collect. The audit is private. Never ask a family if they completed it. Never ask what they wrote. If a family asks for a fresh copy, give one without comment. Translate where feasible. Coordinate with the building’s ELL liaison. This audit lands far harder in the home language than in a translated approximation.

UNIT 4 · LESSON 7 · THE INTERIOR (6–8)

HOW TO USE THIS AUDIT

This audit is for the grown-ups in the home. Your child does not need to fill it out with you, see it, know it exists, or be asked about it. It is a quiet, honest look at the grace practices already living in your house — and an honest look at where there is room to grow. The vocabulary below comes directly from your child's classroom: the Mask vs. the Mirror, the Internal Critic and the Compassionate Witness, the Digital Backpack, Highlight Reels, the Friend Test, Impact vs. Intent, Forgiveness vs. Reconciliation, the Letter of Release, Limits from Self-Respect, the Grace Gap. Use these terms at home. Adolescents are deeply attuned to which adults around them speak the language they are learning. Take twenty minutes. Be honest. No one but your family will ever read this.

RECORD

(OPTIONAL)

START OF YEAR

END OF YEAR

6 · 7 · 8

PART 1 · THE GRACE CLIMATE IN OUR HOME

Rate your household honestly on each item below. Check the number that fits best. 1 = not yet / rarely · 5 = consistently / naturally.

THE COMPASSIONATE WITNESS & THE INTERNAL CRITIC

Adults in our home name the Internal Critic out loud when it shows up in their own self-talk.

1	2	3	4	5
☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

When our adolescent is harsh with themselves, we know how to ask the Friend Test sideways — and how to drop it after.

1	2	3	4	5
☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

We do not respond to a perfectionist child by demanding more, or to a struggling child by demanding less. We can tell the difference between healthy striving and the Internal Critic in disguise.

1	2	3	4	5
☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

ACCOUNTABILITY WITHOUT SELF-PUNISHMENT

When someone in our family makes a real mistake, we move them toward repair, not toward shame. We can tell the difference between guilt (about behaviour) and shame (about identity) — in practice, not just in theory.

1	2	3	4	5
☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

UNIT 4 · LESSON 7 · THE INTERIOR (6–8)

Adults in our home model their own accountability out loud. When we mess up, our adolescent hears us repair — not just regret.	1	2	3	4	5
	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

We do not bring up resolved mistakes as ammunition in new arguments. When a thing is repaired, it is repaired.	1	2	3	4	5
	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

DIGITAL LIFE & THE DIGITAL BACKPACK

We talk about digital life as a real part of life — not as a less-real annex of it. Our adolescent's online relationships and reputation are taken seriously here.	1	2	3	4	5
	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

We are honest about our own Digital Backpacks — our own social media patterns, our own comparison habits, our own Highlight Reel performances.	1	2	3	4	5
	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

We do not surveil our adolescent's private digital life as a default practice. When safety reasons require it, we say so honestly.	1	2	3	4	5
	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

EMPATHY, IMPACT, AND THREE SIDES OF EVERY STORY

When a family member shares a hurt, we listen for the impact, not just the intent of the person who caused it. Impact does not require intent to validate it.	1	2	3	4	5
	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

We try to hold the Three Sides of Every Story — their side, the other person's side, and the version that lives in between — before deciding who is right.	1	2	3	4	5
	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

We make space for feelings before jumping to solutions. We can sit in the difficulty of an unresolved emotional moment without rushing it to closure.	1	2	3	4	5
	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

FORGIVENESS, RECONCILIATION, AND LIMITS

We understand that forgiveness and reconciliation are not the same. We do not require either of one another.	1	2	3	4	5
	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

We can set Limits from Self-Respect without framing them as punishment. Our adolescent has seen a grown-up do this in real life, on someone other than themselves.	1	2	3	4	5
	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

We do not require our adolescent to forgive someone who is currently still hurting them — including ourselves.	1	2	3	4	5
	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

GRACE, MERCY, AND CHARITABLE INTERPRETATION

We extend grace to people outside our family — in traffic, at the store, with difficult relatives. Our adolescent sees this regularly.

1	2	3	4	5
☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

We practise charitable interpretation out loud in everyday situations, even when no point is being made for the children's benefit.

1	2	3	4	5
☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

We understand mercy as a strength, not a weakness — the choice not to use a power we have.

1	2	3	4	5
☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

PART 2 • REFLECTION QUESTIONS

These questions are not scored. Write freely — or talk through them as adults in the home, without your adolescent present. There are no right answers.

WHERE DOES GRACE ALREADY SHOW UP MOST NATURALLY IN OUR HOME? WHAT DOES IT LOOK LIKE, IN A REAL MOMENT FROM THIS PAST MONTH?

WHERE DOES GRACE BREAK DOWN IN OUR FAMILY? WHAT SEEMS TO SET IT OFF — TIME OF DAY, CERTAIN TOPICS, CERTAIN PEOPLE, OUR OWN DEPLETION?

WHERE IN OUR OWN LIVES ARE WE WEARING A MASK WE DON'T WANT OUR CHILD TO INHERIT? YOU DON'T HAVE TO SHARE THIS ANSWER WITH ANYONE — JUST WRITE IT HONESTLY.

WHAT DOES THE INTERNAL CRITIC SOUND LIKE IN YOUR HEAD? WHAT DOES OUR ADOLESCENT HEAR FROM US, IN MOMENTS WHEN WE ARE HARD ON OURSELVES?

WHAT IS ONE THING YOU WANT YOUR ADOLESCENT TO HAVE ABSORBED ABOUT GRACE, FORGIVENESS, OR SELF-COMPASSION BEFORE THEY LEAVE YOUR HOUSE?

IS THERE SOMEONE IN YOUR FAMILY'S STORY — PAST OR PRESENT — WHO IS HARD TO EXTEND GRACE TO? YOU DON'T HAVE TO NAME THEM. JUST NOTICE WHETHER THEY'RE THERE.

PART 3 • FAMILY COMMITMENTS

Choose one or two things your family wants to practise this year. Write them in your own words. These are not assignments — they are intentions.

WE COMMIT TO—

WE COMMIT TO—

UNIT 4 · LESSON 7 · THE INTERIOR (6–8)

FOR EXAMPLE: “THAT SOUNDED LIKE THE INTERNAL CRITIC. WHAT WOULD THE COMPASSIONATE WITNESS SAY?” OR “WHAT’S THE MOST GENEROUS READING OF WHAT JUST HAPPENED?” OR “YOUR FEELINGS MAKE SENSE.”

FOR EXAMPLE: BRINGING UP RESOLVED MISTAKES, LECTURING RIGHT AFTER A DIFFICULT MOMENT, REQUIRING FORGIVENESS, OR COMPARING OUR ADOLESCENT TO A SIBLING, A COUSIN, OR THE VERSION OF THEM WE WISH THEY WERE.

PART 4 · END-OF-YEAR REVIEW

Complete this section at the end of the school year, after Unit 4 Lesson 7. Compare your answers to Parts 1 and 2. The gap between them is your family’s growth story.

WHAT SHIFTED IN OUR HOME THIS YEAR — EVEN SLIGHTLY — AROUND GRACE, FORGIVENESS, OR SELF-COMPASSION?

WAS THERE A MOMENT THIS YEAR WHEN SOMEONE IN OUR FAMILY CHOSE GRACE WHEN THEY DIDN’T HAVE TO? TELL THE STORY IN THREE SENTENCES.

RETURN TO PART 1 AND RE-RATE EACH ITEM WITHOUT LOOKING AT YOUR ORIGINAL ANSWERS FIRST. THEN COMPARE. WHERE DID WE GROW? WHERE ARE WE STILL WORKING?

ONE THING OUR FAMILY WILL KEEP PRACTISING INTO BOOK FOUR NEXT YEAR, INTO HIGH SCHOOL, INTO THE REST OF THEIR ADOLESCENCE.

PRIVATE · KEEP IT IN THE HOUSE

This audit belongs to your family. The school does not collect it. The teacher does not ask about it. No one ever sees it but you. Keep it somewhere you can find it again — a kitchen drawer, the inside cover of a book — and return to it. School of Life Foundation · Architecture of Grace · Grades 6–8.

4.8.E

The Family Grace Audit — Final Reflection

As Book Three closes — after the Year-End Celebration in Unit 4 Lesson 7 — sit down as a family and answer these three questions. You do not need a therapist. You do not need a curriculum. You need an honest conversation and thirty minutes.

WHAT WEIGHT DID WE HELP EACH OTHER PUT DOWN THIS YEAR? YOUR CHILD WROTE A LETTER OF RELEASE IN UNIT 3 — THE PRACTICE OF RELEASING THE INNER WEIGHT OF A HURT THAT IS NOT GOING TO RECEIVE A REAL-WORLD REPAIR. AS A FAMILY, WHAT DID WE RELEASE THIS YEAR? WHAT DID WE CHOOSE, FINALLY, TO STOP CARRYING?

WHEN WAS A TIME WE CHOSE GRACE WHEN WE DIDN’T HAVE TO? IN OUR FAMILY, IN OUR COMMUNITY, IN THE WORLD. EVEN A SMALL MOMENT COUNTS. ESPECIALLY A SMALL ONE.

WHAT CYCLE — OF SHAME, OF UNFORGIVENESS, OF PERFECTIONISM, OF COMPARISON, OF CONTEMPT — ARE WE CHOOSING TO END WITH THIS GENERATION? NAME IT. THEN DECIDE TOGETHER: IS THIS WHERE IT STOPS?

4.8.F

Closing Words to Families

Reproduce on letterhead and send home with the year-end packet, or read aloud at the Year-End Celebration in Unit 4 Lesson 7.

THE INTERIOR IS BUILT — AND IT WILL BE THEIR HOME LONG AFTER WE ARE GONE.

Every lesson, every conversation, every moment of grace your child has practised this year has added a stone to the structure being built inside them. They leave Book Three with something most adults at this age were never given: a working internal vocabulary for the most demanding season of their life so far. They can now distinguish guilt from shame, the Internal Critic from the Compassionate Witness, forgiveness from reconciliation, a Mask from a Mirror, an impact from an intent, a Limit from Self-Respect from a punishment, and grace from anything that has to be earned.

They will not do any of this perfectly. Neither will you. Neither will any of us. But they have been given the language and the practice — early, while it can still take root — for naming what is happening inside them, for choosing the Compassionate Witness over the Internal Critic, for repairing what they break, for forgiving what they choose to forgive, and for refusing to forgive what is still hurting them.

That foundation matters. The work you do at home — not by lecturing them, but by speaking the same vocabulary in your own life — is where it gets built into them for keeps. Your child is becoming the person they are going to be. The Architecture of Grace is the language they will use to do it.

You are the primary architect of your child's heart. The classroom is a partner. You are the foundation. The Interior is being built — and it will be their home long after we are gone.

Thank you for trusting us with the work of your child's heart this year. Book Four awaits in Grades 9–12. Go build something worth living in. School of Life Foundation · Architecture of Grace · Book Three: The Interior · Grades 6–8

4.8.G

Administrative Forms · Master Set

PPRA Parental Notification · Student Opt-Out Request · District Implementation Checklist · Grades 6–8 Edition. Reproduce freely on school letterhead. All three documents must be on file before instruction begins in any federally funded school.

APPENDIX A — PPRA PARENTAL NOTIFICATION LETTER

Reproduce on school letterhead. Mail or email to all families at least 10 calendar days before Unit 1 Lesson 1. (See also the Pre-Year Family Letter in Section 4.8.A; this version is the formal year-start compliance letter, distributed alongside the warmer family letter.)

Date: _____

To: Parent / Guardian of: _____

From: _____

RE: NOTICE OF SUPPLEMENTAL CURRICULUM — ARCHITECTURE OF GRACE, BOOK THREE, GRADES 6–8

Dear Parent or Guardian,

Our school will soon begin the Architecture of Grace social-emotional learning curriculum for Grades 6–8. To comply with the Protection of Pupil Rights Amendment (PPRA, 20 U.S.C. § 1232h), we are notifying you in advance that this curriculum includes activities that invite middle-school students to explore personal beliefs and emotional responses through journal writing, structured discussion, and small voluntary actions.

PPRA-DESIGNATED LESSONS IN BOOK THREE · GRADES 6–8

The following lessons are specifically designated as PPRA-triggering because they invite age-appropriate self-reflection on internal emotional content. Risk markers (★ / ★★) indicate counselor-coverage requirements:

- The Anatomy of a Mistake (Unit 1, Lesson 2 · PPRA) — students examine the difference between guilt (about behaviour) and shame (about identity).
- Owning Your Narrative (Unit 1, Lesson 5 · PPRA) — students reflect on labels they have been given and the story they want to author themselves.
- The Internal Critic (Unit 2, Lesson 1 · PPRA) — students notice and examine the patterns in their own self-talk.
- Accountability Without Self-Punishment (Unit 2, Lesson 4 · PPRA) — students work with the difference between repair and self-attack.
- Rewriting the Script (Unit 2, Lesson 6 · ★★ Highest Risk) — structured discussion of long-running self-narratives. School counselor co-facilitates on-site.
- Forgiveness vs. Reconciliation (Unit 3, Lesson 3 · ★ High Risk) — structured discussion of distinguishing forgiveness from continued relationship with someone who has caused harm.
- The Agency of Release / Letter of Release (Unit 3, Lesson 6 · ★★ Highest Risk) — a private writing practice for releasing the weight of a hurt. School counselor in the room throughout. The letter is never sent.
- Grace Audit Final Project (Unit 4, Lesson 6 · ★ Elevated) — student year-end synthesis project.
- Community Charter & Year-End Celebration (Unit 4, Lesson 7 · ★ Elevated) — class collective commitment to grace practices.

YOUR RIGHTS UNDER PPRA

- You have the right to inspect curriculum materials before they are taught. A physical copy of Book Three is available in the school office within 5 school days of any request.
- You have the right to opt your child out of specific activities, specific lessons, or the full programme. No academic penalty will result.
- For each lesson designated as PPRA-protected (those marked above), you will receive a separate lesson-specific notification at least 10 calendar days in advance.
- To exercise opt-out rights, complete the Opt-Out Request Form (Appendix B) and return it to the school office.

If you have questions, please contact:

School Counselor: _____

Principal / Administrator: _____

Phone / Email: _____

PPRA NOTICE · GRADES 6–8 EDITION

This notice is required under federal law for all schools receiving federal funding. Retain a copy of this letter and all returned Opt-Out Forms in the school's administrative records.

APPENDIX B — STUDENT OPT-OUT REQUEST FORM

Complete and return to the school office. Do not submit to the classroom teacher. A copy will be filed in the school's administrative records — not in the student's academic file. Grades 6–8 Edition.

Student Name: _____

Grade · Teacher: _____

Date of Request: _____

OPT-OUT TYPE · SELECT ONE

☐ **TIER 1 — Curricular Inquiry Only.** I would like to review curriculum materials before making an opt-out decision. Please contact me to arrange access.

☐ **TIER 2 — Selective Activity Opt-Out.** I am opting my child out of the following specific activities or PPRA-flagged lessons. My child will remain in the classroom and receive an alternative activity during opted-out segments.

Activities or lessons opted out of: _____

(continued): _____

☐ **TIER 3 — Full Programme Opt-Out.** I am opting my child out of the entire Architecture of Grace SEL programme for this school year. I understand my child will be relocated to a supervised alternative setting during the SEL block and will receive independent reading or school-approved character-development materials. No academic penalty will result.

ALTERNATIVE PLACEMENT • TIER 2 OR 3 ONLY

- ☐ Library
- ☐ Counselor's office
- ☐ Designated alternative classroom

Parent / Guardian Printed Name: _____

Parent / Guardian Signature • Date: _____

Phone / Email for Follow-Up: _____

FOR OFFICE USE ONLY

Received by • Date Received: _____

Alternative placement arranged: _____

Copy filed in administrative records • Initials: _____

APPENDIX C — DISTRICT IMPLEMENTATION CHECKLIST

To be completed and signed by the designated district administrator before instruction begins. Retain in the district's curriculum adoption file. This checklist constitutes documented evidence of compliance review for the Grades 6–8 edition.

District Name: _____

School Name: _____

Grade Level • Academic Year: _____

Designated Administrator: _____

PRE-IMPLEMENTATION COMPLIANCE ITEMS

- ☐ **PPRA Notice.** Year-start parental notification letter (Appendix A) and the Pre-Year Family Letter (Section 4.8.A) mailed or emailed to all families at least 10 calendar days prior to Unit 1 Lesson 1.
- ☐ **Lesson-Specific PPRA Notices.** Lesson-specific PPRA notification template prepared and scheduled for each PPRA, ★, and ★★ lesson, to be sent 10 calendar days before each.
- ☐ **Curriculum Inspection.** Physical copy of Book Three available in the school office, with a 5-school-day turnaround commitment for any family review request.
- ☐ **Clinical Review.** School Psychologist or Counselor has reviewed Units 2 and 3 in full and confirmed clinical readiness in writing — with particular attention to U2 L6 (Rewriting the Script) and U3 L6 (The Agency of Release / Letter of Release), both ★★ Highest Risk.
- ☐ **Counselor Calendar.** Full Counselor Integration Calendar (Section 4.6) reviewed and counselor on-site coverage confirmed for both ★★ Highest Risk lessons. No exceptions, no substitutes.
- ☐ **Staff Training.** All delivering teachers have completed the Disclosure Protocol training (Section 4.5) and the Type 4 Mandatory Reporting module in the Teacher PD Guide (Section 5.4).
- ☐ **Re-Entry Protocol.** School Counselor and classroom teachers have reviewed and acknowledged the Post-Disclosure Re-Entry Protocol.

UNIT 4 · LESSON 7 · THE INTERIOR (6–8)

- ☐ **Journal Privacy.** The journal-as-private-instructional-material rule (Section 4.5) has been communicated in classroom procedures and acknowledged by teachers in writing.
- ☐ **Letter of Release Protocol.** Teachers delivering U3 L6 have reviewed the Letter of Release protocol: the letter is never sent, never collected, never read by any other party. Students who choose to keep their letter retain it; students who choose to destroy it do so privately.
- ☐ **Opt-Out Process.** Opt-Out Request Form (Appendix B) is available in the school office and designated staff are trained to receive and process requests within the federally required windows.
- ☐ **Legal Review.** District legal counsel or designated administrator has reviewed Section 4.5 (Legal & Clinical Compliance) and confirmed adoption readiness.
- ☐ **Secular Documentation.** The secular nature of the curriculum was explicitly considered and documented at the time of board adoption. The independent school attorney confirmation referenced in Section 4.3 is on file.

ADMINISTRATOR CERTIFICATION

I certify that the above compliance items have been completed prior to the delivery of the Architecture of Grace, Book Three, Grades 6–8 curriculum in our school / district.

Administrator Signature: _____

Printed Name and Title: _____

Date: _____

DISTRICT FILE · GRADES 6–8 COMPLIANCE EDITION

School of Life Foundation · Architecture of Grace · Book Three: The Interior · Grades 6–8 · Legal & Clinical Compliance Edition. This document is provided for administrative use. Consult your district's legal counsel with jurisdiction-specific compliance questions.

4.9 Troubleshooting Guide

HIGH-RISK LESSON SCHEDULING RULES

U2L6 — Rewriting the Script	No substitute. No pre-break delivery. No fire-drill day. Crisis resources posted before students arrive. Counselor in room before first student enters.
U3L3 — Forgiveness vs. Reconciliation	No substitute. Do not schedule within 24 hours of a school-wide safety incident. Counselor on-site or within 60 seconds.
U3L6 — Letter of Release	No substitute. No pre-break delivery. The Letter cannot be split across two sessions — if you cannot finish, do not start. Counselor physically in the room.

COMMON DELIVERY CHALLENGES

A student is crying during a lesson	Hold the room gently. Do not stop the lesson for the whole class. Move quietly to the student. Say: “I see you — I’ll check in after class.” Do not ask what is wrong in the moment. Note for counselor.
A student refuses to participate	Never force participation. Offer: “You can observe and write your exit ticket — that counts.” Some non-participation is protective avoidance. Note privately. Do not escalate publicly.
A student shares something that concerns you	Receive it with care, do not probe, do not promise confidentiality you cannot keep. Follow the Disclosure Protocol (§4.5). Type 3 or 4: contact counselor same day.
A substitute teacher is covering a lesson	Substitutes may NOT deliver ★ or ★★ risk-flagged lessons. If you are absent on a scheduled risk-flagged lesson day, either reschedule or arrange for a co-delivering qualified teacher.
The lesson runs short	Each lesson has a designated primary activity — protect it above all else. Exit ticket is the second priority. If time is genuinely very short: skip the teaching tip and optional extensions.
The lesson runs long	Cut from the scenario card debrief or the optional extension, not from the direct instruction or primary activity. Never cut the exit ticket.
A student challenges the secular framing of grace/forgiveness	Acknowledge the religious significance directly: “In many traditions, these words carry deep spiritual meaning — and that’s real and important. In this class, we’re using them in their psychological sense, which is separate from any religious framework.” Do not debate. Redirect to the content.

TEACHER WELLBEING

THIS CURRICULUM ASKS SOMETHING OF TEACHERS — NOT JUST STUDENTS

Delivering Architecture of Grace — particularly Units 2 and 3 — requires teachers to hold significant emotional content without becoming overwhelmed. This is skilled professional labour. **After U2L6 and U3L6:** debrief with your counselor. Not only for student disclosures — for your own state. These lessons cost something. **That is them working.** If you notice you are carrying students’ material into your personal life — difficulty sleeping, intrusive thoughts, heightened emotional reactivity — that is secondary trauma. Speak to your counselor or a mental health professional. **Teacher wellbeing is curriculum fidelity.** A dysregulated teacher cannot hold a regulated room.

4.10 Curriculum Vocabulary Glossary

The following vocabulary terms are core to Architecture of Grace across all four units. They are taught explicitly, posted on anchor charts, and returned to across the year. Students who complete the programme should be able to define all of these terms in their own words.

UNIT 1 — IDENTITY

Mask / Mirror	The gap between the performed social self (Mask) and the authentic self (Mirror).
Identity Audit	A structured self-reflection tool mapping performed vs. authentic behaviour.
Shame	A global, identity-level response to mistakes: "I am bad." Almost never produces growth.
Guilt	A specific, behaviour-level response: "I made a bad choice." Functional — points toward repair.
Integrity	Alignment between stated values and actual choices.
Narrative / Author	The story told about who you are. To claim authorship is to decide who tells it.
Agency	The power to choose one's own response, even when external circumstances are uncontrollable.

UNIT 2 — SELF-COMPASSION

Internal Critic	The self-critical internal voice. Uses three tactics: catastrophising, globalising, personalising. Not the truth about who you are.
Compassionate Witness	An alternative internal voice that is honest and fair, without punishment. What you would say to a close friend.
Catastrophising	The critic's tactic of turning a bad moment into a permanent condition.
Perfectionism	The critic in disguise. Not high standards — fear of failure masquerading as ambition.
Highlight Reel	The curated, edited presentation of someone's life. Not their full reality.
Friend Test	Would you say that to a friend in the same situation? The primary self-compassion calibration question.

UNIT 3 — FORGIVING OTHERS

Impact vs. Intent	Impact is what is addressed in repair. Intent matters for understanding but does not reduce accountability.
Forgiveness	The psychological process of releasing resentment — an internal act, for the benefit of the forgiver, not the person who caused harm.
Reconciliation	The restoration of a relationship. Not required by forgiveness. Not always appropriate or safe.
Release	Choosing to stop letting resentment use your energy. An act of self-care, not absolution of the other person.
Letter of Release	A voluntary private writing practice. Never collected. Never required.
Limit	A boundary set from self-respect, not retaliation. A statement about what you will and will not accept — focused on what YOU will do.

UNIT 4 — GRACE

Grace	The deliberate choice to extend something generous — patience, inclusion, the benefit of the doubt — to someone who has not necessarily earned it. Chosen strength.
Mercy	The choice to restrain power — withholding a negative response that would be justified.
Charitable Interpretation	Assuming the most generous available explanation before the most negative one.
Grace Gap	A place or pattern in the environment where the absence of grace creates a noticeably harder experience for someone.
Community Charter	A collective written commitment created by the class about how they choose to treat each other. Co-created and signed.
Micro-Moment	A specific, observable, executable grace act — completable in 30 seconds or less. Costs something. Builds character.

REGULATION & REPAIR STRAND — VOCABULARY

Activation	The physiological response to a perceived threat. In this context: the body's response to mistakes, shame, conflict, or perceived rejection. Not a weakness — biology.
3-Breath Reset	A portable real-time regulation tool. Inhale for 4 counts, hold for 4, exhale for 6. Repeat 3 times. Activates the parasympathetic nervous system. Introduced U1L2.
Repair	The process of addressing the impact of one's own harmful action. Distinct from apology and from reconciliation. Requires: naming the action, naming the impact, acknowledging the feeling, stating concrete change, and offering (optionally) to help.
Recovery Arc	The three-phase process of returning to baseline after activation: (1) Stabilize, (2) Process, (3) Re-engage. Recovery is not automatic — it is a chosen sequence. Introduced U2L5.
Flooding	Emotional overwhelm in which the nervous system is so activated that rational processing is temporarily unavailable. Not a character failure. The appropriate response is stabilization — not communication or decision-making.
Regulation	The process of returning the nervous system to a functional state. Regulation is a skill — practiced, not passive. Includes the 3-breath reset, grounding techniques, body awareness, and the Recovery Arc.
Pressure Script	Pre-rehearsed language for use in high-pressure moments when the nervous system is activated. Having the words in advance means not having to generate them while flooded. Introduced U1L4.
Regulate Before Communicating	The principle that limit-setting and repair communication are most effective — and least harmful — when initiated from a regulated state. Stabilize first. Then speak.

Architecture of Grace — The Interior

School of Life Foundation · Pilot Version

James Anthony Ramsden, Founder

SECTION FIVE

Professional Development

Half-Day Pre-Year Module · Mid-Year 90-Minute Session · Grades 6–8

Facilitator Guide for Building Principals, Instructional Coaches, and School Counselors

5.1 Professional Development Overview

Architecture of Grace · The Interior requires two professional development sessions during the implementation year: a half-day pre-year module before Lesson 1, and a 90-minute mid-year session after Unit 2 closes. Both are structural to the curriculum — not optional add-ons. Teachers carrying 6–8 material need a room that holds them the way they are asked to hold their students.

Each session is designed to be delivered by a building principal, instructional coach, or school counselor — not only by the curriculum author. A prepared non-expert can run these days. Everything required is in this section. Read it fully before the session. Deliver it with presence.

TWO-SESSION STRUCTURE

5.2 Half-Day Pre-Year	Establish theoretical foundation, trauma-informed posture, in-the-moment disclosure protocol, live lesson experience, Teacher Reflection habit, shared vocabulary	Before Unit 1 Lesson 1 (August)
5.3 Mid-Year 90 Min	Implementation debrief, disclosure protocol recalibration, teacher wellbeing, preparation for Unit 3's harder content	Within 2 weeks of Unit 2 close (December) · Must precede U3 L3

A NOTE ON TONE

Neither session is a compliance check. They are the threshold between teachers reading the curriculum and teachers being able to deliver it with the presence the work requires. Set that tone from the opening.

5.2 Half-Day Pre-Year Module

3 hours 30 minutes (plus optional 30-minute extended Q&A) · Six blocks · Delivered before Lesson 1 of Unit 1

AUDIENCE	Classroom teachers (Grades 6–8) who will deliver Architecture of Grace · The Interior. School counselors and instructional coaches may attend. Administrators are welcome but should participate as learners, not evaluators.
FACILITATOR	Building principal, instructional coach, or counselor. No prior SEL expertise required; preparation and presence are the requirements.
PREPARATION	Read this full PD module at least 48 hours in advance. Read the Teacher Implementation Guide in full. Complete Block 5 (Teacher Reflection) personally before the day — you will model a real response, not a hypothetical one.
MATERIALS	Participant one-pager (5.5 at the end of this section, one per teacher) · Chart paper and markers · Printed or projected slide outline (5.4) · Journal or index cards for Block 5 · Timer visible to facilitator

BLOCK SEQUENCE

1	The Theoretical Framework — Why This Curriculum Exists	45 min
2	Trauma-Informed Delivery — Holding the Room	45 min
3	Disclosure & Distress Protocol Practice	30 min
4	Live Lesson Model — U2 L1 — The Internal Critic	45 min
5	Teacher Reflection as Personal Practice	30 min
6	Glossary Orientation & Q&A	15 min

5.2 · BLOCK 1 (45 MINUTES)**BLOCK 1**

The Theoretical Framework

UNIT 4 · LESSON 7 · THE INTERIOR (6-8)

Facilitator purpose: Teachers must understand the "why" before they can deliver the "what." This block builds the research foundation and establishes that the curriculum is serious work with a serious evidence base — not a feel-good add-on.

SHAME VS. GUILT RESEARCH (15 MIN)

Open with this: "Before we talk about the curriculum, I want to start with a question. Think of the last time you made a mistake at work — something you genuinely regret. Don't share it. Just hold it. Now notice: what are you feeling right now? Is it about what you did, or about who you are?" Allow 60 seconds of silence. Then: "That distinction is the heart of this curriculum."

Present the research base. Brené Brown's decade of grounded theory research established that shame — the belief that "I am bad" — is correlated with depression, anxiety, addiction, aggression, and eating disorders, and is negatively correlated with empathy, courage, and connection. Guilt — the belief that "I did something bad" — is correlated with positive outcomes including repair behavior, accountability, and prosocial action (Brown, 2010; Tangney, Stuewig & Mashek, 2007). This is not intuitive. Many adults operate with the assumption that shame is a useful motivator. The research says the opposite: shame produces hiding, not repair.

Classroom implication. When a teacher says "you should be ashamed of yourself," they are activating a neurological threat response that shuts down the learning brain and produces aggression or withdrawal — not reflection. When a teacher activates the repair pathway instead — using the curriculum's grade-band-appropriate framing — students learn to do the same for themselves. This curriculum teaches children to hold their own mistakes that way. Ask teachers: "What language did the adults in your life use when you made mistakes? How did it land?" Allow 2 minutes of pair-share.

SELF-COMPASSION SCIENCE (15 MIN)

Kristin Neff's foundational work defines self-compassion as composed of three elements: self-kindness (treating oneself with the care one would offer a good friend), common humanity (recognizing that imperfection and suffering are universal human experiences, not personal failures), and mindfulness (holding painful thoughts and feelings in balanced awareness rather than suppressing or over-identifying with them). Self-compassion is not self-esteem. Self-esteem is contingent on performance and comparison; self-compassion is unconditional. Research shows self-compassion is associated with greater emotional resilience, less anxiety and depression, more motivation after failure, and healthier coping behaviors (Neff, 2011).

FACILITATOR NOTE

Many teachers will have a visceral resistance to self-compassion as a concept. They may have been raised to believe that self-criticism is the engine of improvement. Name this directly: "If your instinct is that self-compassion sounds soft or indulgent — that is a normal and common reaction, and the research will surprise you. Self-compassion is associated with higher standards and more persistence after failure, not lower ones. The internal critic does not make us better. It makes us more afraid."

FORGIVENESS EDUCATION RESEARCH BASE (15 MIN)

Robert Enright and Richard Fitzgibbons established the empirical basis for forgiveness as a teachable, developmental skill. Their research across 35 years and multiple populations demonstrates that forgiveness interventions produce measurable reductions in anxiety, depression, and anger, and improvements in hope and self-esteem. Critically, their model defines forgiveness as a gift the forgiver gives themselves — not a transaction, not reconciliation, and not condoning harmful behavior. This distinction is foundational to the curriculum’s treatment of forgiveness in Units 2, 3, and 4.

Everett Worthington’s REACH model of forgiveness offers a complementary process-oriented framework. Where Enright and Fitzgibbons define the destination of forgiveness, Worthington’s REACH model describes the path. The five steps — Recall the hurt without rumination, Empathize with the one who caused it, offer Altruistic gift of forgiveness, Commit to the forgiveness, and Hold onto it against doubt — provide a process map. The model’s emphasis on empathy as a bridge to forgiveness (not a requirement for it) is directly consistent with the curriculum’s Unit 3 architecture.

REFERENCES FOR FURTHER READING

Brown, B. (2010). *The Gifts of Imperfection*. Hazelden. Tangney, J. P., Stuewig, J., & Mashek, D. J. (2007). Moral emotions and moral behavior. *Annual Review of Psychology*, 58, 345–372. Neff, K. (2011). Self-Compassion: The Proven Power of Being Kind to Yourself. William Morrow. Enright, R., & Fitzgibbons, R. (2015). *Forgiveness Therapy*. American Psychological Association. Worthington, E. L. (2006). *Forgiveness and Reconciliation: Theory and Application*. Routledge.

WHY THIS RESEARCH MATTERS AT GRADES 6–8

Early adolescence is when the Internal Critic becomes a stable internal voice for the first time. The research is clear: this is the developmental window when self-criticism crystallizes into a chronic pattern that can persist for decades. Teaching students to recognize the Critic as a voice (not as truth) at age 11–13 is not preventive in a vague sense — it is a documented protective factor for adolescent and adult mental health.

FACILITATOR CLOSING FOR BLOCK 1

“We are not teaching children to be nice. We are teaching them a set of internal skills that the research says are foundational to mental health, academic engagement, and the capacity to build and repair relationships across a lifetime. That is what you are being asked to deliver. Let’s talk about how.”

5.2 • BLOCK 2 (45 MINUTES)**BLOCK 2****Trauma-Informed Delivery**

Facilitator purpose: This block addresses the emotional reality of teaching this curriculum. Teachers will face activated students, and they will encounter their own material. Prepare them for both.

WHEN CONTENT ACTIVATES STUDENTS (20 MIN)

This curriculum works with real emotional material. Students will sometimes respond to lessons with unexpected emotion — tears, silence, a sudden need to leave the room, or a disclosure that goes further than the classroom context can safely hold. This is not a failure of the curriculum or the teacher. It is evidence that the curriculum is reaching something real.

Distinguishing productive discomfort from acute distress. Productive discomfort is the feeling of sitting with a hard truth or a new idea. A student who is quiet and thoughtful after a difficult lesson is likely in productive discomfort. This is the learning state. Do not rescue students from it by rushing on. A student who is crying, hyperventilating, dissociating (staring blankly, unresponsive), or who makes a disclosure suggesting active trauma or safety concern is in acute distress. This requires immediate, calm response — not curriculum delivery. Pause. Move toward the student quietly. Use the 6-step disclosure protocol (see Block 3).

Adolescent distress often comes through deflection (humor, performance, withdrawal) before it arrives directly. Notes about other students are common at this age and almost always require counselor follow-up — peer-to-peer mandated reporting is a real responsibility for middle school teachers.

FACILITATOR EXERCISE · THREE 6–8 SCENARIOS

Present the three student scenarios below. Ask teachers to identify each as productive discomfort or acute distress, and to name their immediate response. The scenarios are calibrated to 6–8 developmental reality.

Scenario 1. During the Internal Critic lesson, a student writes intensely in their journal for the entire activity, then closes the notebook hard and stares out the window. They are not crying, just very still. When you walk near, they shift to look at the wall. **Scenario 2.** During the Three Sides of Every Story discussion (U3 L2), a student deflects every personal-connection invitation with a joke. Other students start laughing along. The energy in the room shifts from work to performance. **Scenario 3.** A student passes you a folded note as they leave class: "My friend has been cutting and made me promise not to tell anyone. I don't know what to do." Debrief as a group. Identify which scenario(s) require counselor contact within the same day, which require private check-in after class, and which require staying present without intervening.

THE FACILITATOR'S OWN MATERIAL (25 MIN)

Name this directly and early: "Some of you will sit in a lesson about shame and recognize a voice you carry. Some of you will read a self-compassion prompt and realize you have never written one to yourself. Some of you will encounter the forgiveness content and feel something shift — or feel something harden. This is your material. It is not a problem. It is actually a sign that you are the right person to teach this curriculum. But you need to know it's there before you stand in front of your class, not while you're standing there."

Facilitator exercise. Ask teachers to journal privately (not shared) for 5 minutes on this prompt: "Which unit or lesson in this curriculum do you anticipate will be hardest for you to deliver — and why?" After journaling, invite (do not require) 2–3 people to share at the level they are comfortable. Normalize that this curriculum surfaces real things. The Teacher Reflection box in each lesson exists for this reason — it is a private processing tool for the teacher, not a record for anyone else.

KEY MESSAGE

You do not need to be fully healed to teach this curriculum. You need to be aware. Awareness of your own material means you will not project it onto your students, rush past the hard parts, or deliver the lesson from behind a wall of professional distance. Presence — genuine, grounded presence — is the pedagogical method of this curriculum. You cannot fake it. You can practice it.

5.2 · BLOCK 3 (30 MINUTES)**BLOCK 3****Disclosure & Distress Protocol Practice**

Facilitator purpose: Teachers need to practice — not just read — the in-the-moment disclosure response. The role-play scenarios below are calibrated to 6–8 developmental reality. They use fictional student names. Do not use names from the curriculum's scenario cards.

THE 6-STEP IN-THE-MOMENT RESPONSE PROTOCOL (10 MIN)

1	Pause and move toward	Stop the lesson. Walk calmly toward the student. Do not draw attention from other students if possible. Give the class independent work: "Keep working in your journal — I'll be right back."
2	Acknowledge without probing	"I can see something is happening for you right now. You don't have to explain it." Do not ask "what's wrong?" — this requires the student to explain while still activated.
3	Offer a choice	"Would you like to step into the hall with me for a minute, or would you like to stay here and just breathe?" Give the student agency. Both choices are valid.
4	Listen and assess	If the student speaks, listen without judgment. Assess: is this a Type 1–3 personal share (emotional but contained) or a Type 4 active safety concern (ongoing harm, suicidal ideation, abuse)? If Type 4: proceed to Step 5 immediately.
5	Connect to counselor (Type 4)	"Thank you for trusting me with this. I want to make sure you have the right support — I'm going to walk you to [counselor's name] right now." Do not promise confidentiality. Do not delay. Contact the counselor immediately.
6	Document and debrief yourself	After class: document what happened in your Teacher Reflection space. Debrief with the counselor or a trusted colleague. You carried something real. Put it down before your next class.

UNIT 4 · LESSON 7 · THE INTERIOR (6–8)

ROLE-PLAY PRACTICE (20 MIN)

Run two scenarios in pairs. One teacher plays the teacher; one plays the student. Debrief after each. Rotate roles. Use only the fictional names below — do not use names from the curriculum scenario cards. The scenarios are calibrated to 6–8 reality.

SCENARIO A · TYPE 2 PERSONAL SHARE (MILD)

During the U2 L4 discussion of accountability without self-punishment, a 7th grader named Jordan says, "My mom always says I should feel bad about disappointing her, and that if I felt bad enough I wouldn't keep messing up. Is that the Internal Critic?" The class goes quiet. **Practice.** How do you validate Jordan's question, honor what they have just disclosed about a family dynamic, use the curriculum's vocabulary correctly without psychologizing the parent, and bring the class back to the lesson? **Debrief.** What did you say first? Did you use the Internal Critic / Compassionate Witness language, or did you stay generic? Did you protect Jordan's parent while validating Jordan's reality?

SCENARIO B · TYPE 4 ACTIVE SAFETY CONCERN (SERIOUS)

An 8th grader named Aanya brings you a journal entry during independent work. It reads: "Sometimes I think about not being here anymore. Not like, doing anything. Just being gone. My friend says I shouldn't think like that but I don't know how to stop." Aanya is watching your face. **Practice.** Walk through the 6-step protocol live. What do you say first to Aanya? How do you address the "not doing anything" qualifier without dismissing it? How do you move her to the counselor without alerting peers? What is your first sentence to the counselor? **Debrief.** Discuss as full group after both scenarios. Note specifically: passive ideation in adolescents ("just being gone") is still an active safety concern. The protocol does not change. **Key takeaway.** Adolescents test whether you are real. They will deliver the most serious content with hedges, qualifiers, and exit-routes built in. Take all of it at face value. The protocol is the same. Your tone — calm, present, not panicked — is what they are calibrating against.

5.2 · BLOCK 4 (45 MINUTES)

BLOCK 4

Live Lesson Model — U2 L1 — The Internal Critic

Facilitator purpose: Teachers need to experience what this curriculum feels like from the student's seat before they deliver it. **Unit 2 Lesson 1** introduces the curriculum's signature middle-school construct — the Internal Critic vs. the Compassionate Witness. It is the most concept-dense lesson in the first half of the year and the clearest demonstration of the curriculum's pedagogical method for adolescents. PPRA-flagged content. Teachers must experience this lesson from the student seat before delivering it.

SETUP (5 MIN)

Announce: "For the next 35 minutes, you are a 7th grader in this classroom. I am going to deliver this lesson to you. After we finish, we will debrief together as teachers. Your job right now is not to evaluate the lesson — it is to be in it. Notice what you feel, what questions arise, and what you want to know that the lesson doesn't answer."

UNIT 4 · LESSON 7 · THE INTERIOR (6–8)

DELIVER U2 L1 IN FULL (35 MIN)

Use the lesson plan from Section 2 (The Lessons) — The Internal Critic of this master document. Deliver at Grade 7 level. Include the inner-voice journaling, the Critic vs. Witness sorting activity, and the exit ticket sentence frames. The Mask vs. The Mirror metaphor from Unit 1 should be referenced as foundation. The facilitator should deliver this with genuine presence — not as a demonstration of “how it’s done” but as an actual lesson. If something lands unexpectedly in the room, stay with it.

DEBRIEF (5 MIN)

Return to teacher mode. Ask three questions:

- What did you notice in yourself during the lesson?
- What questions did the lesson raise for you that you’d want answered before teaching it?
- What moment in the lesson do you think would land hardest for your students — and what would you do?

Take 2–3 responses per question. These responses are the curriculum’s best preparation. Write the unanswered questions on chart paper. Answer them now if you can. If you cannot, acknowledge them honestly: “That’s a real question. Here’s how I’d navigate it.”

5.2 · BLOCK 5 (30 MINUTES)

BLOCK 5

Teacher Reflection as Personal Practice

Facilitator purpose: The Teacher Reflection box is the most important structural element in this curriculum for teacher sustainability. Introduce it as a habit before Day 1, not as an afterthought.

INTRODUCE THE TEACHER REFLECTION BOX (5 MIN)

Every lesson in this curriculum contains a Teacher Reflection prompt. It is not a form to be submitted, a record to be reviewed, or an accountability measure of any kind. It is a private processing tool for you, the teacher, after each lesson. It exists for one reason: this curriculum will do real work in you as you deliver it. If you have nowhere to put that work, it accumulates. Teachers who neglect their own reflection in emotionally demanding curricula burn out faster and deliver less effectively over time. The reflection box is your drain.

Middle school teachers carry the highest disclosure load of any grade band. Adolescents will tell you things they have not told their parents, often without warning, and often with the exit-routes already built in. The Reflection box is not optional in this grade band — it is professional self-care infrastructure.

MODEL A REAL RESPONSE (10 MIN)

The facilitator shares their own Teacher Reflection response — written in advance, from a real experience with this material. Not a polished, professional response. A real one. This is non-negotiable. Teachers cannot be asked to be vulnerable in their reflection practice if the facilitator is not willing to model it. The facilitator should have completed a reflection from Block 4’s live lesson delivery before reading it aloud.

SAMPLE PROMPT

"What did this lesson surface for you personally? What are you still carrying from it?" Read your actual response. Sit with the silence after.

ESTABLISH THE HABIT (15 MIN)

Have each teacher write their first reflection now — from today's PD session.

REFLECTION PROMPT

"What from today do you most need to sit with before your first lesson? What do you already know about yourself that will help you deliver this curriculum? What do you not yet know?"

Allow 10 minutes of private writing. Do not collect. Do not ask for sharing. End with: "This is the habit. It takes 5 minutes after each lesson. It is the most important thing you can do to make sure you can keep delivering this curriculum at the level it deserves."

5.2 · BLOCK 6 (15 MINUTES)**BLOCK 6**

Glossary Orientation & Q&A

Facilitator purpose: Every staff member who interacts with students must use the same vocabulary. Shared language is the infrastructure of this curriculum. This block is short but non-negotiable.

WALK THROUGH THE GLOSSARY (8 MIN)

Distribute the participant one-pager (5.5 at the end of this section). The one-pager contains the twelve most essential vocabulary terms — drawn from Section 4.10 (Curriculum Vocabulary Glossary). Walk through each term: define it, give a classroom example, and if there is a common misuse or confusion, name it.

THREE TERMS THAT REQUIRE SPECIAL ATTENTION AT GRADES 6–8

- "Internal Critic" vs. "Compassionate Witness" — the central construct of the Interior grade band. Every staff member who interacts with these students must be able to name the Critic when they hear it ("that's the Critic talking") and offer the Witness as the alternative voice ("what would the Compassionate Witness say?").
- "Forgiveness" — at middle school, students often confuse forgiveness with reconciliation. The curriculum is explicit: forgiveness is internal, reconciliation is relational, and they are not the same. U3 L3 makes this distinction the lesson.
- "The Digital Backpack" — the metaphor for the cumulative weight of online identity. Middle schoolers often carry digital baggage adults do not see. Equity Alert content. Use the metaphor as offered; do not improvise around it.

OPEN Q&A (7 MIN)

“What questions do you have that we haven’t answered today?” Take as many as time allows. Write unanswered questions on chart paper. Post them publicly. Tell teachers: “If a question came up today that you couldn’t resolve, it will come up in your classroom. That’s not a problem — it’s preparation. You now know to expect it.”

CLOSING WORDS

“You are ready. You don’t have to be perfect. You have to be present. Your students have been waiting for a classroom that holds them this way.”

5.3 Mid-Year Professional Development Session

Facilitator Guide · 90 Minutes · Deliver After Unit 2 Closes (December)

TOTAL TIME	90 minutes (3 blocks · no break required)
AUDIENCE	All classroom teachers delivering Architecture of Grace · The Interior · Grades 6–8. School counselors welcome. Administrators participate as learners.
FACILITATOR	Building principal, instructional coach, or counselor who delivered the initial half-day PD. Read full guide 24 hours in advance.
TIMING	Deliver within 2 weeks of Unit 2 closing (December). Must precede U3 L3.
MATERIALS	Chart paper · markers · teacher journals or index cards · printed participant reference card · timer visible to facilitator
PURPOSE	Debrief implementation, recalibrate the disclosure protocol, surface teacher wellbeing concerns, and prepare teachers emotionally for Unit 3.

TONE-SETTING NOTE

This session is not a compliance check. It is a structural support. Teachers who have spent a full semester carrying emotionally weighted curriculum deserve a room that holds them the way they have been holding their students. Set that tone from the opening.

5.3 · BLOCK 1 (30 MINUTES)**BLOCK 1****Implementation Debrief**

Facilitator purpose: Teachers have been delivering this curriculum for a full semester. Before you give them anything new, let them say what has actually happened.

OPENING (5 MIN)

Ask teachers to write privately for 3 minutes (not shared):

OPENING PROMPT

"Think of one moment from the last semester of delivering this curriculum that stayed with you after class. Not the lesson plan — the moment. What happened? What did you carry home?"

STRUCTURED DEBRIEF (20 MIN)

Post four questions on chart paper. One at a time, 4–5 minutes each. Facilitator listens and captures themes without evaluating.

- What has been working better than you expected? What surprised you about how students responded?
- What has been harder than you expected? What lesson or moment did you feel under-prepared for?
- What questions do you still have that the initial PD didn't answer?
- What are 2–3 students you are still thinking about from Units 1–2?

CAUTION

Do not let the fourth question become a student-deficit conversation. Redirect: "What does this student need from you going into Unit 3?" The question is about teacher action, not student pathology.

CLOSING THE DEBRIEF (5 MIN)

Acknowledge the themes you heard without ranking them. Name anything that needs Block 2: "I heard several of you say disclosures happened differently than expected. We're going to spend the next block on exactly that."

5.3 · BLOCK 2 (35 MINUTES)

BLOCK 2

Disclosure Protocol Recalibration

Facilitator purpose: Teachers have now used the protocol in real conditions. This block connects it to what actually happened and prepares them for Unit 3's harder content.

PROTOCOL REVIEW FROM EXPERIENCE (15 MIN)

Distribute the participant reference card. Ask: "In the last semester, did anyone have a disclosure that required you to use this protocol? Which step was hardest in the moment?"

UNIT 4 · LESSON 7 · THE INTERIOR (6–8)

"I froze."	Normal. Step 1 is all you need: stop and move toward the student. Everything else follows from presence.
"I wasn't sure if it was Type 3 or 4."	When uncertain, treat as Type 4. Let the counselor assess. You are not required to assess accurately under pressure — you are required to act.
"The student said 'I'm fine' but I wasn't sure."	"I'm fine" after a significant disclosure is almost always protective. Follow up privately after class. Brief the counselor.
"Nothing came up for me."	Also valid. Some classrooms generate less activation. Unit 3 will change the frequency.

UNIT 3 PREPARATION — HIGH-RISK LESSONS (15 MIN)

U3 L3 · FORGIVENESS VS. RECONCILIATION

Some students in every classroom are in ongoing unsafe situations. This lesson may be the first time they hear clearly that they do not have to return to harm. Counselor on-site is mandatory. Before delivering U3 L3, identify 2–3 students you are watching. Know who they are before you walk in. U2 L6 — Rewriting the Script (★★ HIGHEST RISK) and U3 L6 — The Agency of Release (★★ HIGHEST RISK) — both require counselor-on-site protocol.

RE-PRACTICE: THE ONE SENTENCE THAT MATTERS (5 MIN)

Have teachers practice this sentence out loud with a partner — twice. It must be automatic under stress.

PRACTICE SENTENCE

"Thank you for trusting me with this. I want to make sure you have the right support — I'm going to walk you to [counselor's name] right now."

5.3 · BLOCK 3 (25 MINUTES)

BLOCK 3

Teacher Wellbeing & Entering Unit 3

Facilitator purpose: This is the most important block. Give teachers permission to care for themselves before Unit 3 begins. Name what the semester has cost them.

THE FACILITATOR'S OWN REFLECTION (10 MIN)

This block begins with the facilitator modeling, not instructing. Read aloud — from your actual Teacher Reflection notes, not a prepared script — something this semester surfaced for you personally in relation to this curriculum.

UNIT 4 · LESSON 7 · THE INTERIOR (6–8)

NON-NEGOTIABLE

If you have not kept Teacher Reflection notes, you must write something genuine before this session. Teachers cannot be asked to be vulnerable if you are delivering this block from behind professional distance.

After your own reflection, give teachers 5 minutes to write privately:

PRIVATE REFLECTION PROMPT

"What has this curriculum surfaced in you personally that you have been carrying? What lesson hit closer to home than you expected? What have you been putting down after class that you haven't named to anyone?"

TEACHER SUPPORT WEB (10 MIN)

Ask teachers to map their own support web on an index card — drawing from the same activity students did in U3 L7 (Limits from Self-Respect).

- Who is on your support web right now?
- Have you actually used it this semester?
- Is there anything you've been carrying that you need to put down before Unit 3?

Before closing: "You taught your students that asking for support is wisdom, not weakness. The same is true for you. Identify one person on your support web you will contact before U3 L3 if you need to."

CLOSING WORDS

"Your students are carrying something from this semester into Unit 3. So are you. That is not a problem — that is what this curriculum does. Go in with your eyes open, your counselor on speed dial, and the knowledge that what you have built in this room over the last five months is already changing things. Unit 3 begins next week. You are ready."

5.4 Facilitator Slide Outline (Half-Day Module)

No design required. These headings translate directly to slides or chart paper. Add your school logo and colors as desired. The slide outline is calibrated to BOOK THREE — The Interior (Grades 6–8).

1	Welcome + Opening Reflection	Opening reflection prompt (see Block 1). Why we're here. What this day is not (a compliance training).
2	Shame vs. Guilt: The Research	Brown (2010), Tangney et al. (2007). Shame = "I am bad." Guilt = "I did bad." Different neural pathways. Different behavioral outcomes. Pair-share.
3	Self-Compassion: Not What You Think	Neff (2011). Three elements. Not self-esteem. Research outcomes. Name the resistance — then address it.
4	Forgiveness Education: The Evidence Base	Enright & Fitzgibbons. What forgiveness is not (reconciliation, condoning, forgetting). What it produces in the research. Why it is teachable.
5	Holding the 6–8 Room: Productive Discomfort vs. Acute Distress	Three 6–8 scenario exercise. What is each? What is your response? Debrief.
6	Your Own Material	Private journal prompt. Optional share. You don't need to be healed. You need to be aware.
7	The 6-Step Disclosure Protocol	Display all 6 steps. Walk through. Do not rush this slide.
8	Role-Play: 6–8 Scenarios	Display scenario text. Pair practice. Full-group debrief. Key distinctions.
9	Live Lesson: U2 L1	The Internal Critic delivered live. Close laptop. Be in the room.
10	Teacher Reflection: Your First Entry	Display the three reflection prompts. 10 minutes private writing. No collection. No share required. This is the habit.
11	Glossary Walk + Q&A	Refer to one-pager. 12 key terms. Special attention to the three identified for Grades 6–8. Open Q&A. Chart unanswered questions.
12	Closing: You Are Ready	"You don't have to be perfect. You have to be present." Distribute one-pager. Send teachers off.

5.5 Participant One-Pager

This single page is the teacher's take-home reference from the PD day. It contains the essential vocabulary and the disclosure protocol in compact form. Print one per teacher (Grades 6–8 edition). Laminate if possible.

12 ESSENTIAL VOCABULARY TERMS

Shame	"I am bad." Self-attack. Hides and harms.
Guilt	"I did something bad." Behavior-focused. Leads to repair.
Internal Critic	The shame voice. Attacks the person, not the behavior.
Compassionate Witness	The kind observer voice. Sees clearly without attacking.
Forgiveness	A gift to yourself. Not reconciliation. Not condoning. Not forgetting.
Grace Gap	Unearned kindness extended across a relational gap. A chosen act, not a reaction.
Self-Compassion	Treating yourself with the care you'd offer a good friend after a mistake.
Oops / Forever	Distinguishing a mistake (Oops) from a permanent identity statement (Forever).
Narrative Identity	The story a person tells about who they are, built from their experiences.
Charitable Interpretation	Choosing the most generous explanation for another's behavior.
Productive Discomfort	The learning edge. Sitting with a hard truth. Do not rescue students from it.
Community Charter	The class's year-end public commitment to grace practices. The culminating artifact.

IN-THE-MOMENT DISCLOSURE PROTOCOL (6 STEPS)

1. Pause. Move toward the student. Give class independent work.
2. "I can see something is happening. You don't have to explain it."
3. Offer a choice: hall or stay and breathe. Both are valid.
4. Listen. Assess: Type 1–3 (contained) or Type 4 (safety concern)?
5. Type 4: "Thank you for trusting me. I'm walking you to [counselor] now." Do not promise confidentiality. Do not delay.
6. Document. Debrief with counselor or colleague. Put it down before your next class.

TEACHER REFLECTION HABIT

After every lesson: 5 minutes. Private. Not collected. Answer one of: What surfaced for me today? What did I want to rush past — and why? What do I want to carry forward?

CLOSING WORDS

"You don't need to be perfectly healed to teach this curriculum. You need to be present and aware. Your students have been waiting for a classroom that holds them this way." **Architecture of Grace · The Interior · School of Life Foundation · James Anthony Ramsden**

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